

Phil 311 The Philosophy of History

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 311 • Dr. Daniel Bonevac

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Lecture 1: What is History?

At a glance — Bonevac opens an eight-part series asking what history is.

- 1.1 Welcome to lecture one of an eight-part lecture series entitled Philosophy of History. What is history? Is it something that just gathers dust in the past, in museums, in books? It's very hard to defend that idea these days. History is at the heart of so many different explosive political debates—how we narrate the past, which bits of the past we take to be paradigmatic or illustrative of our present conditions. So the history wars are more intense, have been fought more intensely over the last 15 to 20 years than at almost any other point in modern history.
- 1.2 And so this prompts the question, what are we talking about when we're talking about history? What is it? Who gets to speak it authoritatively? There's, of course, a whole new media ecosystem opening up now, with people with no formal education saying, "Actually, I think this is a theory that's never been tried, and this actually makes much better sense of our history," with professional historians trying to correct them or saying that they're wrong or they haven't got the right degrees or qualifications, to their 6.5 followers on YouTube versus the new kid's 3.4 million followers on YouTube, holding forth as an armchair historian of the Second World War.
- 1.3 History is always with us, and the relationship of the past to the present is one that will be a recurring theme of this lecture. The past is changing as much as the present, in terms of the past that we select from and use to shape our understanding of who we are, what we're for, what kind of society we should be aiming for, and so on and so forth.
- 1.4 It turns out, helpfully, that people have been doing history for a very long time. The first historian, as we'll see and we'll discuss in some detail, is normally said to be Herodotus. Herodotus of Halicarnassus. Halicarnassus is modern-day Bodrum, in the southwest corner of Turkey. We'll talk about him in more detail.
- 1.5 But our word "history" comes from the opening sentence of the work that we now give simply the label Histories, Herodotus' Histories, because it starts, as we'll see, with the words "apodexis historias." This is an "apodexis." This is a demonstration or a write-up. This is my report, "historias," of my "historie," my inquiry, my inquiry into the past, and why certain cities have gone from small to great, and others have gone from great to small, and I look for the patterns and collect, listen to what everybody tells me, try to gather the evidence.
- 1.6 This is the first time somebody is thinking, or at least writing, in terms of a grand narrative sweep. History is more than just a chronicle, more than just a shopping list of events that are happening, that happened in sequence, as you tend to get in the ancient Near East attempts—the civilizations of Mesopotamia, of Egypt, the Hittites, the Assyrians. It's very dull, what counts as history for them. "I fought 23 battles. I won

all of them. I put to death X number of people." It's very bland. There's no attempt to impose any meaning or interpretation. There's occasional reference to the gods, and the gods definitely being on my side all the time, but it's not very granular. It's nothing like the detail or care that Herodotus gives it.

- 1.7 It so happens that Herodotus is followed very quickly by, arguably, a co-founding father of history as a discipline, which is Thucydides. Thucydides of Athens. We'll talk a lot about Thucydides in due course and, indeed, all over the course. Thucydides does something very, very different, almost as if he's—most scholars agree that he's consciously distancing himself, differentiating himself, from Herodotus' more happy-go-lucky, pick up reports from these priests, pick up reports from these nomads, stitch them all together, just say, "Well, this is what I heard," and then weaving it together in these grand, almost theological narratives about the Persians overreaching themselves and provoking the envy of the gods, and the gods strike back, and so on and so forth.
- 1.8 Whereas Thucydides is much, much, much drier, much more dispassionate, much more rigorous, much more cerebral, much more focused on psychology, personal psychology, much more interested in questions of economics and resources, military power, a capacity for military strategy. Underpinning Thucydides still is this extraordinary moral framework: horror of war. Some of the most extraordinary passages condemning the folly of war, particularly civil war, come from the pages of Thucydides. There is a sort of moral earnestness. It's not completely dispassionate in that sense, but it's a very, very different style from Herodotus, who, if you read him today, you might say, actually, it's more like anthropology than history.
- 1.9 There's an entire book, I think it's nine books, the Histories. The whole of Book 2 is devoted to the Egyptians. The Egyptians don't feature in any way in the climactic Persian Wars, the wars between Persia and Greece. The Egyptians are not involved at all, but he devotes an entire book to "my holidays in Egypt" and "this is what the priests told me." It's a fascinating resource for understanding Egypt and that civilization at that point. Almost his gullibility or his credulity has been a huge win for ancient historians because he puts it all down and doesn't test it too much. He just says, "This is just what I've heard. That seems plausible to me. That doesn't, but this is what I heard," and so on.
- 1.10 Thucydides is much, much more focused, much more narrowly focused, on politics, on diplomacy, on military strategy, resources, yes, charismatic figures, and what makes societies tick, and the horrors that a supposedly civilized society can go to to achieve its end, when it sees itself as having a particular agency or role within the unfolding of history.
- 1.11 What are we doing in this course? Well, the first question, really, the only question that we're looking at, is: What is history? Once we've understood what is history, I think all the other questions will flow from that. A lot of answers, hopefully, will flow from the answer to that great question. Once we, I think, understand what history is, we'll come

to understand why it's so important, why we do it, why it's something that is a vital influence on us from the past, an instructive influence. It's a very powerful way of modeling good, as it were, values that we can aspire to, and also vices we want to ignore.

- 1.12 So, what is history? We'll be looking at different perspectives on that big question. Are there patterns to history? Does history repeat itself? If it doesn't, does it rhyme? Are there certain patterns that we can see at a micro level? Are there larger patterns that we could think of within the religious dimension? We'll be thinking in terms of providence, as end times. The story ends in a particular way; it begins in a particular way.
- 1.13 History is invested in almost, certainly, the three Abrahamic monotheistic religions. History is invested with a purpose, with meaning, and it has the superintending presence of God as the source of all reality and the source of all history who stands outside history.
- 1.14 Of course, those grand trajectories are less fashionable today, but they're still present, but I think in more camouflaged ways. So contemporary historians are just as shaped by earlier historians, by a particular vision of the good society, a particular conception of international relations, very often, the authority of international law, and so on and so forth; versus more of pro-nation historiography, which is what characterizes many of the historians of the 18th and 19th century, particularly in France and Germany. To write the history of your nation is itself, is to be a kind of pro-nation; celebrating your nation is to put yourself on one particular end of the spectrum. In more contemporary historians, you'll see an interest in global history, history that transcends the sort of national boundaries and imperial boundaries and so on.
- 1.15 The discipline of history itself is constantly evolving. We can ask: Why does it matter? Why does it matter how we understand history? Well, obviously, we can answer that question in quite a straightforward way by saying: What does my past mean to me and your past mean to you? I mean, in a way, everything. My entire present is what it is in virtue of the past that I've had. And once you move that up a bit to villages or communities, to cities, to maybe nations, you can still see it's obviously in a much weaker sense than from your own subject or your own family folklore, which is itself a very important part of how families think about themselves across time and honor each other.
- 1.16 This is a very different way of thinking, to be clear, but it's still—you can see how important history would be to a community, to a collective. It can hold up signs of— it's a very powerful way of signaling, that is not signaling that comes from the state or any kind of coercive force, but it's just sitting there in the culture. This is the kind of people we used to be. This is the kind of people we could be. This is how far we've fallen short in the past. This is what we should avoid doing again, etc.

- 1.17** History plays a huge role in shaping the moral universe, the moral architecture, you might say, in writing the moral grammar of a community, of a large community, of a nation. You might even say more than a nation; you might say a civilization. India, China, Russia—these are countries that are not quite countries; they're not quitenation-states; they're more than just nations, or at least they think of themselves as civilizational presences in the world. That's part of the history that they tell of themselves, underwrites that, that self-conception of themselves as something more than just a nation.
- 1.18** So, these are the sort of questions we're going to be considering. We'll be looking at different perspectives, different ways of answering these broad questions. But one problem that's worth putting on the table goes back to the great German critic, philosopher, Gotthold Lessing. He's a figure who emerges at the peak of the German Enlightenment. We're talking 1770s, 1780s, in Prussia. This is when people like Immanuel Kant are around. Hegel is born in 1770. This is really where the Germans are getting their go at philosophy. This is the end of the 18th century.
- 1.19** Lessing has this fascinating line that goes something like, "The accidental truths of history can never provide the basis or the proof, the Beweis, of necessary truths of reason." Accidental truths of history can never become the bedrock for necessary truths of reason. Very interesting claim. What's he saying there? He's saying that historical knowledge and, say, necessary knowledge—so something like mathematics, something solid and necessary, a necessary truth of reason, like $2 + 2 = 4$ —versus historical knowledge.
- 1.20** Those two, says Lessing, are completely different kinds of thing. There can't be any traffic between them. It can't be that history can ever give us that gold-standard knowledge that necessary truth by reason can do— the armchair reason, the reason that we can use, and the truths we can find out without getting up out of the armchair, just staying where we are, just thinking. How could that kind of thinking have anything to do with historical knowledge, which is, by definition, only knowledge you can establish by getting up out of the armchair and collect the sources and talk to the eyewitness and so on? It's two different kinds of knowledge, says Lessing.
- 1.21** He says, between these two kinds of truths, these two categories of truths, "an ugly broad ditch" has opened up, "which I cannot get across, however often and however earnestly I have tried to make the leap." I won't inflict the German on you. So there's this big ugly ditch, says Lessing, between the knowledge that we can get from history, even from the very best historians, and the bedrock, solid knowledge that we can get from necessary truths of reason—logic, mathematics, geometry, and so on and so forth.
- 1.22** In many ways, this goes right to the heart of the question and the challenge to the question of: What is history? What knowledge are we getting from it? Is it a science? In some ways, it is. Is it a humanity? Yes, it's the study of humanity, largely, so it surely

owns its place as a humanity. When it was first proposed for introduction as a degree course at Oxford in the mid-19th century, there was a lot of resistance. Modern history was not seen to be something that a gentleman should study, maybe take part in and influence.

- 1.23** The history that had to be done was the history of Greece, the history of Rome, the history of—because it's history as moral instruction. Look at the empires they built. We're building an empire, too. Let's read the histories of the civilizations that became successful empire-builders, as we're trying to build an even bigger one. And so, it took a while to be accepted, indeed, as an academic discipline. It's not until, really, the end of the 19th century that you've got something like the modern guild of academic professional historians has really begun to open up, and all the infrastructure around it didn't really begin to develop until the early 20th century.
- 1.24** This is the great challenge that Lessing proposes, that our historical knowledge is always going to be a little uncertain. It's always going to fall short of these bedrock gold-plated truth claims. We can know that $2 + 2 = 4$ with absolute certainty. What time did Caesar cross the Rubicon in 49 BC? Exactly what time of day was it? Were you sure it was that date? Who is the nearest historian to it? It's contingent. It happened once, if it happened at all. It's particular. There's nothing that our reason can help us, really, get to in terms of getting a more accurate, making that hopefully-true claim even truer or more solidly true.
- 1.25** This is the puzzle. This is what the historian has to learn to be satisfied with, uncertainties and speculative conclusions. That will vary depending on what period in the past you're focusing on. One of the fascinating features of ancient history, why I love ancient history so much, is because the evidence is incredibly scarce. That's a challenge to the ancient historian, but it's also an extraordinary stimulus for his imagination.
- 1.26** You've got a couple of temples, a few pots, a passing mention in Pausanias' history of Greece, but it's 200 years later. Pausanias didn't like those guys. It could have been, you know, and that's all you've got. It's all you know of this particular sub-tribe near Carthage in the first century BC. You've got to piece everything together. There's a lot more detective work involved. Whereas the modern historian, there's an avalanche of information. It's just too much information. The challenge for a contemporary historian is how to navigate all the evidence and how to organize it and how to spot, in the haystack, the magic hook that will make sense of everything else. But either way, the challenges on the historian are such that we know that historical knowledge is not going to have that bedrock certainty. Ordinarily, that doesn't trouble us, and perhaps probably shouldn't trouble us.
- 1.27** History is obviously not a science, in the sense that you might say science studies the repeatable, what can be repeated; and indeed, the more it can be repeated and the more the same pattern of behavior obtains, the truer, the better supported a scientific

statement becomes. It's about testability, repeatability. History studies the one-off, the particular. It's in the past. It will never happen again in quite the same way. Even if you do think that history is cyclical and repeats itself almost exactly, it's not going to happen in quite that way. It's a one-off, and you can't test it. There's no repeatability here. It's a fundamentally different posture of human inquiry. It's a different way of thinking about reality and how we should understand it.

- 1.28 The classic view, when people first started thinking about what history was, or what its purpose, particularly, might be in the contemporary context, and more than just doing, as Thomas Hobbes did, for example, an entire translation of Thucydides, or Machiavelli in his *Discorsi*, his *Discourses* on Livy. He's just studying Livy's history of the Roman Republic as it emerges and as it builds up its empire and its strength all around the western half of the Mediterranean, and those histories are distinctive. All that characterized doing history up until the end of the 18th century really was studying the past as Machiavelli studied Livy to get lessons for the present.
- 1.29 It's in the 19th century that we first really start getting—or I should say the 18th century— that we start getting an explosion of interest in histories of different nations, histories of different tribes and cultures and peoples. Think of David Hume. What rescued David Hume, the great Scottish philosopher, from poverty was him knuckling down, locking himself in an attic, and writing a many, many-volumed history of England that sold incredibly well and allowed him to begin to live the life of leisure he'd always dreamed of and write his philosophy.
- 1.30 This beginning, it's part of the Enlightenment, you can say, the emergence of history as a discipline. The writing of history is something that you could say is a distinctive feature, particularly of the Scottish Enlightenment. I'm thinking not just of David Hume, but also of Adam Smith, to some extent. There's a lot of historical work in his *Wealth of Nations*.
- 1.31 But Edward Gibbon is probably, obviously, the greatest historian of the Scottish Enlightenment, and his *Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire* is this very self-consciously, not modern exactly, but it's self-consciously, you might say, post-Christian or self-consciously secular in the way it describes history unfolding, and the temper that he shows towards the influence of Christianity in the *Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*. It shows that there's a secular self-confidence coming through in the writing of history.
- 1.32 The key figure here, the first person to really start saying, "What are we trying to do when we're doing history?", was von Ranke, R-A-N-K-E, Leopold von Ranke, 1795 to 1886. Pretty long life over a fascinating period in the evolution of the German university — of course, the German Protestant university—that came to dominate.
- 1.33 Alexander von Humboldt: inspiration in philosophy that everything should be studied, there should be research faculties everywhere. It should be less like the medieval

structure of the university, where you just have lots of quasi-autonomous colleges dotted around. You actually have an institution that is much more unified, has a much more unified structure, and takes research at least as seriously as teaching. So, the idea that—the seminar is born in the German university, for example, in the 19th century. The idea of having a PhD is something that emerges from this period.

- 1.34** So history was—von Ranke argues that, really, what we're trying to do when we're doing history is to do roughly what the scientist is doing: recording what's happened. Just recording the past. We have got access to it. It's not always perfect, but it's broadly reliable. His famous phrase is, "Wie es eigentlich gewesen." The point of the historian is to get to how things really, eigentlich, were. Gewesen, to show how it actually was. That's the job of the historian. History, in other words—this is maybe a little bit crude, but I think it's fair—can be objective like a science. It can be a science, is Ranke's very bold claim.
- 1.35** He says that you can. There are protocols we can establish as historians. There are procedures we can agree to follow. There are criteria for success in some historical explanation that we can agree on. There are criteria for failure of a particular historical explanation that we can broadly converge on, even if we will disagree about the details. This is how a scientific body would come together and organize itself in its quest for the truth, the truths about the objects of its inquiry.
- 1.36** So Ranke sets to work on what these criteria should be, or what protocols, what sort of methods should the historian use that are analogous to those that the scientist uses: check your sources, rigorous source criticism, criteria for what counts as a good source and a bad source, how you distinguish between primary and secondary and tertiary sources, in terms of eyewitness, more distant, etc. Can we get all the events in the right order? Do all the different accounts make sense of each other? If they don't, can we explain why and which one has got it wrong?
- 1.37** Is this a science? Well, you're discovering truths with methods about reality. Is the person exploring the Cambrian explosion, which is very relevant to how we understand, make sense of the history of evolution and evolutionary theory, the fossil-hunter looking for evidence for his claims, claims that he's making about a past that is way more distant than a few hundred years ago, how is it different? How are those two exercises? One is a science, one's evolutionary science, and the other is not a science at all, just a humanity, like writing poetry or something.
- 1.38** So, Ranke does make a good case. It gets unfairly caricatured, but you can see what he's trying to do. He says, "We have standards, too. We can have standards, too." And if you don't like them, we have others—no, he didn't say that. I think that was Ava Gardner. But he thought he could do it. He said that there are ways we could, standards that we can agree on, and then abide by, and we can start the great research tradition of the German university in the historical sciences.

- 1.39 So that's been, still is quite a very influential way of thinking about history. But it's—in many ways, even those who disagreed with it, implicitly use the methods, or descendants of the methods, that Ranke was urging in support of a scientific view of history, of something that is reliable, that can gather the facts and make sense of them, in as plausible a way as a science does. His influence has extended even into his critics, just by using the most basic tools of historical inquiry. Whatever your actual philosophy of history might be, it was an extremely influential one.
- 1.40 After Ranke, we encounter this very interesting distinction in German thought between the Naturwissenschaften and the Geisteswissenschaften. So Wissenschaft is the German word for knowledge, wissen, to know. Wissenschaft is the noun. And within, as the German university begins to develop, you start to have all these difficult dialogues as to what counts as a discipline and how you divide them up and what the architecture of knowledge and research within the university should be.
- 1.41 And quickly, it emerges that there's something distinctive, it seems, about the natural sciences, which is distinct from the human sciences, the Geisteswissenschaften, the human-spirited sciences, as it were, the sciences that are invested with human meaning and subjectivity and so on and so forth. The question then is, which side of that fence is history going to fall down? Which side of the fence does it belong on? Does it belong— where should it be placed?
- 1.42 The challenge, of course, is that, yes, you might accept Ranke's claim that it can be, history is a guild, can be a scientific guild just like any other. There is also a dimension to history and to historical knowledge and to historical understanding that involves understanding the actions and the decisions and the motivations of other human beings in a way that no other science, in a way that science is simply blind to. No scientific conclusions can make appeal to, or base their claims on, what a particular person feels about the world, or can invoke any kind of human agency or human explanation in how black holes got formed or whatever it might be.
- 1.43 These are completely different explanations when persons are involved, when subjects are involved. And a field of human inquiry that defines itself by reference to studying just objects is not going to be able to make any sense of a body of knowledge that includes subjects, people who are unpredictable, do crazy things, or sometimes do very smart things, and you can trace the patterns. But the patterns you're tracing are patterns you're tracing as a human being. You're not just wanting to reduce everything to the sciences, to scientific statements. Science is blind to almost all the considerations that the historians have to be especially sensitive to.
- 1.44 And so, this split emerges. It's basically a friendly split, but a moment in the development of the self-organization of the modern university, because the German model would come to have enormous influence elsewhere in the world, in particular the United States. You have this distinction between the natural sciences. The job of the natural sciences is to explain, "erklären," to chart the different laws that would be

relevant to any scientific explanation, questions that natural sciences help us to predict, to control things, to produce things.

- 1.45** Whereas the human sciences are not trying to explain, "erklären." They're trying to understand, "verstehen." And understanding is different from, you might say, ordinary knowing, scientific knowing. Understanding is, you're understanding the motivations and the psychological patterns that explain human behavior and human interaction and the human perspective on reality.
- 1.46** It turns out you can't explain human behavior by just predicting in a way that—you can't collect evidence of past human behavior and then perfectly project it forward in a way that a scientist will be able to do, if his hypothesis is true, is the correct one. It will predict. But perfectly accurate historical analysis of the situation is not going to help us. It's not resting on it being true about some future state. It can't stick its neck out in quite the same way as a scientific theory can.
- 1.47** This split opens up, and history gets caught up in that. How do we understand history? What pressure does this put on Ranke's view that history should be conducted as if it were a science? Wilhelm Dilthey, who is an important figure in this development, and really is responsible for charting this or articulating the importance of this distinction between merely knowing and understanding, between objective knowledge and then a more, you might say, a more sympathetic knowledge.
- 1.48** He says that doing history should be much more like interpreting a book or reading a letter that somebody's written to you. The dimension of sympathy, of being able to share the same kind of psychology and the same basic understandings of other human beings in the past, however different their context might have been, it is possible for us to imagine that we were Caesar at the Rubicon. It's possible for us to imagine: What would it be like if I'd been sitting on that horse, looking at that little trickle, thinking, "Should I do this? Should I do that?" It's possible to do that, because as distant and maybe as mighty or awful as he was, Caesar was a human being.
- 1.49** There's a very basic level, but a vital level, at which we can understand the historical actors of the past, even if we can't understand everything. We are that kind of being. It's not completely closed off to us. And so, Dilthey says we should apply our interpretive capacities when we're thinking about history, when we're reasoning about history. We should interpret it, just as there are good interpretations in literary criticism and bad interpretations in film criticism, we can have criteria for what counts as a really good interpretation of this period of history. This makes sense of most of the different actors and what happened and so on and so forth, and its consequences.
- 1.50** For Dilthey, this would be more like writing a novel than doing a science, than writing up a scientific experiment, because there'll be moments of inspiration as you're writing this history and you're trying to get into the minds of this person and that person, and there'll be little breakthroughs. The process will feel probably more like the writing of a

novel than chewing your pencil, trying to crack Fermat's last theorem, or running around the lab trying to see if the results that you get are consistent with the hypothesis that you put forward. What we're witnessing is a shift back and forth between history as a science and history as something that's not—a humanity, you might say.

- 1.51** This founds an important school, actually, in British historiography in the 20th century. When I use the word historiography, by the way, that's the word that's used when we're talking about the writing of history, graphi-historia. Historiography is, as it were, a division within history; it's a kind of philosophy of history, you might say, but it's thinking about history, and it's writing about history, what we're doing when we're doing history, historiography.
- 1.52** The figure I'm thinking of here is the great R. G. Collingwood, who's not particularly well known, sadly, these days, but wrote a wonderful book called *The Idea of History*, 1946, which pushed this idea of Dilthey even further. He says, "All history is the history of human thought." All history is the history of thought. That's actually all it is. In many ways, this is the polar opposite of what we'll see to be Karl Marx's view of how history works. For him, thought is actually downstream of almost everything else. For him, it's not thought, it's material processes, material resources, scarcity in material resources, plenty in material resources, and very dismissive of what philosophers can do, and certainly skeptical of how they might understand the past.
- 1.53** Collingwood's view is, effectively, we've got to—when we're trying to do, let's say, a history of Caesar and what he was thinking in 49 BC, we've got to try to think Caesar's thoughts after him. That's the idea. We've got to try to get inside Caesar's mind and remind ourselves of where he's just been, who he's up against, what he's feeling, the size of his army, what his army wants. Collingwood says you can actually build up a really, pretty plausible picture of what it might have been like, that then helps you explain and understand why he did what he did, why he went with it, decided to do it in the end. Does it make sense of other bits of Caesar's life, before he was executed in 44 BC?
- 1.54** All of these questions can be fed into an interpretation that you can recognize as good or bad or mediocre in terms of how much evidence it uses, how much light it sheds on what needs to be understood. When you're thinking about why Caesar might have done it, you'll be thinking about, you've got to know about the republican constitution and the worries about a king coming in or a dictator, particularly, coming in. You've got to understand that.
- 1.55** You've also got to understand the relationship that Caesar had with his armies. You've also got to think about the amount of land that he would have had to find for his veterans. This was a huge source of contention in the republican period. As the army gets bigger, the rewards for the veterans get bigger, the bill gets much, much bigger. And so, vast tracks of Italy were effectively conscripted and given by powerful generals

to veterans. So, all of these factors you would have in mind as you're attempting an imaginative reconstruction and interpretation of why Caesar acted the way he did.

- 1.56** There's another way of thinking about history that is a lot more radical than either of these. Both are the ones we've seen up until now. Ranke, you might say, is the realist. This is a historian who wants to be a scientist. But also Dilthey and Collingwood don't fundamentally deny that what we're doing when we're studying history and writing about history, forming historical judgments, we are describing reality out there. It's not just what we would like it to be. It's not just us holding forth. We're trying to discover.
- 1.57** This third view is more skeptical about that. Benedetto Croce, one of two very great Italian historiographers, the other one being Giambattista Vico, who was sort of king of the Neapolitan Enlightenment, what Croce argues—Croce is much later, of course, the 19th century to mid-20th century—Croce's view is that history is always folded into our present. And the history we do, the reason we do it is just to be answered solely in the terms of now, on the particular present that we find ourselves in.
- 1.58** We're very pragmatic creatures. We encounter problems as all human beings do in the world. There are examples of the problems being handled in different ways in the past, but we'll take what we need to achieve the ends of now. All history is contemporary history. That's the idea. All history is contemporary history, even if we go far, far back. There's more to this than you might think. We have, for example, from the ancient world, a lot of evidence that history is primarily something that has a moral purpose. It's edifying.
- 1.59** Famously, Plutarch, who lived around about the first century AD, famously wrote about 40 lives, lives of great men, lives of great men. He did Roman lives, and he did Greek lives, then he would pair them together. You'd have Alexander with Caesar, and there'd be these interesting—they weren't all great guys, all good guys, but they were short "bioi," biography, lives. For many, many centuries, Plutarch's lives were textbooks.
- 1.60** That's pretty much all the history that little Roman boys did, or boys all around the empire. It's, "These are these great lives and be like them, don't be like him," et cetera. They were all historical figures, some of them quite obscure. The point there is not, did Plutarch get his account of the life of Themistocles exactly correct, given what we now know? What did they think they were doing when they were teaching Plutarch as history? That would have been totally to miss the point.
- 1.61** Plutarch is not a bad historian. There's no reason to doubt that much of what he says about the different lives. He was certainly there within two or three, four centuries of the people he was writing about, with access to significant resources. But he has a particular purpose. It is to celebrate or maybe criticize these different figures. So there is a moralizing function here, which suited the purposes of Rome at that point.
- 1.62** Croce says this, really, all history is like this. If you've ever known, I've certainly experienced this many times, walking into a bookshop and seeing the front table or

several tables dominated by books on a theme that would have been unintelligible to somebody three years ago. But suddenly it's come up as a huge issue, and so there's little histories and biographies of key players, and then this whole phenomenon emerges.

- 1.63 So it's true that history is more and more shaped—I think it's not implausible to say—history is more and more shaped by—certainly has always been shaped—by the demands of the present, the self-understanding of the present.
- 1.64 You think of the battles in the United States—when was this? I think about the early 2020s, between those who were pushing for 1619 as the founding date of the United States and those who pushed or reiterated the push for 1776 as the founding date. It's a very interesting question. When do we begin? When does "we" begin? When can we first use the first person plural? We'll see later on, we'll see in a later lecture how important that choosing year zero is; in fact, I think we might be discussing it shortly. These contestations matter, and the way we select, the way we narrate history is going to always be sensitive to our contemporary concerns.
- 1.65 It's worth pointing out, just as we come in to land, what the terrain ahead is going to look like. We've done some scene-setting in this first lecture. We're going to be moving in the next lecture to look at the birth of history in somebody I've already mentioned, in the work of somebody I've already mentioned, Herodotus of Halicarnassus. We're going to look at his achievements and the impact that that had, that his history had, on the formation of a sense of Hellenic identity, of being Greek, of being part of a Greek civilization.
- 1.66 We'll look, of course, at Thucydides, as well, his great successor who comes after him. We'll look at Polybius, a very interesting Greek-writing historian, but charting the rise of Rome at the beginning of the third century BC and the first great conflicts with Carthage—the great Polybius, who also has some very interesting ideas about whether history has a pattern and the cyclicity that he thinks that history shows when it comes to thinking about constitutions and political societies.
- 1.67 We'll be looking at some Roman historians as well, some brilliant Roman historians, of course. There's Livy, there's Tacitus, there's Sallust. But it's probably fair to say, they don't belong on quite the same level as Herodotus and Thucydides because they're not inventing history, for a start. Herodotus invented it. I mean, he's the first person, that's the first work we can say. It's the first work that the word "history" has ever applied to.
- 1.68 And Thucydides, too, almost reinvents it immediately into something that focuses more on questions of strategy and diplomacy and economy and material resources and plague dynamics and epidemiology and those— it's a different mode of history, you might say, but supplements something that maybe Herodotus had missed. But the Roman historians aren't innovative in quite that way, as brilliant as they are in observing the past and observing their own societies.

- 1.69** Then we'll move on to consider the emergence of, certainly, doctrines of providence, that is to say, more theologically inflected ideas of how history develops, which invoke often an end state, or an eschatology, a study of the end times, a protology, so a study of how it all began and why, and why things now are like what they are because of what had happened before and so on and so forth—a very, very different way of thinking about history, from Herodotus and Thucydides and the Roman historians.
- 1.70** It's true to say we'll see throughout the first half of this series, this tension, for the most part, between a Hebraic philosophy of history, just broadly speaking, a linear one, and a Hellenic philosophy of history, which is, broadly speaking, a more chaotic and cyclical one. That's something that will emerge; we'll come back to discuss quite frequently.
- 1.71** It's worth noting also that there's writing of history that is, you might say, not so much critical, just trying to get at what actually happened or try to get to the best interpretation of what happened, but more speculative in the sense of, can we do mega history? Can we do a history of Indian civilization from 3,000 BC to the present? Can we see patterns in history that are vaster than any history of a particular country or a particular battle would ever give me?
- 1.72** Actually, in recent years, I'd say in the last maybe 15, 20 years, a discipline has emerged called cliodynamics. Cliodynamics. Why clio? Because Clio is one of the nine muses, and specifically, she's the muse of history. Clio is a classicist's way of a metonym for history. Cliodynamics is this science; is it a science? They claim it's a science. That old argument is resurfacing.
- 1.73** But those who champion somebody like Peter Turchin, who is focused on this study of cliodynamics, says no, we can actually predict quite reliably what's going to happen in the future, because we've looked at all these different patterns. We've got so much more information than previous historians had. We can get so much more data in. We can make much more reliable predictions about what's going to happen, and we can start to see how all these patterns fit together. This is something that's pretty new. He's got his critics, very fierce critics, but he's also got significant support.
- 1.74** So, in a way, that approach is one that confirms, in many ways, Benedetto Croce's claim that we're using history for our own ends. We want to study this particular phenomenon in the past because we're worried about drone warfare with that country over there. Let's see what we can do, what we can project forward.
- 1.75** I've mentioned already that that distinction emerging between the Hellenic and the Hebraic, that is to say, between the more cyclical, the messier way of understanding history, let's say at least more arbitrary, history evolves in much more arbitrary ways, to the more linear, theologically inflected, God in the beginning, God in the end, and human progress through creation, fall, captivity, exodus, liberation, captivity again, liberation again, and so on and so forth. It's a theological narrative. The history is a

history of not just the early Israelites, but the relationship between God and the early Israelites.

1.76 There'll be other tensions, too. We've already seen this tension between objectivity and interpretation. Objectivity with Ranke, as the history-as-a-science approach, versus Dilthey and Collingwood saying, no, we're always interpreting. If we're interpreting the behavior of others as human behavior, we're not giving a scientific account of what's happening; that would be inconceivably dull, for a start. But we're simply trying to communicate in a way that, at the level of personal human understanding, doesn't have to compete with the level of scientific, molecular brain-state explanation. These are two distinct and non-competing ways of explaining the world.

1.77 So, in the next lecture, we'll dive into more detail to help understand the cradle of history—how it began, how it emerged, and what was driving it, and what its implications are for the way we think about history today.

Lecture 2: The History of History

At a glance — The history of history.

- 2.1 Welcome to the second lecture in this eight-part series, Philosophy of History. In the first lecture, we looked at some of the grand questions that philosophy of history asks. What is history? Why does history turn out the way it turns out? What clues can we get about the future or for our present about studying history, from studying history better and understanding history better?
- 2.2 We looked at different ways of thinking of history, different ways of treating it. Should it be a science? Should it be a humanity? How much confidence can we put in getting objective facts that we don't—or how much confidence should we put in interpreting and forging a convincing account, human account, of what's happened in the past, as opposed to just a dry chronicle of events, dispassionately and objectively described?
- 2.3 We looked also at Benedetto Croce's view that, actually, all history serves the present. It serves some purpose in the present, whether it's to shore up a sense of national collective self-identity or to harness a people in facing some terrible existential threat. In wartime, most obviously, that's when history, myth-making, storytelling, a sense of a narrative that encompasses a whole nation, a whole people, becomes very, very important.
- 2.4 In this lecture, I want us to look at the origins of history, the origins of historical writing, and to see what we can learn about history from the way in which its first practitioners worked, and indeed how its first practitioners understood what they were doing as historians. There are all sorts of ways of understanding these early historians. Even before the first historian, we have a figure like Homer. The debate over whether or not the Trojan War really happened is still burning strong, but it is clear that the Homeric narratives have some basis in history.
- 2.5 There's an emerging consensus that, yes, there was a city that bore the name Ilion or Ilium, roughly, almost exactly where Homer puts it, very close to Istanbul today, up by the Dardanelles. We've done a lot of archeological work on that site, and it's scholars think that Troy VIb is in fact the city that met some cataclysm, some terrible fire, possibly a siege in the first, say, first quarter, first half, of the 12th century BC.
- 2.6 And it's consistent with a lot of other bits of evidence that we've managed to put together, particularly from Hittite tablets, tablets left by the Hittites, deciphering something called Linear B. Brilliant Englishman deciphered this ancient script, Linear B, which has helped shed more light on this late Mycenaean world that seems to be what's driving the memories of Homer and the people who worked within the Homeric tradition. But it's not quite history, nor is it trying to be history. There's clearly a kernel of history there, but it doesn't understand itself as history.

- 2.7** There's a figure who emerges almost immediately after Homer, who's sadly neglected because he's a wonderful, he's a very grumpy poet, but he's a farmer and always trying to till land that doesn't produce much in the way of a crop. The gods are always mean to him. The weather's always terrible. Everything's very bleak. Then there's this famous passage—this is from his work, *Works and Days*; *Works and Days* is what it's called—*"Hemera kai erga."* At one point, he says that we're living in the worst age. There was once an age of gold, then there was an age of silver, silver-hearted men, then the age of bronze, and finally, the age of iron. We're in the age of iron, and it's bleak. But that's the way time and history unfolds, from the best to the worst.
- 2.8** Now, is this history? Well, it's a theory about time. It's a theory about the direction that history is heading in, down, relentlessly down. It's a story about the past and the past getting increasingly worse, and then projecting forward because the future must resemble the past. It's declinism. It's the opposite of utopianism—declinism or dystopianism. It's all going to get a lot worse. So, there are these figures who are emerging before history really gets going in the fifth century BC, who are thinking in interesting ways about time and about history.
- 2.9** There are other figures who are emerging round about this time on the west coast of Asia Minor, modern-day Turkey, who are not quite historians, but they are beginning to write chronicles, one-off descriptions of particular events, something like a chronicle. Unfortunately, we've only got them in fragments, but there's something about that people are trying to begin to make sense of what's happened in the past.
- 2.10** If you think, also, another example would be the performance of a play by the first of the great three Greek dramatists, Aeschylus. Aeschylus is extraordinary. Aeschylus fights in the Battle of Marathon in 490 with that extraordinary defeat by the Athenians of the combined forces of Persia, and held them off for another 10 years—the Battle of Salamis in 480—and they win again, and then again the following year—the Battle of Plataea.
- 2.11** Six years later, in 472, Aeschylus puts on a play about Salamis. It's called simply the *Persians*. He writes a Greek tragedy about the sea battle that had happened just eight years before, in 480 BC. It's a very moving play, and it's one of our best sources for what happened on that day. It's an extraordinary source. It's a source, almost a first-hand source. Aeschylus would have known what it was like to fight, to row in a trireme, to be a marine as well as an army officer, a standard army officer. Most Greeks would have been able to do both, certainly in the first half of the fifth century.
- 2.12** Now, to go back to that distinction between Ranke and Dilthey in the previous lecture, you could say, if you could watch that play, Aeschylus' *Persians*, yes, you could say that it's all made up. I mean, the screenplay is made up, and they never actually said that. This speech is far too dramatic and articulate and sophisticated. It wouldn't have been something that the Persian queen would have wanted to say. And Persian maidens don't talk in a chorus and so on and so forth.

- 2.13** Nevertheless, it's an incredible insight in terms of—through the lens of Dilthey and Collingwood, if we're trying to interpret and understand the past, isn't it better to have this very moving play? Because Aeschylus is very generous to the other side, he doesn't demonize the Persians at all. In fact, it's very passionate, very moving. The tragedy is, what happens to the Persians? What happens when people overreach themselves and try to be too much like the gods? The gods will strike them down. It's a work of great sympathy by Aeschylus, especially given the fact that he was in the fighting, had been trained to fight and kill the Persians.
- 2.14** He was a hardened veteran, a very proud veteran, of the wars against the Persians. There's still this extraordinary imaginative sympathy here, and it is an incredible source. It's written by somebody who I don't think directly fought at Salamis—he would have been too old by then— but he would have watched it, and he would have known many, many, many people, many dozens of people who were there on the day, as it were. So it's a valuable source. It's a form of history, and not just a source, but something that attempts, in its own poetic literary mode, to make sense of a cataclysmically significant battle, the battle of Salamis.
- 2.15** John Stuart Mill at one point says that the Battle of Salamis was more important for the English than the Battle of Hastings, when William the Conqueror came across in 1066, and we all started picking up these French words, and he completely reorganized England, and it was the harrowing of the north and all of this. But no, Mill says, no, battle of Salamis, because if that had gone the other way, Europe would have very plausibly become Persia, no Alexander the Great, no Roman Empire. The whole of history would have been very different then.
- 2.16** So, we have this extraordinary document, a play, written just eight years after, by somebody who had known people involved, and it would have been performed in front of hundreds of people who had been directly involved in the battle.
- 2.17** So, there's a little bit of throat-clearing, you might say. The idea of something like history is in the air in Athens in particular, in the middle of the fifth century BC. And so, to the figure of our first historian, often called the father of history—Cicero calls him "pater historiae," the father of history— is this figure, who I mentioned in the first lecture: Herodotus of Halicarnassus.
- 2.18** Some texts, some manuscripts, refer to him as "Herodotus tou Crotonos," or Herodotus of Croton, which is, awkwardly, on the heel of Italy, a very, very long way from the southwest corner of Turkey. It's a completely different place. So he seems to have referred to himself as being from two different places in completely different corners of the Mediterranean. The answer to that is almost certainly that he accepted an invitation by the Athenians to go off and form part of a new colonial city, a colonial outpost, in the heel of Italy, Thurium, which the Athenians were supporting and busily building up at this time. He ends up there having gone through Athens. So he's an immensely well-traveled person for his era.

- 2.19** This is a period of intense commerce, trade, and traffic; it has been, really, from, let's say, 700 BC onwards. There are all sorts of different networks happening. First of all, you've got the Greeks. When you say Greeks, what you're talking about is actually dozens and dozens of independent city-states. There isn't any kind of centralized authority. They start trying to form leagues. They don't work out too well. Alliances, but they break up very quickly.
- 2.20** But each city-state, each "polis", is its own unit. You can write specific histories about that polis. There isn't a sense of Greece being part of an empire; it's just a group of people who speak the same language with slightly different accents, worship roughly the same gods, have roughly the same customs. But first and foremost, you're a Spartan, not a Greek. You're a Corinthian, not a Greek. You're an Athenian more than you're a Greek. It's your city-state that is your be-all and end-all, as it were.
- 2.21** It gets very difficult when the Persians come along. The Greeks are saying, "Why do we have to fight together? We're normally fighting each other. It's much more fun. Why can't we just keep going ahead with killing each other?" They will know there's this—they want to kill all of us. And so, we wouldn't be able to kill each other if we were all killed by these guys. So, in order to allow us to carry on killing each other, we've got to defeat these people who want to kill all of us.
- 2.22** But you can see, even there, there's a reluctance. The Spartans don't turn up at Marathon because they've got a festival on. You've got a few hundred Athenians in a bay, with their backs to the mountain, and you've got several thousand—we don't quite know how many, but possibly in the tens of thousands—of Persians disembarking to come and invade, not just to get rid of Athens, to get rid of the whole of Greece, if they could get through, but particularly Athens, after Athens gave support to something called the Ionian Revolt in the 490s.
- 2.23** They send help to the Spartans, and Spartans say, "Sorry, no, we're on holiday. It's Labor Day weekend. We know that the entirety of our civilization is under mortal threat, but we've got barbecues to get to and parties to have and services to do. Sorry." So they just don't turn up, and the Athenians don't let them forget this.
- 2.24** But then, 10 years later, the second invasion, the son of the Persian king comes in through the northeast and then tries to get through a pass in northern Greece to mount an invasion from the land, a territorial invasion from the north. The Spartans are off, and they defend the pass with great courage in 480, in the summer of 480 BC, and that delays, crucially delays, the Persian forces by several weeks, and they do play a very significant role in the battle of Plataea the following year, in 479.
- 2.25** Why are these important? Why is all this important to know? Because you've got a context in which you can understand for the first time how all of these different networks are operating, how the different city-states are interrelating, how they understand themselves as a collective entity. Ideas, as I said, are moving very fast

around the Mediterranean at this point. This is when coinage is first really invented. It's, let's say, probably around about 700, 650 BC in Lydia. But it's really becoming the power of having vaguely standardized currencies as a technology for trade, to accelerate trade, that is having enormously transformative effects.

- 2.26** You've got the city of Carthage, founded in 814 BC. These are mainly trading. These are traders, the Phoenicians. They used to be, plausibly, used to be Canaanites. They bring with them the alphabet, or at least the symbols that the Greeks would turn into what we now think of as an alphabet. "Aleph," the Phoenician Semitic word for ox or cow, if you have a—think of a capital A upside-down, put a couple of dots in it, you get a primitive ox face. Aleph simply meant ox. "Beth" simply meant tent. If you put a capital B on its side, the right way, you can see it's a couple of tents.
- 2.27** And the Greek genius was to see, as it came across all these symbols, as trading was getting busier over the course of the 7th, 6th, 5th centuries BC, the Greek genius was to see that maybe we don't need to treat these as symbols of particular things, like an ox or a tent. But why don't we say that they represent different sounds? In that moment, that moment of genius, we were all saved from hundreds and hundreds of hours at school, learning one symbol for every object in the world, or as ideographic scripts, languages, require us to do.
- 2.28** But no, somebody somewhere had the idea that there are many, many more things in the world than there are sounds that our mouth can make. We can express a lot with very few sounds. So, we should be focusing on symbols for the sounds. We should have a phonetic alphabet, not symbols for things, not an ideographic script. And so, aleph just became "a", and beth just became "b", and the Greeks designed the alphabet, 24 letters as opposed to 26. They have some duplicates, long O, short O, long E, short E. But apart from that, I think almost all our letters are in there somewhere. Y is a bit of a tricky one. But that's there; the bones, as it were, the bones of language suddenly emerge at this period.
- 2.29** This is the context in which our great hero, Herodotus, the father of history, emerges. The opening words of his Histories, which, it's hard to know, but let's say they come out round about 430 BC, just as a plague is about to hit Athens that is going to have huge consequences for her, for her fortune against Sparta in the Archidamian War, which begins in 431 BC, which is the second major phase of the Peloponnesian Wars, which run from, let's say, 446 to 404 BC.
- 2.30** It's a time at which the Persian wars are being forgotten and the intra-Greek wars, specifically the wars between the city-states that are gathered and allied around Athens and those who have gathered around Sparta—this is a new kind of war, as Thucydides, its great historian, says at one point, "A war like no other." In many ways, the Peloponnesian War was a brutal, brutal war that had no precedent, nothing to compare it to, certainly until then.

- 2.31** The first words of Herodotus' history are, "Herodotou Halikarnesseos histories apodexis hede." Herodotus from Halicarnassus here lays out, this is the laying-out, "apodexis," of the inquiry, the "histories," of Herodotus from Halicarnassus. That's the first sentence of any history that's recognized as trying to be history. It's an inquiry. That's what history means. "Historia" simply means, in Greek, to inquire.
- 2.32** In the Greek idea, in the Greek word "historie," there's a sense of investigation, inquiring, pursuing, you might say, researching. The point is not passively receiving information and chronicling it in a long, boring shopping list. It's actively investigating and inquiring into the past. This is the difference from some of the fragmentary previous writers I mentioned, like Hecataeus of Abdera, where it's clearly a lot more—or you might say ancient Near Eastern epigraphy, which is much more repetitive, and it's not trying to invest very much meaning in the writing on the statues and in the stone.
- 2.33** It's a fascinating opening, the Histories. He says at one point, this is in section 5 of the first chapter, "I'm writing this so that the things done by men will not be forgotten in time, and that great and marvelous deeds, 'klea erga,' some displayed by Greeks, some by barbarians, may not lose their glory," their "kleos." Kleos is this word in Greek, which has huge resonance from Homer. So kleos was the primary incentive, the primary driver, for the behavior of the Homeric warrior, the need to win glory and renown.
- 2.34** So you can still see in Herodotus that he's charmed by the Homeric universe and the currency of the Homeric universe— glory, fame, renown. But in that line, there's an extraordinary sensitivity to the vicissitudes of history, the fact that history is just a roller coaster ride in terms of going from fortune to fate, fate to fortune, and good to bad. There's a randomness to it. He's saying, "So I'm going to write about everyone. I'm going to write about everything I see, so that things may not be forgotten in time."
- 2.35** He says there's a memorializing function here to history. "I'm doing this so people don't forget." That's a reason. "I'm doing it for as many people as possible because you're never going to know who's going to become great and who's going to become small again. And I'm looking at non-Greeks as well as Greeks." Very, very interesting. "I'm going to be looking at the 'barbaroi,' the barbarians." Barbarians is a technical word in ancient Greece, effectively meaning "not Greek." If you're not Greek, you are a barbarian. Very simple.
- 2.36** In fact, they weren't even sure. Sometimes they thought some of the Greeks were barbarians as well. There was a very interesting debate as to whether or not the Macedonians were actually Greek. They're more like Geordies in England, or maybe hillbillies, if they haven't got— it's not clear if they're continuous in terms of language and so on and so forth.
- 2.37** But Herodotus is unbelievably generous. He's very open, open to all, partly because of his background, being brought up in Halicarnassus, which would have been, from the

490s onwards, under the control of Persia, under the boot of the Persian emperor, which, that whole coastline of what was once Greece, Ionian Greece, is wiped out by the Persians in the 490s, or at least is occupied and taken over. So Herodotus is saying, "I'm interested in Greeks as well as non-Greeks."

- 2.38** He devotes huge chunks of his nine-book Histories to other cultures, to Scythians, to Egyptians, to Lydians, to Medes, all of these different civilizations and cultures he's aware of, and documents, I think, in a very fair and dispassionate and an interested way. He's got an extraordinary curiosity, Herodotus.
- 2.39** What are his methods? What are the methods of the first-ever historian? Can we form a picture of that? He's a very relaxed writer. Often, he'll say, "I saw this myself. You may not believe me, but I saw it myself. I heard the priests tell me themselves." Often, he'll do a balanced reportage: "These people told me this, these people told me that. Maybe can't both be true, or it's a little bit of some tensions there, but I'm just reporting what I say." Sometimes he says, "By the way, I don't believe this. This is just, somebody told me. I don't myself believe it, but that's what he said."
- 2.40** And so, he's got this intellectual openness and a charity and generosity and capacity to draw in all this interesting material that seems to have absolutely nothing to do with this central plot of his Histories, namely, how did these little old Greeks beat the mightiest empire the world had ever seen, not just once, twice, but three times— three battles: Marathon in 490, Salamis in 480, and the Battle of Plataea in 479, but even the great defeats at Thermopylae were glorious defeats and displays an extraordinary strategic genius by the Greeks and extraordinary courage by the Greeks, which show that they could comfortably rank at the level of mighty Persia.
- 2.41** Very interestingly, towards the end of Herodotus' Histories, part of the reasoning that he seems to be pushing is that the reason that the Greeks did so well, even though you might have predicted that they wouldn't, given the vast differences in their resources and manpower and so on, is because they were free. They had freedom. They had "eleutheria". They had democracy.
- 2.42** Democracy at this point, I should point out, is about 16 years old. Democracy is a teenager in 490 BC— seventeen, actually. The first, Cleisthenes' reforms, the moment where you can say democracy begins in Athens, is around about 508-507 BC. 490 is the Battle of Marathon, and 480 is the final battle of Salamis, and then Plataea, and then Herodotus is writing, let's say, 450s, 440s. The way it's being framed, it's clear: What did we have that they didn't? Freedom, democracy. Every single citizen—no citizen is a slave. Whereas in Persia, there's only one citizen who isn't.
- 2.43** Herodotus says—and this is clearly picking up something, the spin in Athens at the time, but it's not implausible—that every single citizen in Athens felt himself an equal member of, had an equal stake in the survival of Athens and in the victory of the Greeks, because "I've got my say in the assembly. I've got my right that I could be

President one day, and nothing's going to stop me." It's the Athenian dream. And they could be—almost all of them were, at some point, not least because you could only be president for a day. You could be president for a day, but only a day. It's a 24-hour cycle, or their equivalent to a president, to make sure that no single person got too much power.

- 2.44 So he's got this very clear story that's supposed to connect these nine books together, including the book where he's just talking about Egypt. Egypt, as I think I said in the previous lecture, has absolutely nothing to do with the Persian Wars. The links turn out to be very tenuous: "No, I'm just going to tell you all about—" I mean, there were these Persian Wars. They happened around Greece, around where Athens and the Saronic Gulf is today, which is about a 100-mile stretch at most. It's a very big bay.
- 2.45 "I'm going to talk about those battles, but I'm going to spend the first five books writing about the whole of the Eastern Mediterranean and beyond, as it was round about that time and in the three or four centuries running up to it. I'm not going to just tell you about Persia; I'm going to tell you about how Persia got great. And there's this guy, Cyrus. Oh, and there's amazing stories about what he did when he was a boy. And let me tell you about when Cyrus was a boy. And oh, by the way, there was this other guy called Croesus, who was king of Lydia, very, very wealthy. And he thought he could take on the Persians, but they couldn't. And the Persians and the Medes had this big fight, and eventually Croesus lost." Lots of detail about Croesus, and then Croesus vanishes, dies, his empire falls. Nothing to do.
- 2.46 This was still 100 years out from the Persian Wars. There doesn't seem to be any reason for it, that Herodotus includes it. He's like, "The history of the Persian Wars, I'm not going to get to the Persian Wars till book seven out of nine." But it's this obsessive interest in the world, which he's trying to stitch together, not always in a particularly effective way, but he's trying to bring everything into this grand narrative that he wants to tell, which is how the Greeks defeated the Persians. It's the question: How did they do it?
- 2.47 He's not appealing to resources, because the Greeks didn't have more powerful resources. He says it's ideas, or it's men's belief in ideas, that alters the course of history. It was the Greeks' belief that they were free, their conviction that they were free and equal, that meant that they had the spirit, as it were, to overcome armies that were much bigger than them, but made up of slaves, slaves to the Persian king.
- 2.48 So that's Herodotus, and we can see in his writing there's interesting features, different layers of historical explanation. He's perfectly happy to appeal to how the gods were feeling, how this particular god was feeling that day, to explain some weird phenomenon that he's not able to explain otherwise. He's saying that it's perfectly possible that Aphrodite wasn't too happy with him or whatever.

- 2.49** But there's also an interest in human explanations: "This is why Themistocles behaved the way he did. This is why Croesus was arrogant, and he overreached himself and didn't understand the ambiguity in the Delphic Oracle, in his case," to very natural explanations, so that there are parts of Herodotus that read as if you're almost, it's like botany. It's a description of nature, of the natural world, divested of any human interpretation.
- 2.50** So you can say that, for Herodotus, history is unpredictable. It doesn't move in particular set directions. It hasn't got one overall horizon, but that you can appeal to things like ideas and people's convictions to explain. In other words, you can appeal to human beings, human agents, as key players in a historical explanation. It's not just about material resources. It's about what people believe, how they feel, what they think they're doing.
- 2.51** Herodotus, in some corners, is called the father of lies because he seems like he's constantly spinning implausible stories. I should say that there have been about a half-dozen occasions in the last 50-odd years when there's been some random archeological find, or some random piece of epigraphy has been deciphered, that test what Herodotus talks about, and that effectively confirm Herodotus. The one I came across a few weeks ago was about, is it gold-eating ants? He reports hearing about gold-eating ants, and he writes this strange passage, and this has been confirmed.
- 2.52** He's to be treated as probably our best source for that extraordinary clash between Greece and Persia in the first half of the fifth century BC. But there's also these other benefits that he has, as the first historian, that he's got methodological openness to what counts as history, what is interesting about human beings, and what is worthy of not being forgotten and being properly recorded.
- 2.53** Our second great figure—and I referred to him in the previous lecture as, in many ways, the kind of co-founder of history with Herodotus—is Thucydides. Thucydides of Athens, born probably around about 460. We're not sure when he dies. He tragically breaks off his history in 411 BC, but it seems as if he was probably still alive in 405, 404. Thucydides is, in many ways, a very, very different figure from Herodotus. He's born in Athens, grows up in Athens. He goes into exile up in the north of Greece at various points. But he's really Athenian, born and bred, doesn't travel very much. He doesn't have Herodotus' style or his literary flair.
- 2.54** He's a general. In fact, he is a general in the war that he describes, that he becomes the great historian of in his history of the Peloponnesian War. Actually, reading the sections where he describes himself in the third person at a key moment in— this is around about 422-421 BC, towards the end of the Archidamian War—he actually confronts and loses to this brilliant Spartan general called Brasidas, but he records it very dispassionately.

- 2.55** He stresses the importance of verification, rigor in checking. You don't get any appeals, as you do in Herodotus, to divine intervention or to oracles or any of that. He writes these long, elaborate speeches, which he puts into the mouth of different historical characters. But he's got a particular method. He's got a particular defense of that. He says, "I'm looking for the truest cause of why things happen." The "alethestate prophasis," the truest reason, the truest cause, for why Athens and Sparta went to war.
- 2.56** You might think of Herodotus as writing about the great clash between Greece and Persia, between Greece and its greatest foe, and Thucydides is writing the history of the horrific civil, internal Hellenic conflict that tore apart the Greek world from, let's say, from the 440s onwards, 446 to 404 BC. Those are the key years of the Peloponnesian War. But they carry on butchering each other deep into the fourth century BC, and it's not until Alexander the Great comes along and clears them all out, defeats them all, that there's some measure of peace restored to this part of the world.
- 2.57** But by that point, the golden age, the great civilizational heights that the Greek genius lifted itself to in the fifth century, would never be recovered. It was just this short, very, very short flash that ended in tragedy, in war. Thucydides is the great documenter of this war. He talks about his history at one point as a "ktema es to aiei," a possession for always, for the always, a possession for all time. This is his self-understanding of what he's doing, as something that's monumental. He says, as a "ktema te es aiei mallon e agonisma es to parachrema akouein xynkeitali." A possession for all time, rather than as a prize essay, an "agonisma," that's just for the moment, just for hearing.
- 2.58** It could be a sly dig at Herodotus, who, it seems from his prose, that these sometimes read like transcripts from a storytelling afternoon in the Agora in Athens. There's something of the storytelling style to him. It's very plausible that a lot of Herodotus' materials he had tried out orally in performance, even semi-formal performance, in and around Athens, and no doubt to Thucydides himself. Thucydides says, "These are not just my YouTube clips or me performing on stage somewhere. This is serious."
- 2.59** His reasoning for thinking that his history is going to be a possession for all time is that human nature is something for all time. Human nature is not something that changes. He's got this confidence in the constancy of human nature, a constancy for virtuous behavior and a constancy for vicious behavior. This is how he operates. He's looking for causes, particularly looking for structural causes, looking at the way in which individuals make decisions.
- 2.60** And yet, it might be easy to fall into the trap of thinking that Thucydides is so dispassionate that he doesn't have any moral judgments to make about what he's describing, the history he's writing. And that's not true at all. Indeed, some of the most remarkable passages in Thucydides' history of the Peloponnesian War are those passages when it's very clear that a moral horror is about to take place, and that Thucydides is aware of it, and is indeed trying to make sense of it as best he can,

whether it's, famously, in Book 5, with the confrontation between the forces of Athens that have just landed on the small island of Melos.

- 2.61** Thucydides does these superb speeches between the Athenians and the Melians, and the Melians back to the Athenians and so on. Effectively, the message of the Athenians is, "The strong do what they can, and the weak suffer what they must." The strong do what they can, and the weak suffer what they must. This is a famous excerpt from the speeches of the Athenians to the Melians in Book 5 of Thucydides' history. He wrote the speech, and, in many ways, this is a reconstruction, but no doubt also an elaboration.
- 2.62** Thucydides conveys very powerfully the morality that governed the Athenian decision-making, early democratic bodies, namely, that might is right. We're stronger, we're more powerful, and there's no rhyme or reason to it. There's no objective morality that governs us both. We're stronger, we're more powerful, and we're going to—it's only power that matters, and there can be no appeal to justice between unequals. This is the logic. This is how Thucydides reads the situation. The Melians refuse to capitulate. All the men of Melos are massacred, and all the women and children are enslaved. Thucydides doesn't moralize that part; he simply describes it. But he's laid out the arguments for and against, and it's clear what his own views are.
- 2.63** An extraordinary figure, really, Thucydides, in many ways, the father of international relations, certainly the father of the doctrine of realism in international relations. That is to say, you should be looking to the extent that you can as a nation to bend the world in the direction of what's realistic. You shouldn't, in fact, try to bend the world at all, if possible. The realist is going to take much more seriously the motivations and the psychology of a geopolitical opponent, is going to be less bothered by, for example, shaking hands or making convenient alliances with people who there would be all sorts of reasons for saying is an immoral person and a terrible leader, and maybe even a totalitarian leader. But the realist will say, "No, our interest is the national interest. And so, yes, it should factor into the balance of our judgment, all the bad that this person has done in the past and the threats that he poses and so on, but overall, we should forge this alliance because this is going to be useful to us and this achieves our ends."
- 2.64** The realist in international relations is somebody who tries to search for those psychologies, not the grandstanding that might sometimes accompany it. "No, we've got to do this because it's the right thing to do. Even though this terrible injustice is happening on the other side of the world, we couldn't actually have much influence on it, even if we did." But for Thucydides, this is an idealist; this is not understanding the true motives behind why geopolitical actors relate to each other in the way that they do. But Thucydides is the first to really think hard about those questions.
- 2.65** The third Greek historian I wanted to glance at, as we're moving past, is partly because he doesn't get enough airtime in my view. He gets lost between the two great Greek historians, Herodotus and Thucydides, and then the Roman historians who begin to

emerge in the first century BC. But poor old Polybius is Greek, so he writes in Greek, but he spends a significant chunk of his life under house arrest with the Romans. But he's lucky, because he is alive over the period in the second century BC—from, say, 200 to 118 BC are his dates— he's alive when many of the veterans of the first great Punic War, the first great clash between Rome and Carthage, occurred, 263 to 241.

- 2.66** Then the second Punic War, a few decades later, and Polybius would have witnessed the final crushing and erasure and annihilation of Carthage in 146 BC by Scipio Africanus, and the annihilation of the beautiful city of Corinth in the Peloponnese by Lucius Mummius, also in 146, 147-146 BC. Polybius would have witnessed that and would have seen the great, should we say the great century of conflict between Carthage and Rome, let's say 264, at the beginning of the first Punic War, and 147, 146, the flattening, the final flattening of Carthage forever. That really is Polybius' subject. That's what he throws himself into.
- 2.67** His question is—part of the rationale for his writing his history is—my question is: Why did Rome succeed when so many others failed? What was it about Rome that gave it its greatness? In Book 6 of his histories, he develops this very interesting theory. He says that Plato is probably right that the way political change happens is that you have these early tribes, and there's a captain of the gang, and he gets elevated and gets turned into a king.
- 2.68** Then the king gets corrupt, or his son gets corrupt and becomes a tyrant. And then his friends have to step in, get rid of the tyrant, rule as an elite, an officer class of the best, of the "aristoi." we have an aristocracy, power, "kratos," vested in the best, in the aristoi. But then that elite gets captured, it gets politicized, it gets corrupt. It becomes a rule, an "arche," by the "oligoi," by the few, an oligarchy. It's just an oligarchy.
- 2.69** Then eventually, the people get fed up with the oligarchy, and they overturn it in a big revolution, the "demos." You have a "demo kratos," a democracy. But then the people can't be trusted either, because mobs go crazy and get corrupt. You get, in Greek, an "ochlos," a mob. And then you get ochlocracy, mobocracy, ruled by the mob. So what you need is a strong, dynamic, charismatic figure who will come through to sort it all out, who you then elevate as a king, and so on.
- 2.70** And so, for Polybius—or Plato before him and Polybius—there's this huge never-ending cycle, from king to tyrant to aristocracy to oligarchy to democracy to mobocracy, and then back. Polybius says, "Until Rome, until Rome." The genius of the Roman Republic is that it solved this problem. It stopped this pattern in history in its tracks. So how did they do that?
- 2.71** Polybius' answer is: they've got this mixed constitution. They've always got their king, and they've always got something to prevent the king from becoming a tyrant. They've always got their aristoi, their aristocracy, but they've got other things to stop the aristocracy becoming an oligarchy. And they've worked out a way for the people to

have some representation, but not so much that they become a mob. They're checked from becoming a mob.

- 2.72** This is what Polybius says when he looks at the Roman constitution. He says, basically, they've got two kings who are elected for one year, and you've got to wait your turn. It's not impossible to be elected again, but it's basically one and you're out, and that you've got to share it with one other person. You're a consul. It's not a monarchy; it's a diarchy, two kings, like the Spartans. You've got the consuls that come in the beginning of the year; they leave at the end of the year. There are two of them. They're voted. They're the kings.
- 2.73** That's the closest Rome was ever going to get to having kings or some sovereign authority or monarchical authority, after what it had gone through at the end of the sixth century when it got rid of its kings. You've got the consuls, you have the king, monarchy role. Then you've got the Senate, and the Senate is effectively the aristoi, the best men. Then you've got the tribunes, who are elected by the people. All three are connected to each other. No one of those has complete power. Power is separated, is diffused across these three.
- 2.74** Polybius says this breaks the pattern, because you're trying to, through checks and balances, filter out the best of each of those three modes of governance: governance by one, governance by few, governance by many. In this way, you've got a model that includes a bit of rule by one or two, a bit of rule by the few, and some rule by the many. That's what insulates the system, society and Rome, for Polybius, against degeneration.
- 2.75** In many ways, that's the way to understand the U.S. Constitution, the presidency, the Senate, and the House of Representatives. And although in a very different way, you can read Britain like that, or at least historically as having been like that. You have the monarch, the Crown, in Parliament, all power unified in the Crown, but that power is—it can't be checked exactly, but its power has different modes. The power of the Crown has different modes.
- 2.76** So it has a legislative mode, and that will be the House of Commons and the House of Lords, the House of Lords representing the aristoi, you might say, the Senate, the House of Commons representing the demos, and the judiciary is included within the House of Parliament, or at least historically had been. It's a lot more of a unified model, but you've still got that, Polybius' idea of those three different elements checking each other and balancing each other.
- 2.77** So, that's a walk through some of the great Greek historians. It's worth, as I said, just mentioning briefly some of the Roman ones. Although, as I said at the beginning, it's really the Greeks who are founding history as a discipline. It's really, with the Romans, we have Roman historians; we have a different— something that's brilliant in its own way, but doesn't have the innovative, the power of forging something, an entirely new way of approaching the past.

2.78 I'll say a little bit more about these Roman historians in the next lecture as a prelude to thinking about some of the more Hebraic ways of thinking about history, in addition to the Hellenic ones, where we see history as being invested with much more theological claims about its direction and how to understand the succession of different events.

Lecture 3: Sacred History

At a glance — Sacred history.

- 3.1 Welcome to lecture three of the eight-part series, Philosophy of History. In the last lecture, we did a whistle-stop tour of the great Greek historians, really the cradle of history as a discipline, the cradle of historiography, the great figures of Herodotus of Halicarnassus, and of Thucydides of Athens. Finally, we looked at the great Polybius, who was beginning to document and write about this new emerging power, Rome, across the Mediterranean.
- 3.2 It's worth adding to that a brief comment at least, on the Roman historians that followed them. I'm thinking of two in particular. I think the two greatest—certainly my two favorite— but the two, I think, most important and significant historians that emerged from the late Roman Republic and early Rome, early Rome as a dynastic principate, are Livy and Tacitus. Tacitus, coming a bit later than Livy himself, Livy's 59 BC to 17 AD. He dies the same year as—no, sorry, just three years later than Augustus, who dies in 14 AD.
- 3.3 He's really writing about the Rome of the past, republican Rome, the great myths and legends and the founding legends that gave rise to the glory of Rome. The story of Romulus and Remus is in here, the story of the capture of the Sabine women, Horatius at the Bridge, lots of these very famous scenes from republican histories. We have them because Livy writes about them.
- 3.4 For Livy, you can say that history is a form of moral instruction. These are "exempla" in Latin. These are examples, exemplars, ways of behaving under conditions of extreme stress that are praiseworthy, that we should try to emulate, we should meditate on, we should digest, we should think about. A little bit like you might hear a religious person talk about the founder of their religion, all the things they did, all the saints or the prophets in their faith. It's normal you would read lives of the saints or lives of great martyrs or lives of people who you want to emulate in some way or who've devoted themselves to something you value.
- 3.5 That's very much Livy's style. It's quite didactic. It's instructive. It's trying to teach what's right and what's not. He stresses republican virtue, the great sacrifices that many figures in Roman republican history made for the "res publica", with Latin—those two Latin words simply mean public affairs, or the things that belong to the public.
- 3.6 Livy is often skeptical about what he sees as the dangers of wealth and luxury arising or accruing to an increasingly significant geopolitical power in the Mediterranean world at that time. Is wealth, is money going to our heads, is a regular theme. Look at these great figures who lived ascetic lives, who were not interested in greed and luxury. We regard them as noble for having done that.

- 3.7** Livy's histories, interestingly, get taken up by Machiavelli in the 16th century, 1531. The *Discorsi* come out, Discourses, simply discourses on Livy's history of Rome. It's quite a patchy history of Rome. I mean, he wrote about 120, 130 books altogether. We've only got about 35 of them surviving. But it's a history, *Ab Urbe Condita*, from the city's founding, from the city being founded. The typical date, the standard received date for that, is 753 BC. Rome is founded in 753 BC. Carthage, a little bit earlier than that. Livy sets out to write a history from that year zero.
- 3.8** And indeed, if you go round, if you look at Roman epigraphy, that is to say, writings on statues and writings in marble, you can see that that's the history, that's the timeline in which a Roman would have positioned himself. So, 31 BC, the Battle of Actium, when Augustus finally wins the great civil wars and emerges as this sort of king, but who's also not, in 31 BC—that is what? My math isn't terribly good, but it's something like 722. It would be something like 722, "ab urbe condita." So 722 "ab urbe condita" would be 31 BC in our time, because it would be, 753 is year zero. And so, 722 takes us to just about the date of the Battle of Actium, and for us, 31 BC.
- 3.9** So Livy is important, and so is the more cynical figure of Tacitus, who is beginning to describe what Livy really never saw, namely the slow corruption of the Roman imperium, the Roman imperial dynasty. And so, Tacitus writes acidically about Augustus, to some extent, Augustus' slow isolation as, in fact, emperor now, and the slow decline of the so beloved by many dramas and novels over the years, of the Julio-Claudian dynasty of the first century. All the really mad emperors were concentrated into this quite short span of decades from roughly 14 AD, when Augustus dies, Tiberius takes over, up to at least the 90s AD, when you've still got pretty crazy emperors around like Nero and Domitian.
- 3.10** It was not a great run for emperors. There were four of them in one year in 69 AD. So Tacitus could be forgiven for being a little bit cynical, but he says he is writing as a senator. He's somebody who's achieved high office in the early second century AD. So he's writing about, really, the previous 80, 90 years. So he would have access to good sources. He'd have access to excellent eyewitnesses, people who worked in the imperial palace, in the civil service, in the armies, and so on.
- 3.11** But he says, "It's my purpose to set out 'sine ira et studio,' without anger or partiality or bias, the causes of what is now far from me." By this, he meant, he says elsewhere, the historians under Tiberius and Gaius and Claudius and Nero either didn't end up too well, because they spoke the truth, or more likely, everything they wrote was false because they were living under a reign of terror. If they said the wrong thing, they'd meet a bad end. Whereas I'm free of that and I can write dispassionately and without anger or bias.
- 3.12** But there's a lot of snide asides and snide remarks. One of my favorite, in particular, is in two words in Latin or three words, "Capax imperii nisi imperasset." Actually, four words: "Capax imperii nisi imperasset." He was capable of ruling, capable of imperium.

He had all the marks of being somebody who could rule well. "Nisi imperasset," if only he hadn't ruled. Somebody who, just in four words, is capable. He could have been a contender, but he was, and we saw how terrible that judgment was, that he would be any good. So, he has these waspish little asides like this.

- 3.13** Like Livy, he laments the simplicities and moral clarity of republican Rome, which runs from roughly 509 BC all the way up to, through lots of civil wars in the first century BC, finally comes to an end. You've got the assassination of Caesar in 44; you've got the Battle of Philippi in 42; you've got the 30s, which is just a bloodbath all across Italy and around most of the Mediterranean that Rome now dominates, between all these different characters, between Pompey and Crassus, and Caesar and Brutus and Mark Antony, and then finally Octavian.
- 3.14** Anyway, all this gets resolved finally in one big sea battle in 31 BC, when finally Octavian defeats the combined naval forces of Antony, Mark Antony and Cleopatra. That's really the beginning, 31 BC, of the moment when Rome ceases to be a republic and is, for the first time, an imperial dynasty, an empire that understands itself as an empire, even though it preserved the republican constitution. So Augustus says, "I'm not your king, but if you would like me to put myself forward for election as one of the two consuls just for this year, I'd be very happy to do that. Oh, and I think my best friend would be a very suitable partner, Agrippa, Marcus Agrippa."
- 3.15** So it turns out, the old republican Rome is back, and there's just the two consuls at the top, as we've had for nearly 500 years. "Oh, he looks familiar, and his best friend looks familiar, too." The next year comes around, and Augustus is very reluctant, but really feels the people are demanding that he put himself forward again for the consulship, that's only supposed to be held for one year. And mysteriously, by popular acclaim, he's elected consul again, the second year in a row. But he says, "I'm just a consul, just a humble consul. I'm maybe a 'princeps'. Maybe I'm a prince, a 'princeps'. I'm the first among equals. That's what I am."
- 3.16** But he moves into a very humble home on the top of the Palatine Hill, next to where the Colosseum is today, and had a very ostentatiously frugal life, wasn't too lavish, didn't let greed go to his head, tried to insist that Romans should get back to family values. It didn't help that both his daughter, Julia, and his granddaughter, Julia, had very public affairs, sometimes with his friends and former friends. So he had a very particular—and Tacitus is very good at describing how this transition happens, even without it seeming to happen, and how Augustus gets control.
- 3.17** Then, beyond that, he charts the terrible decline, particularly the moral decline, of the imperial dynasty in the first century, some really clinically insane emperors. Nero wasn't even the worst. A collection of people where you can say Nero wasn't the worst is not a great bunch of people, not a bunch of people you want to be anywhere close to. I mean, Caligula was probably quite a lot worse than Nero. Caligula is the emperor who made his horse a senator, a member of the Senate. That's how much respect he

had for the Senate. Maybe it was a subtle critique of the Senate. Anyone could be a senator.

- 3.18** So there's a lot of psychological insight in Tacitus. And there's a couple of fascinating passages. For example, Chapter 44 of Book 15 of the Annals, what's left of it, of his great work, the Annals—again, as with Livy, these texts are terribly mothballed and pockmarked, and we've only got large fragments, very large chunks, but nothing close to the complete work, tragically. But there's a fascinating chapter, Chapter 44 of Book 15, where he talks about Nero starting the fire in Rome, and then deciding to blame it on the followers of Christus. And he just has this throwaway remark.
- 3.19** And this is very interesting. This is describing the great fire in Rome that happens in 64 AD, the reasons for it, the rumors that Tacitus takes to be true, that Nero started the fire. Then there was this group who called themselves followers of Christus, who were part of this "superstitio," they were part of a superstition, like a cult, not a religion, not a "religio", a cult. The reason this is so important is that this is one of our first pieces of pagan evidence for Christianity. It's one of our earliest pieces of evidence outside the New Testament for the early Christians.
- 3.20** That's quite an interesting date, 64 AD, because that's 31, 2, 3 years after the allegedly historical event of the resurrection. So, what you've got is a 30-year interval between that event happening and there being a community of followers of this man, who was crucified and executed, in the metropolis, in the very capital of the empire, a community that was somehow sustaining itself and was seen by the Romans as distinct from Jews.
- 3.21** Because there were Jews there, too, but, in Roman eyes, they were distinct groups, large enough for it to be possible for Nero to get away with using it as a scapegoat. If it was just this obscure group, Nero wouldn't have chosen to scapegoat the Christians if it were not broadly, generally widely known that there was this community there, that they're always up to no good, but they're like that. It's that group. That in itself is priceless evidence. It shows that, at a very, very short, very, very fast, very short time scale, this movement has spread very fast and established itself in the imperial capital, and is being recognized as a distinct group.
- 3.22** So that's a little bit about—a coda, as it were, to our discussion of the Greek historians, saying something about Livy and Tacitus and their value. I think we can now step back and, having observed the account of history that these different figures offer, which is whereby history is messy, it is cyclical to some extent, it exhibits certain patterns, we can use it for moral instruction in particular. We can see that this is an age of decadence, compared to a much simpler, more glorious age that came before. This is very common to both Livy and to Tacitus, to the extent that I think they do romanticize the republican past.

- 3.23** We're moving now more towards theologically structured ways of thinking about history. What's interesting is that, round about the time that Carthage is being founded and Rome is being founded as a city, round about the first time that all the Greek city-states are starting to send out their colonies to Italy and the south of France, you have the emergence of another kind of history. You might call it prophetic history, the history that has come down to us in the history books of the Hebrew scriptures of the Old Testament, in particular, the Deuteronomistic histories, the history that we really start to read as history.
- 3.24** Think of Joshua, Book of Joshua, here. Think of, obviously, 1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, and Numbers, and Deuteronomy, important historical documents, too, attempts to do some kind of history. And then that slightly curious later pair of texts, Chronicles, 1 Chronicles, 2 Chronicles, which is clearly a later rewrite of big chunks of 1, 2 Samuel, 1, 2 Kings.
- 3.25** But this is history. It is recognizable as a kind of history that is more sophisticated again than anything else in the ancient Near East at the time—more sophisticated than, say, what the Hittites' tablets reveal about them, or the cenotaphs of the—sorry, the great tombs of the Egyptian pharaohs. It's clear that there's a reflection on history here. History has a meaning.
- 3.26** As it emerges in early Israelite religion, history is not cyclical, it's not static, it's not random, it's directed. It has a purpose. Yes, it's messy, but there are very clear through lines that are propelling history forward towards a particular end. This is the basic structure of the Hebraic historical imagination, very different from the Hellenic one, which doesn't think in these terms at all. There's no beginning, middle, and an end. Sometimes it used to be brilliant, but now it's terrible. In Homer's day, everybody was so much stronger and so much nicer to their moms. Now look at us. There's quite a lot of that, but there isn't a sense of history that is all directed towards a particular end, a transcendent end, an end which is the end of history itself.
- 3.27** What's so interesting about the Hebrew scriptures, or the historical books in the Hebrew scriptures, is that it's both a nation writing the history of itself, but also writing a history that is a history of itself and, by extension, because of a central theological claim, the history of humanity, the whole history of everybody.
- 3.28** There's this incredible toggling and shifting in those historical books between the particularity of the promises and the obligations on the early Israelites, but the universality of their destiny, of their goal. This is something about more than just greatness for ourselves, but we're to be a light unto the Gentiles. That's their self-understanding, within the theologically framed history.
- 3.29** History doesn't repeat itself. Everything is unrepeatable, but there's a broad— because there's a direction, you could say that different events are connected to each other in different ways, but basically, events are unique. There aren't recurring patterns. There

aren't eternal patterns as Giambattista Vico would think, or Polybius, for example. There's just beginning, middle, and end, or in theological terms, creation, fall, rescue, freedom, and political self-consciousness, and then a kind of exile and return, and then a kind of future redemption. That's the basic narrative arc of the Old Testament.

3.30 Where did we come from? It was creation, Genesis 1-2. What went wrong? Story of the fall. How do we put it right? Basically, covenant. Who's going to rescue us when we can't get it right? Exodus, and the beginnings of a political self-conception. How do we organize ourselves? How do we count ourselves? Numbers. How do we organize ourselves? Law, Deuteronomy, the second law, Deuteronomy. Then, again, motifs of captivity, exile, and return that we see already in the Book of Exodus with respect to the Egyptians. We see in a lot of the prophets in the sixth century BC, when it comes to the Israelites' relationship to Babylon, the Babylonians who captured Jerusalem in 587 BC and until Cyrus liberates them in 539 BC, that's seen, in some ways, as another kind of captivity, a Babylonian captivity.

3.31 And then, one day, there will be a restoration, a restoration of the Jewish people to their home in Jerusalem. And so, there's a future orientation, a future redemption. And you could say that's the narrative arc of the Old Testament history books and the narrative arc of the prophets as well, the major and minor prophets. That's the way in which history is structured for them, going in a particular direction. The story of the nation also somehow distills the story of all humanity, because Genesis 1 isn't about the origins of the first member of the nation of Israel, or the first Israelite, Adam, the first man, the human.

3.32 This is what's so fascinating about the Old Testament: that dawning awareness that they're not just a nation, but somehow have this destiny. They also somehow distill within themselves a universal narrative of all human beings. All human beings are created, all human beings fall, all human beings need some mechanism to correct the fall. All human beings end up in captivity of some sort, need exodus and liberation from it, need order, the order that law provides, and so on and so forth.

3.33 A key idea in these books, in the Old Testament, of course, is that of covenant. Covenant. That the history of Israel is not the history of Israel in the historical books of the Old Testament, but really, the history of the relationship between the people of Israel and God and their God. That's what it's about. It's the push and pull between these two that is what drives the historical books.

3.34 You have something similar in Homer. At various points, Aphrodite comes down and throws a tantrum on the battlefield because she gets a little bit stung on her arm. Hera starts henpecking Zeus, just nagging him and being very mean to him. And the narrative of the Iliad is punctuated, quite tragically at various points, by the gods living their very easy lives in the middle of the horrors of the battlefield. But there isn't any sense that the gods are particularly involved. It's a very different feeling from reading the Old Testament history books and looking at the interaction between gods and mere

mortals. It's a very, very different sort of relationship, one involving covenant, promise, a steadiness of character, steadiness of relationships, certainly compared to the wildly arbitrary and unpredictable behavior of Homer's gods.

- 3.35** Different covenants emerge in the historical self-narration of the early Israelites. You have the covenant with Abraham, of course, covenant with Moses on Sinai, a covenant with David. The idea behind a covenant is, in many ways, that it's a promise made between God and a people for now and forever. So the promise continues to bind, reciprocally bind God and the people that he's made it with, his people. It's a covenant that was forged at a particular moment in history. It hasn't just been timelessly the case. No, God did a deal with Abraham. This is what he said, this is what Abraham said, this is the covenant.
- 3.36** And similarly with Moses, we've got it in writing. It's part of our history. This is what he agreed with David. These are the promises, and we need to do this in order for that to happen. This is absolutely central to understanding the way time flows in the Hebrew mind, the way history flows in the Hebrew mind, and as an explanation of what happens in history.
- 3.37** This idea of a covenant being forged at a particular time in a particular place, so having a beginning, but then eternally existing, as it were, beyond that, is very unusual. But it's an incredibly powerful way to forge a group of people together who are acutely conscious of themselves as being, first and foremost, a part of a group. Because this isn't just history. This is a history of the promises that God has made with your people in a very specific way, which claimed to be binding for all time.
- 3.38** So, yes, you could say, this is all part of our national history: we had this fantastic forefather, we had this great king, God really liked him, and they did a deal. So this is our eternal divine promise of what's going to be the case for us, forever. So history there, is it history? You're talking about something that is understood to be much more like the cornerstone of history, the starting point from which all other history comes from, namely, the relationship between God, if God exists, and human beings. It's a very unusual way of writing history, you might say, this theologically structured, theologically filtered way.
- 3.39** But in many ways, you can look at the Greek histories and say, well, they're also shaped by all sorts of decisions that involve theology or involve some sense of fate, for example. Herodotus believes deeply in hubris and nemesis, that if mere mortals overreach themselves, they'll provoke the envy of the gods, "phthonos theon," and the gods will strike them down, and you will meet your nemesis. So this is like a cyclical, tit-for-tat Philosophy of History, which is Herodotus'. Is it true? Is it not? Well, it's as contestable as the great theological narratives of the Old Testament. We do operate with these hunches, these big ideas. "He had it coming. He was always getting too big for his boots. Of course, it was time. He was going to get struck down." We like to invest events with meanings that we would like to be true, that might be true.

- 3.40 So, with the history books in the Old Testament, it's not just what happened—maybe Chronicles, which is quite dry, which is basically, this is what happened. We've heard it all before, because it's been done better in 1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, and 2 Kings, by a much greater writer. But broadly speaking, it's not what happened, but why did it happen? Not what did Israel go through, but why did it happen? What's the explanation for why this happened?
- 3.41 Even if the answers tended to be a little bit more sacred than secular, it's still an attempt to organize the past in some way, with some central question. Remember, with Polybius, it was: How is it that Rome got so successful so fast when others didn't? For Thucydides, it was: How do we explain why the Greek world, at the peak of its civilizational excellence, decided to tear itself apart in this devastating war for 31 years? Herodotus, too. He wants to understand the Persian Wars and so on. So all these animating questions, each category of which still does understand history and its direction in a very different way.
- 3.42 And this is a source for moral instruction. You could say that the Greek historians, the Roman historians, are teaching moderation, or "phronesis" in Greek, "prudentia" in Latin. Prudence—prudence isn't a word that's very muscular these days, but it's good judgment, good practical judgment, practical wisdom, a good translation of "prudentia."
- 3.43 You understand how power works. You navigate the world as it is. The world is a random and messy place. Everything can be a little bit arbitrary. There are no second chances, and there's no life after death, or at least no life after death worth thinking about or that will be very enjoyable. That's the Greek view. The heroes are the ones who can meet with equanimity the adversities that are thrown at them. They can stay calm. They can recognize that they don't have as much control as they might think over the world and so on and so forth. So it cultivates stoicism, you might say. It's not by accident that the Stoics emerge around this time.
- 3.44 Whereas in the Old Testament books, you could say, morally, what are the first readers getting from these texts? It's not so much a guide to how to live well; it's more that this is what's going to happen at the end of history. "You're part of this group that has this role to play in the whole of the history of humanity. Just make sure you have this meal, then you go to these prayers, and you just keep your end of the bargain, and everything will be fine. That's the role you're playing in history. You've got to be obedient. When things get tough, you hope, look to the horizon, the glorious end of all things, and you'll be fine."
- 3.45 It's a very different way of using history to instruct ourselves on how we should go about living our lives. The Greek mind is: anything could happen. The gods could throw anything at you at any time. Wildly unpredictable. Psychopaths, in many cases. Don't take any advice from them, definitely, or don't try to get any wisdom for any interactions between the gods and mortals in Homer and elsewhere. It's just, they're

not on your side. You know what's going to happen in the future, so just be careful and don't get too big for your boots, and you'll be fine.

- 3.46** Whereas there's a completely different moral message that comes through the Old Testament, which is much more about hope. It's about remaining faithful, obedient to the covenants, and committed to your nation, committed to its rules, its food laws, and so on and so forth. Very different framing from the point of view of moral teaching.
- 3.47** Up until now, we've considered, when it comes to history, the twin engine rooms of Western history, the Hellenic and the Hebraic. So the Greek influence and, subsequently, the Roman influence, and the influence of the texts that have come down to us in the Old Testament, and indeed, texts beyond that in the inter-testamental period, the so-called Apocrypha, the great book of the Maccabees, which describes the great clash between Second Temple Jews in Jerusalem, and Antiochus Epiphanes IV, who's a successor to Alexander the Great, a great Hellenistic king, who clashes terribly with Jews at the time, and this is recorded in Book of Maccabees, which is interesting, again, theologically structured history.
- 3.48** All of these histories and all of the writing that emerges from those texts are particular. It's about this particular people. It's about the Israelites and so on. Whereas with Thucydides and Herodotus, he's saying, "I'm going to write about everybody, absolutely everybody: the Egyptians, the Scythians, the Phoenicians. Everybody's going to get a mention, because I don't know who's going to be— I don't know what's going to happen in the future. I'm a Greek, and it could be terrible, it could be good. They don't know what's going to happen to them. It could be terrible, it could be good. So I'm just going to write it all down, so that nothing gets forgotten, that doesn't deserve to be forgotten. Because all of these human beings are being motivated for glory, for 'kleos,' and it's my job to make sure the kleos, the glory, shines through." So, these are the two engine rooms.
- 3.49** Now, one of the most extraordinary developments in the intellectual history of the West occurs when a movement emerges in the first century, in the second century AD, that becomes rapidly, intellectually sophisticated enough to start to think about how to integrate these two engines into a single engine room. That movement was Christianity. Because in the early Christians, you have highly literate, sophisticated intellectuals who are brought up as faithful, observant Jews.
- 3.50** Sometimes you have major figures in early Christianity who are Roman citizens, who are brought up in a Hellenistic, Greek-speaking, sophisticated urban center in the Roman Empire. Sometimes they're the same person. I've just described St. Paul, or Saul of Tarsus, as he was. He's a Roman citizen. We know that, because when he's pulled, dragged in front of a local court, he demands his right to be tried in Rome. "Civis Romanus sum," I am a Roman citizen. I demand my rights, which was a trial in Rome, which he got.

- 3.51** But he's brought up by the best rabbis from as a child all the way up through his teenage years and becomes one of the most fearsome Pharisees, scriptural judges of his day, probably spoke Latin pretty well, probably could read—we certainly know he could read and write extraordinary Greek. So it's amazing; the figure of Paul blends all three of these big identities together, dominating the Mediterranean world for so many centuries: the Jewish, the Roman, and the Greek identity. Roman citizenship, extraordinary Greek language, Greek prose, and Jewish upbringing of extremely intense Jewish scholarly upbringing.
- 3.52** In many ways, you can say that this fusion of the two, the fusion of the Hebraic and the Hellenic, has a significant impact on how we understand history, on how the early Christians understood time, particularly in dialogue with an established Roman intellectual guild that thought all of this, thought of all the claims of early Christianity, not just not—they didn't even think of it as a religion, they just said this is a superstition; this is a cult. It's not worth taking seriously, let alone taking as seriously as, potentially, some philosophy or some set of true claims about the nature of the world and of the nature of humanity.
- 3.53** But you do have this synthesis problem between the Hellenic and the Hebraic. The Hebraic is focusing on a particular people at a particular place in a particular phase in history. Everything's to do with the particular. Same with the early Christians, in many ways. This particular person, not anybody else, it's this particular person who's the second person of the Trinity. Whereas the Greek mind is much more relaxed with universal reason, abstract principles, mathematics, geometry, timeless truths, especially after the conquests of Alexander the Great in the 330s and the 320s BC.
- 3.54** Alexander the Great covers more land at a greater speed than almost any other military figure in history. Quite extraordinary. So the Greeks, if you're born in, let's say, 350 BC in some Greek city-state, at that point, you're living in a world of Greek-speaking cities who are constantly killing each other and forging different alliances with each other, that covers like a tiny, tiny geographical span, barely the size of Arizona, significantly smaller than Arizona, in fact. As you grow up and hit your twenties, you're getting into the 320s BC. By that point, by the time Alexander the Great dies at age 33 or so, in 322 BC, the Macedonians, Alexander has conquered almost the entirety of the known world. And everybody thereafter will have to have Greek at least as a second language. It's quite extraordinary.
- 3.55** Some people have said that that's part of what explains the way in which, particularly the Stoics, the Stoic school of philosophers, had a view of morality as something that applies to all human beings. You go from this idea of there being a "polis," a city-state, to the idea of there being a cosmopolis, a world- or planet-state. We go from a world where it's just me and other Athenians, trying to fight and kill Thebans. We're all speaking Greek, but we're just all these little city-states up against each other, to suddenly, we've won the entire world. The entire world is now starting to speak our

language, and we're trading with them, and they're a little bit different, but they're basically the same. They want money, too, or they want good goods, and so on and so forth.

- 3.56** The idea of humanity being a universal category that somehow transcended your particular religion, your particular language, your particular location, this idea begins to emerge for the first time. You could say it's the point at which humanity is invented. Human beings become human beings. They stop becoming just Athenians or just Syracusans or just Phoenicians. "Oh, no, hold on. I mean, I do hate the Phoenicians, don't get me wrong, but they are people. We are somehow part of some other thing." Alexander's conquests made that cosmopolitanism, globalism, as it were, much more natural, much easier than it would have been otherwise.
- 3.57** But anyway, how did this marriage of two very disparate ways of thinking about history, how did they come together? Well, a key figure here is that of St. Augustine, St. Augustine of Hippo, who is born in 354 AD and dies in 430 AD. An extraordinary period to have lived through in the history of Rome, the late history of Rome, because in 410, when Augustine is in his mid-50s, Rome gets sacked. Really, for the first time since 753 BC, when it was said to have been founded, Rome fell in late August 410 AD.
- 3.58** It wasn't much of a fight. Rome, really, the western half of the Roman Empire, was exhausted at this point. Very poor defenses, but the Visigoths managed to get in very quickly, very easily. This is an extraordinary shock to the whole of the Mediterranean world. The accusations arose that this was all Christianity's fault because we're doing fine for a thousand years, and then one of our emperors gets into this cult. Suddenly, we all have to follow it, and all the Christians are in charge now, and the whole of the empire has now been baptized. Then Rome falls. The Visigoths come in, and it's all over. It must have been the Christians. It's the only thing that's been different in the last 100 years.
- 3.59** What Augustine does is, he sits down and writes, decides to answer this challenge, this criticism, in a work that runs to 22 books. It is the longest continuous prose text to have survived from antiquity. It's a huge, huge book. *De Civitate Dei Contra Paganos*. On the City of God, Against the Pagans, taking on these pagans who are criticizing, who are saying that it's Christianity that brought Rome down. I'm going to talk about two cities. I'm going to talk about the City of God, "*civitas Dei*," and I'm going to be talking about the earthly city, the "*civitas terrena*."
- 3.60** It's an extraordinary work. It's triggered by this criticism over the reason for Rome's fall, but it becomes a comprehensive philosophy of history. You might even say a comprehensive theology of history. He spends the first 10 books trying to refute the pagan claims that Rome was great because of all these pagan gods. He goes through these very amusing examples of how these pagan gods were actually not so great. These were not the gods you'd probably want to imitate.

- 3.61** And then he starts talking about this idea he develops of the two cities, writing about creation and fall and foundation, and how different cities get founded. He then makes some very interesting and startling claims that we've not really seen before in our other historians from the past. He says that there's within us, each of us, a citizenship of these two cities. Two loves have made two cities. "Fecerunt civitates duas amores duo." Human beings are driven by what they love, not by what they know, not even by what they desire, quite, but by what they love.
- 3.62** What human beings need to learn how to do is to rank and order their loves in the appropriate degree. You love God first and foremost because you owe your existence to God. You show love to your parents because of what they've done and their proximity and what they've done to bring you into the world. Or if they haven't done very much beyond that, the fact that they occupy the office of doing that, that's the function that they have had or ought to have had in your life, that's the reason they should be honored, even if there is no other actual reason for honoring them.
- 3.63** It's not about geography. It's about the orientation of our loves and our affections, what it is we love. It's not institutions, it's not money, it's not war or fear of war or love of honor, as we've seen up until now. No, but what we love, loving rightly and loving wrongly. He comes, and he sketches these two different cities. You've got the City of God, the "civitas Dei." This is a society of those who love God more than themselves. These citizens of this city are just pilgrims on the way through, "peregrini," off to the city of heavenly Jerusalem, the City of God. True homeland is heaven.
- 3.64** Then you've got the "civitas terrena," the earthly city, where it's the society of those who love self more than God. They desire and love temporal things that are here today, gone tomorrow, rather than eternal things that will satisfy eternally, says Augustine. These citizens worship creatures, rather than the creator of all creatures, and so on. It's Cain who founded this city. Cain, from Genesis 4, the first murderer. The first city-builder is the first murderer.
- 3.65** In Livy, when he tells the story of Romulus and Remus, it's not just a murder, but a brother killing a brother. This is this noble story of this terrible sibling rivalry, but this founding act of violence is what's going to make Romans tough. It's a very different way of thinking about things. Whereas Augustine is absolutely clear that you've got to be wary of the city-people, the city, the metropolis. Got to be wary of Cain and Babylon and Rome, and it's the cities that are the problem.
- 3.66** This is Augustine's vision. By the way, he's not saying that the City of God equals the church, and he's not saying that the earthly city is the state. In fact, he says, again and again, nobody knows who's a citizen of which city. This is a very important part of Augustine's City of God. You can't separate things. You're not God. You don't know who's the citizen of the heavenly place or the citizen of merely the earthly place. It's not for you to stipulate. You don't know what your citizenship is. So, act humbly and sparingly and forgivingly, and not knowing of every citizen what their ultimate

citizenship is going to be. So, we should all seek the welfare of the city that we are in, and all hope to be eventually citizens of the heavenly city.

- 3.67** In Augustine, we have a clear vision of the providence of history, that God, as it were, looks over the process of history, stands outside time. History is linear. It doesn't just go in circles. Christ dies once and once only. And that one time is maximally effective. Nothing more needs to be done. But on the cyclical view of history, then is Christ going to be crucified? Is the incarnation going to happen infinitely many times? No, because if it's happened once, it's happened definitively. These are arguments that are not going to impress a pagan theologian or a pagan philosopher, but this is what he argues.
- 3.68** Augustine's creationism, like his belief that reality was brought into being by God at a point in time, lends itself very naturally to a philosophy of history that says that there's a beginning, we're in the middle, and there are all these promises that God's made, so there's something happening at the end, and that's the structure. That's the structure of time, if you are in a creationist culture.
- 3.69** By creationist, I don't mean claims about young Earth creationism and the age of the Earth. I mean, in a broad sense, being part of a belief system which says all of reality is created in some way, whether it was billions of years ago, whether it was the Darwinian explanation is the right one or what, it doesn't matter. For Jews, for Christians, and for Muslims, there's this idea that time begins, history begins, and we're in the middle of it, and stuff's going to happen at the end. It's a technical theological term. Something is going to happen at the end. There's a start, there's a beginning, there's a middle, and the end.
- 3.70** Now, this may seem very natural to us, but it's actually not the norm for most history writing, or I should say, most cultures, some for whom the passing of time is simply an illusion, as you have in, say, Buddhist schools and many Indian philosophical schools. Or sense experience is an illusion, and that includes time. All history is a history of our illusions, so how could it matter?
- 3.71** You don't see in those cultures, you don't see great historians emerge. You see a few. You see great epics, as in the case of the Mahabharata in India, out of which the Gita is this extraordinary pearl, this extraordinary extract from the Mahabharata. But very little history as we would know, no real history as we would recognize it. It's conditioned by how they think about time. The genius of Augustine is that he thinks about time as a Jew might think of it, as somebody who's steeped in the time world and the historical world of the historical books of the Old Testament, but also as a Roman would think about it, would be thinking of it in terms of the city, how to run and structure a good city.
- 3.72** He's talking about the City of God. He's still talking like all good Romans in terms of being in a city and the proper ordering and functioning of a city. That's a very Roman, quite Roman and pagan, pagan concern, you might say. And there is randomness, as

you would have in Greek pagan historiography, because human beings are random and unpredictable, and odd things can happen. But also, Augustine is very insistent, God has overall direction, overall control over the direction of history, and sometimes in some of its very precise details.

3.73 So that takes us to the end of our third lecture. We've seen here, in this lecture, history is, you might say sacred—historiography through the lens of the sacred, as in the case of the historic books of the Hebrew Bible and the great figure of St. Augustine and his work on the City of God. In the previous lecture, we've looked at the very distinct Greek approaches to historiography. I've looked at some of the points of comparison, but most importantly, the points of contrast and the ways in which a figure like Augustine can integrate the two.

3.74 This sets us up very nicely to move into the High Middle Ages and slowly creep towards early modernity, 1600, 1700. We start to see historiography and historians writing in a much more self-consciously secular way, in a way that's much more recognizable to us today, even though many centuries separate us from them.

Lecture 4: Secular History

At a glance — Secular history.

- 4.1 Welcome to lecture four of this eight-part lecture series, Philosophy of History. In the first three lectures, we were really looking at the history of history. How did history begin? What's the history of history? Who first decided to sit down and self-consciously write, set about a project that we could nowadays call historical, an attempt to understand the past? Not just a chronicle, not just a shopping list of things that have happened in the past, but an account of the past that tries to make sense of the past, tries to understand why different things that have happened in the past, how that might affect our present, and how we might make cautious predictions about the future.
- 4.2 We looked in the first lecture at some of these big general questions: What is history? What counts as good history? What are the right methods? Is it a bit more like a science? Is it like a science where we're investigating the world—in this case, the past of the world—and then we make a big list of everything that we've seen and observed, and then that's history, like a science? It's slightly unusual science, but that's effectively what it is.
- 4.3 Then we looked at a rival view that said, no, that doesn't make any sense at all. History involves human beings, complicated agents with desires and beliefs and mood swings and illnesses. This is not the realm of just science. We're talking about human beings, persons. Persons don't behave the way that scientists want them to behave the whole time. They're unpredictable. So, it must be the case that history is more like a humanity than a science.
- 4.4 Do you remember, this is the battle that breaks out in the 19th century, when the German model of university is beginning to bed down, and the question is: How do you carve up knowledge? What's the appropriate map for human knowledge? Which areas belong in which neighborhood and so on and so forth? History is a difficult one, because we aspire to, in doing history, we aspire to a lot of scientific virtues, like accuracy and use of evidence and clear thinking and proper inferences and so on and so forth. So that feels like it's a science.
- 4.5 On the other hand, history involves, as I said, human beings, human persons who can't be predicted, where you can't make predictions in the way that a physicist can make predictions, or a cosmologist, or an astronomer can make precise mathematical conditions. That's just not how human beings work. This is why the phrase "social sciences" has emerged now. If you're doing economics, for example, economists would love to be seen as scientists, but they're not, because they're dealing with messy human beings who behave in unpredictable and irrational ways. It's like a science, but we'll call it a social science.

- 4.6 But any time a field of study calls itself a science, but it involves the study of human beings, be very, very cautious. Because the implicit claim, the implicit methodology is that we would treat human beings as objects of scientific inquiry, and we don't need to make any room at all for personal explanation or foibles or unpredictable characters and so on and so forth.
- 4.7 We looked at those big questions and then moved into, in the last lecture, in the third lecture, we looked at different ways of understanding what the historian's art is about, or what the proper task of the historian is. We looked at different versions of that. We looked at the Greeks—Herodotus, Thucydides, and Polybius. We looked at some Roman historians, Livy and Tacitus, in particular. Then we moved into a more theologically inflected world, particularly in the figure of Saint Augustine.
- 4.8 But I talked, too, about the historical books in the Torah, in the Old Testament, and how history is understood there as being something that's much more linear, much more directed towards one particular end, one particular horizon, and God is involved at every step of the way. In a particular, providential and broadly benevolent way, which is very different from the world of Homer, where the gods could be nice to you one day, and then they could zap you the next, and you just don't know. Maybe Zeus is having a bad day, or Hera's having a bad day, or whatever it might be.
- 4.9 Whereas the claim within the Hebraic world is that, no, there's a God who cares about this people and has these particular desires and intentions and aspirations and hopes for this people and will interact in some regular way, reliable, trustworthy way, with the processes of history to bring about this final end. Of course, the complication with Israel is that it is both a particular nation with particular rituals and beliefs and so on, but it is also a nation or a community, political community, that believes itself to be somehow the whole of humanity, or a light to lighten the Gentiles.
- 4.10 So, it is both very particular in its vocation as a people, but it's also got this universal vocation of being something for the whole world, and somehow representing in microcosm its stories, particularly in Genesis, its stories representing something that is true not just for Israel, not just for Israelites, but for all human beings. This is something in the grand sweep of the history of religion that is very unusual. Very unusual for there to be this universal scope to a religion. It's not just the in-group. This religion isn't just for the in-group; it's for all. That obviously affects the way in which history is told, the purposes of the historian.
- 4.11 What we're going to look at in this lecture is really the pivot into the modern world, when we're thinking about the writing of history and exploring what the historian is trying to do. We could say we're moving in some ways from a world in which the sacred is the most important thing, to a world in which the secular is the most dominant atmosphere, the dominant climate, from sacred to secular.

- 4.12 When that comes to history and thinking about history, you could say it's moving from providence, that is to say, God, "provideo," looking forward, overseeing, the courses, the flow of history, to a point where we might say it's not providence, it's progress. This is the God-free way of talking about time moving forward. Progress, capital-P progress, where progress is defined in a very specific, often in a very specific way, that reasonable people could disagree with, but it's a capital-P progress.
- 4.13 It's something that—a very clear idea of what's wrong at the moment and what could be better in the future, what the sunlit uplands look like, but they are earthly sunlit uplands, not heavenly sunlit uplands. This is the key difference as you're moving from the sacred to the secular. One advantage of thinking that you can never have earthly sunlit uplands, that it's always going to be a bit of a mess, and that the only chance you've got of sunlit uplands is heavenly sunlit uplands, if that's baked into the way you understand history, then, there are some downsides to it that I could think of.
- 4.14 But one big upside is that you're not ever going to dare to claim that you can build utopia down here, that you could build heaven on Earth. That would effectively be aspiring to something within a religious tradition that only God could bring about. There's always this check. As crazy as eschatology can sometimes seem to us, and all this debate between millenarians and post-millenarians and a-millenarians and all this sort of thing, in a way, the confusion and the energy is, as it were, outsourced to the life beyond. There isn't this sense that we can build paradise here on Earth. That's not the case with some of these 19th-century philosophies of history that treat progress as being this-worldly, that we need a revolution here and now in order to attain this particular paradise here on Earth.
- 4.15 We're going to have a look at this transition, and you can start to see at the end of the Middle Ages, as widespread belief in God begins to wane, and God as the author of history in particular begins to weaken and wane, other figures step forward. The Renaissance, which, let's say, begins in the second half of the 15th century, possibly a little bit sooner than that, let's say 1400—actually, it's well underway 100 years before that when Dante is working, is beginning to write the first cantos of the *Commedia*. But by 1400, it's well underway. And what's happening with the Renaissance is a rediscovery of the civilizational fruits and blessings of Greece and Rome.
- 4.16 That is partly, mainly, you might say, an aesthetic revival, so in terms of the buildings that begin to emerge in Rome and Florence and Venice and Naples at the time. The art, obviously, has themes—the topics that are chosen for art, broaden out and include all the classical options, but also in terms of texts, and particularly historical texts. Machiavelli, in addition, of course, he's most famous for writing *The Prince*, but he wrote this other fascinating book. In many ways, it's a deeper insight into how Machiavelli thinks and into his ideas.
- 4.17 He gets hold of Livy's history of Rome, *Ab Urbe Condita*, from the founding of Rome, from the foundation of Rome up to the present day, which is roughly up to the time of

Augustus in the 20s BC. Lots of it has been lost, but what's remained, and what remained in the Renaissance, was enough to really energize a new way of thinking about politics for Machiavelli. Machiavelli writes these *Discorsi*, Discourses on Livy, so reflections on this historian from 1,500 years ago, about the Roman republic, the rise of the Roman republic, that happened, when you're in the Renaissance, 2,200 years before, in the eighth century BC.

- 4.18** So, you think, clearly Machiavelli is up to something here. He understands that the history of Rome over that period, and the way Livy interpreted that history, has got things to teach Renaissance city-states now, 1,400-1,500 years later. "I'm going to write a whole work based on what's left of his histories, to try to understand and to try to shed light on our current predicaments." So it's extraordinary confidence in the power of history to help us understand human affairs and to operate better as a historical actor.
- 4.19** What also follows this phase, this rediscovery of ancient texts, is a way of thinking about history that begins to undermine the more providential, more theological narratives that dominated at the time. Then with the rise of the Enlightenment in the 1600s, you do start to have this push towards thinking about history strictly in secular terms, strictly through reason, putting a lot of confidence in human reason to understand the past. We get rid of revelation. We put reason there instead. They're seen as opposites. We don't talk about providence, we talk about progress. We think of history as a way to educate and usher human beings into the sunlit uplands of enlightenment, autonomy, reason, and rationality.
- 4.20** So you see these historians begin to emerge who are trying just that. Perhaps the most, one of the most well-known of these, a product of the Neapolitan Enlightenment—there are Enlightenments all over the place. There's one in Scotland, the Scottish Enlightenment. There's a German Enlightenment. There's a French Enlightenment. There's a Neapolitan Enlightenment. It's important to distinguish them because they're very, very different intellectual cultures.
- 4.21** I always try to encourage my students never to use the word "Enlightenment" without adding an S at the end, at least if it's a capital E. Because I don't like the term anyway. It's self-congratulatory. What comes before enlightenment? Darkness, darkness and death. That's certainly not true, as we know already. It's certainly not true of the world before 1600.
- 4.22** But Giambattista Vico attempts a comprehensive speculative analysis of the processes of history. It's very much centered on the human subject as a historical actor. He says that, because human beings are involved in the making of history, we've got a good chance of working out what happened and why it happened, because we're human beings, too. "Verum factum" is this famous phrase; the truth is what is made. "Verum," true, "factum," made.

- 4.23 We can know history because history is the history of other human beings, and we, too, are human beings. We know history because other human beings made history. That gives us an insight into history that the scientist doesn't have, the biologist doesn't have when he's studying dolphins. The biologist is never going to have access to what it's like to be a dolphin. But because when we're doing history, we do. I mean, yes, Caesar's probably not the person I'd have got on with in the pub, but he is a human being, and he's moved by probably fairly ordinary human desires and ambitions. Maybe the ambition has gone to his head a little bit, but I can still relate to, broadly understand this.
- 4.24 This person is not a complete mystery. No human person is ever a complete mystery to me because I am a human person. There's an awful lot that I'll have in common automatically, no matter the distance that separates us across time or the differences in circumstances that might obtain. There's still this basic, common human understanding perspective. History is more knowable than nature in that sense, because we've got this privileged access, as other human beings.
- 4.25 Vico comes up with a history of history, a meta-history, a history about history. He says there are three ages, and these three ages operate in a cycle, in a circle. It's a cyclical pattern. Do you remember with Polybius, the third century BC, a Greek-speaking historian of the Carthaginian wars, the three Carthaginian wars with Rome, he talks about in Book 6 of "anacyclosis," the cycle between monarchy to tyranny, to aristocracy, to oligarchy, to democracy, to mobocracy, ochlocracy. Then the cycle begins again, because you need a charismatic leader to come in and sort out the mob, and he becomes king, and then the king becomes a tyrant, and so you've got this circle. History moves in a circle.
- 4.26 Vico probably hasn't got this in mind, but there's something similar to his idea with the three ages, that they operate in a cycle. History doesn't go from A to B. It goes from A to B to C to B to A and around in a circle. So Vico says, in the first age, you've got the age of the gods, where theocracy appeals to sacred texts, appeals to high priests. These are what's authoritative in a community. It tends to be an age which is imaginative and poetic, probably the thinking of the Homeric world, the Homeric era.
- 4.27 Then, says Vico, there emerges an age of heroes, so aristocrats, figures that come to be mythologized for extraordinary acts of human strength, but they're mortals, warrior nobility, that kind of thing. Then, says Vico, you have the age of men, implicitly the weakest age of them all. It's democratic. Everything's rational, egalitarian. It may be the leftover of a monarchy, but this is where you end up: a big, flat, blank, equal plane. Eventually, this final third age, the age of men, dissolves and declines, and then the cycle begins anew. The cycle begins afresh. He thinks that history operates in these cyclical patterns.
- 4.28 But there's still a providential optimism in Vico. He still thinks that, despite all of the mistakes that are made along the way, despite the decline from the age of gods to the

age of heroes, to the age of men, that God's hand is still somehow at work to achieve a final universal order. We get this idea coming through quite a lot.

- 4.29 Adam Smith's invisible hand. It's interesting, Adam Smith, in the *Wealth of Nations*, it's a capital I for Invisible and a capital H for Hand, the invisible hand. What is this mysterious mechanism that harnesses our self-interest and our interest for ourselves and for our own, and transmutes it into benevolence, a benefaction for all, through the processes of the free and open market, with proper division of labor and so on and so forth?
- 4.30 How is it that human self-interest is coordinated to produce something that is good for all, that benefits all, that's in the interests of everybody? Hegel has a similar idea to this, too, that there's somehow, in history, there's a rationality or there's a wisdom that corrects human error. It's quite interesting. We'll come back to that.
- 4.31 So, just to put Vico on the table as a very important figure who's really doing the first meta-history, as it were, thinking about the history of history and how different, whether there could be patterns across different civilizations and empires and countries and so on, whether history has a pattern in that sense.
- 4.32 Vico, of course, is Neapolitan, writing in Italian. There is a continental tradition of historiography that differs quite a lot from what's going on in England and in Scotland at the time, but particularly in Scotland. It's very much the Scottish Enlightenment that is the engine room of the Enlightenment in the British Isles, not least because Oxford and Cambridge were, intellectually speaking, backwaters in the 17th and 18th century. There were one or two geniuses.
- 4.33 There's Newton, of course, but the University of Cambridge didn't really take up Newton's teachings and redesign the whole curriculum and syllabus around his new vision for particle physics and for matter in motion and the extraordinary revolutions that he even brings about. It's not part of the university's teaching until many, many decades later. Oxford and Cambridge are still quite stultified. They're quite siloed because of the obsessive commitment to particularly the classics, Latin and Greek, also to theology, and particularly the restriction on admission for both students and staff and dons to be professing members of the Church of England.
- 4.34 There was a filter there, which was not the case with the Scottish universities, which were already nonconformist, were already resisting the episcopacy, the bishop-led Church of England. And so, it was in Scotland that the Enlightenment really happened in Britain, not in Oxford, not in Cambridge. London, to some extent, some of the London coffeehouses are beginning to get going there. You have these amazing lunch clubs, for example, where a lot of these figures come together over long, drunken lunches and read each other's work to each other and are very rude to each other. But it was amazing how these different people would come together from different walks of life.

- 4.35 One of the people who enjoyed these long lunches was, arguably, the author of the greatest history ever written in the English language, and that is Edward Gibbon. Edward Gibbon is the author of not just the great history. He wrote a lovely little book called, I think, simply, *Memoirs*, where he describes the idea for this history coming to him and why he decided to set about it and so on. He starts work on it. The first publication is, fittingly, 1776. That's the year of publication: 1776. This will be a year that has some resonance for Americans who are watching this.
- 4.36 It has a huge importance to me as a Brit because it's the year that David Hume died. David Hume died in 1776. But that's not the only reason 1776 is an important year for the British. It's also the year that *The Wealth of Nations* was published. Adam Smith's *Wealth of Nations* was published in 1776. That's another reason it's an extraordinary year for us Brits. Thirdly, the third and final reason, which surely must be at the forefront of your minds, the third and final reason 1776 is such an important year for us Brits is because it is the year that marks the publication of the first of six volumes of Edward Gibbon's *The History of the Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*. Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire, that is, not any other empire.
- 4.37 It is an extraordinary work, when you consider the sources that Gibbon needed to access, the complexity, the logistical complexity of getting copies of these different manuscripts, of what was left of the historiographical achievement of ancient Rome, of the Romans. The history runs from the death of Marcus Aurelius in, I think that's 178-ish, 178, 180, all the way up to 1453, 1453 being the year of the fall of Constantinople at the hands of the Ottomans. That sweep is—for Gibbon, the death of Marcus Aurelius is where Rome is at its peak, and 1453 is the moment when Rome falls.
- 4.38 Now, you might say, "Hold on, last time I checked, Istanbul is not Rome. Constantinople is not Rome. Why should the fall of a city in Turkey mean that it's the end of Rome?" Well, because Rome was moved by Constantine. The capital of the Roman Empire was moved by Constantine in the 330s AD to Constantinople. He modestly named the new Rome, Me-City, Constantine City. Really, you could say the energy, the center of gravity, the engine room of the empire, moved from Rome in Italy to Constantinople in modern-day Turkey. So Gibbon sees Rome's history as the Roman Empire's history continuing beyond Rome, losing its place as a center of gravity.
- 4.39 His question, the question that animated the whole history, is simply this: Why did Rome fall? Why did Rome fall? In a funny way, it's the opposite of the question that Polybius asks when he's setting down to write his history of the three Carthaginian wars: Why did Rome not fall? How did Rome get so powerful? It could have been so many—if you were put at the beginning of the first Punic War in 263 BC, if you were just a proverbial alien that landed and said, "It's Carthage versus Rome; who's going to win?", you'd put your money on Carthage every time.
- 4.40 There's a vast, vast fleet, trading outposts all around the Mediterranean. Carthage itself is based in North Africa, controls the Mediterranean, the straits between North Africa

and Sicily. Carthage has got Malta. You've also got trading outposts that they've been laying in Spain and the south of France. Marseille, Massalia, is a Carthaginian colony. But the Carthaginians come from Tyre. They come from Phoenicia, which is the Levant, the Middle East. So they've got city bases there: Sidon, Tyre, etc.

- 4.41 So you would not put your money on the Romans, who had no fleet to speak of, no naval forces. Had really only shown themselves to be competent from a military point of view in settling local battles in Italy around Rome. And yet, this is what happens. Over that period, from 263 BC to the final annihilation of Carthage by Scipio Africanus in 146 BC, Rome rises to become the most dominant military and administrative force that the world had ever seen, certainly the Mediterranean world had ever seen.
- 4.42 And so, they're asking different questions. For Gibbon, if in Polybius, it's the rise of Rome, and for Gibbon, it's the fall of Rome. Why did it fall? And his answer, famously, is, Rome fell because of the triumph of barbarism and religion— barbarism and religion—which, when you read Gibbon, you might wonder why he uses two words there. For him, religion just is barbarism.
- 4.43 The arguments that he's making are not dissimilar to the arguments that St. Augustine seems to be replying to, in his masterly 22-book on The City of God. Remember, Augustine is saying, no, it's not because Rome's got Christianity that it fell so quickly after that. It's what Romans, what pagans took to be the splendid virtues, are in fact horrors, lead to horrendous outcomes and situations. Rome was decaying from within, morally, particularly. It's dominated by false religion, by religions which make no sense of human experience, and so on and so forth.
- 4.44 But Gibbon, as it were, it's almost like he doesn't really care about any of Augustine's arguments, saying this is Christianity. It undermines civic virtue. It has this focus on—it focuses too much on the next world at the expense of what's happening in this one. It's a very standard complaint, often made about religion. You're always in the departure lounge, and really, who cares what happens in the departure lounge? We're off soon. I don't need to keep it tidy or anything, that idea.
- 4.45 So, there is this waspishness in Gibbon's tone, which is a distinctively Scottish Enlightenment waspishness towards a folk-popular commitment to the truth of religious commitments, a disdain for superstition, a disdain for sentiment and feeling, probably, I think, in Gibbon's case, and a focus on facts and on reason and on orderly argument.
- 4.46 But I think what is most interesting about it is this idea that the thread that's woven through the entire history is one of decline. Everything's going down, down, down, down, down. We'll start to see more and more of these works, which are, as I said, examples almost of meta-history, because it's not just talking about particular historical phases, reigns of particular kings and queens, or battles or wars. It's saying that this is a grand thesis about the whole, as almost a civilizational narrative here that spans, as I

said in Gibbon's case, from 180-odd AD all the way up to 1453. So that's over a thousand years. He's saying that, throughout those thousand years, there is a particular story to be told, a story of decline.

- 4.47 So that's Edward Gibbon. There are lots of other very distinguished historians of this period, the 18th century, 19th century. But typically, the histories, the great histories are histories of Greece and Rome. You've got, obviously, Gibbon's great history of Rome from the second century AD onwards.
- 4.48 You've got the figure of George Grote. I've been reading quite a lot of George Grote recently. Grote produced a much more optimistic history than Gibbon's of the classical world. It was focused on not Rome, but Greece, the history of Greece in 12 volumes. It's enormous. It traces the rise of the different Greek city-states, but particularly the rise of Athens, the birth of democracy, the birth of the institutions that you need to sustain democracy, how it all worked, how it all collapsed, the horrors of the Peloponnesian War that he describes so brilliantly in Book 6 and Book 7 of his history.
- 4.49 The message throughout, really, is that the Athenians were the good guys. They were a bit misunderstood, and they have reacted with those genocides on the island of Milos and in Mytilene. But apart from that, they were benevolent, and they meant well, and they wanted to spread democracy around the Mediterranean. Democracy is a good thing. It's beneficial, it's rational, it's for all the people, not just lords and ladies. This is the thrust of his great history of Greece, Grote's great history of Greece— a history that is written around about the time of very, very delicate and difficult conversations that are happening in Britain about democracy.
- 4.50 In 1832, you have the first Great Reform Act, and then in 1867, you have the second Great Reform Act. What were the Great Reform Acts? An attempt to restructure British democracy so that, for example, certain constituencies weren't just being represented by a lord, a couple of peasants, and three cows, as was the case with some of these constituencies, the so-called rotten boroughs—rotten boroughs where you could just buy your seat in parliament, persuade the two peasants working your land, and maybe the three cows as well, to vote for you, and you've got your seat for life. There was a lot of that corruption going on.
- 4.51 And so, in 1832, there's this huge battle in the English Parliament, in Westminster, and eventually there's great resistance from the Lords, in particular from the House of Lords, our Senate, as it were, against this move. But it was pushed through, and the vote was opened up to a much, much wider range of people. Then, secondly, in 1867, something similar again, a huge expansion of the voting franchise to people who previously couldn't have it before, to whom it wasn't extended before.
- 4.52 You can see what Grote is doing. I'm not saying this is the only reason for him writing this big history that praises democracy and democracy's institutions in Athens and criticizes the oligarchies of Sparta and Sparta's allies. You can see that there is this idea

that the past, a history of the past, even if it's a history of a city-state, some city-state of a few tens of thousands of people from 2,500 years ago, that is important, important enough to do a 12-volume history on that sold incredibly well.

- 4.53** This is—doing history, even history this ancient, can teach us, can help us resolve disputes that are alive today. In Grote's case, the 1830 debates around the Great Reform Acts and what democracy meant, what the institutions of democracy meant, and how they should be reformed. Grote is a fairly obscure figure, but an important one in history in the 19th century in particular.
- 4.54** The final figure I wanted to mention in this context is that of Thomas Carlyle. Thomas Carlyle, who lived for many years in Chelsea, you can still visit his house today; it overlooks the Thames. Very complicated man, but brilliant, a brilliant writer, and very daring in his criticisms of what he saw as the forces driving the Industrial Revolution, the forces of mechanism, of utilitarianism, of bureaucracy, and more of a diminished way of thinking about society, a more reductive way of thinking about human beings in terms of economics, in terms of science, and so on and so forth.
- 4.55** His view, and his famous six lectures that he delivered in 1840s, on heroes, hero worship, and the heroic in history. It's a very interesting book. It's six lectures, six chapters, where he looks at different kinds of heroes—the hero as a poet, the hero as a man of letters, the hero as king, and so on and so forth.
- 4.56** He says that there are certain figures in history who show us how to be heroes, who show us that, actually, history is the biography of heroes, very often, of great men who seize the initiative. Yes, they need to be lucky, they need to be in the right place, they maybe need to be connected to the right circles, but it's individual genius in the end that is, really, what turns history.
- 4.57** So, in his lecture on the hero as poet, he talks about Dante and Shakespeare. Dante and Shakespeare are these heroic figures who expand the boundaries of what we thought was possible in terms of articulating the human condition, understanding the human condition.
- 4.58** The hero as king, he chooses Napoleon. Interesting choice, because was Napoleon a king? Well, no, they just got rid of their king. So they didn't want another king. They definitely didn't want another king. And Napoleon wouldn't have wanted to be their next king. So he gets himself crowned Holy Roman Emperor. And so, "Yeah, I'm not a king. I'm just the Holy Roman Emperor of France and everywhere else, everywhere else I can conquer." So he thinks Napoleon is one of these great figures.
- 4.59** And then he picks—this is another quite witty selection—Oliver Cromwell. Oliver Cromwell, who gave instructions and orders to execute pretty much the only monarch we've ever executed in Britain, Charles I, in 1649. Then Cromwell takes over, not as king, of course, but as protector because he's got rid of the monarchy. But anyway, Carlyle mischievously includes him in the hero as king lecture, because he thinks that

Cromwell displays a certain genius of personality, a charisma, energy, momentum, that managed to change the course of history.

- 4.60 He says, at one point, "All things that we see standing accomplished in the world are properly the outer material result, the practical realization and embodiment, of thoughts that dwelt in the great men sent into the world." This is the Carlyle picture of what drives history. He's reacting against, as we'll see in subsequent lectures, he's reacting against different currents there.
- 4.61 One is the current unleashed by Hegel, whom we'll talk about soon. For Hegel, it's not individuals that really change history. It's really, history has an inner rationale, an inner logic, an inner reason of its own, and it unfolds itself that way, through the processes of all, through all, or countlessly many causal processes, reason disperses itself, diffuses itself, and there's no real room for individual genius or agency.
- 4.62 Carlyle is also thinking about the Marxist view of history, where, really, you simply need to appeal to material forces, forces involving resources and scarcity of resources and ownership of resources, the ownership of the means and control of production. Who should be in charge of that? Effectively, history is just a history of struggle between classes.
- 4.63 On this view, individuals don't matter. Napoleon doesn't matter, Cromwell doesn't matter. They're simply puppets for much larger, deeper processes that are happening beneath the surface that we can get some sense of. But history just has got this—it's like a combine harvester that keeps on moving, and it doesn't really matter who's driving it. It might look as if Napoleon is driving it, but it's just moving no matter what.
- 4.64 Here, too, Carlyle is nervous about, both in Hegel and in Marx, he's nervous about the consequences of de-emphasizing the impact that brilliant individuals can have on the world, because this is a new way—you know, doing down heroes, or pretending there aren't any heroes, or pretending that great people can't have an impact on history, for good or ill, is a very unusual view before the 19th century.
- 4.65 What did the Romans do? If you go to school in the Roman Empire? For many, many, many centuries, you would be reading Plutarch's lives of the great men, lives of great Greeks, lives of great Romans, and he'd pair them together, and you'd read about their great—and that was what you studied. That's how you learned how to become a great — you want to be a great man? Study the lives of great men. That's what you do.
- 4.66 And the assumption there is always that great men, they don't make everything happen, but they are in the driving seat, in certain fundamental ways. Carlyle is trying to bring this view back, against the idea that no, no, it's, actual individuals don't matter, really. They're just offshoots of these deeper processes. There's an interesting debate going on there as to who's in the cockpit of historical change. Is anybody? Is it a who or is it a what?

- 4.67 One interesting figure that has quite a lot to say about how history works and what makes history change is the novelist Tolstoy. Anybody who's had the joy of reading *War and Peace* will know how much of that book is devoted to what you could only describe as philosophy of history. How does history happen? In particular, Tolstoy often goes off for pages and pages and pages about the meaning of history and what would have happened if X had done that, had he done that instead of that. What if Y had come in? Are there any patterns to history?
- 4.68 In fact, the epilogue of *War and Peace*, much of the last few pages of *War and Peace*, is devoted to this very philosophical discussion. Nothing about Pierre, nothing about any of the—nothing about André, just philosophy of history. And one of the conclusions Tolstoy seems to come to is that the trouble with historians is that they're always seeking a single cause when they're trying to understand history, as if there's just one explanation, and that will clarify everything.
- 4.69 For Carlyle, it would be great men. For Augustine, it would be God and providence. For Hegel, it would be "Geist" or the world spirit. For Collingwood, as we saw early on in the series—R. G. Collingwood— it's thought. History is just the history of thought, of men's thoughts. As he noticed, as Tolstoy notes, in Napoleon's case, Napoleon's definitely got a Napoleon complex, definitely. He has ambitions. He knows where he's going, and Corsica just isn't big enough for him. Then it turns out, Paris and France is no longer big enough for him, and so on and so forth.
- 4.70 The idea is, the Carlylean idea, is that it's Napoleon's genius and his foresight and his combination of abilities and skills, and yes, his good fortune and being in the right place at the right time, that that's ultimately what wins the battles, the great battles in the Napoleonic Wars, the Battle of Austerlitz 200 years ago, almost about 220 years. So, Tolstoy has these long, long discussions.
- 4.71 As he's talking about the Battle of Austerlitz, there is a very famous scene in the book. This is, supposedly, Napoleon's masterpiece. He planned it all beautifully. But then we know from reading the novel that there's fog, the orders don't get through, they're not obeyed, they're nothing. The first contact with the enemy completely shatters all the plans. There's confusion, randomness, different things happening to different people that were completely unexpected. Not a single column marches in the right order.
- 4.72 In what sense can you say Napoleon's in charge of this battle, of this victory, of this enormous clash? Like, he's got maybe some control and influence here and there, but at a point, once the battle starts, it's game over. I mean, you can't just keep controlling something like that. And Tolstoy's point is, Napoleon is claiming credit for what was never under his control, really. Victory comes from chance encounters, subordinate decisions, little local initiatives at the edge of it, all accumulating into a big power differential which eventually confers victory on the French. It's a mess.

- 4.73 There's no way that one person could have swayed that in either way. They could have had a contributory role in swaying it, made some key decisions here and there, but overwhelmingly, it will be chance, it will be something very contingent, something possibly very surprising. History moves through not one will or the will of a half a dozen charismatic heroes, but through millions of individual lives and decision-making processes. This is the Tolstoyan view.
- 4.74 No doubt that's why War and Peace is so damn long, because he's got to give us the perspective of every single one of those million wills, so that we can properly understand what's going on. It's why that book is so full of life, is so true to life because he's describing every aspect, every perspective one could possibly have from that period.
- 4.75 Hence, I can't remember who said it, but there's that quote that, "If life could write, it would write War and Peace." Because there's a sense that it's all in, everything's in there. There's no one single explanation for why what's happened has happened in War and Peace. It would be a much shorter book if Tolstoy did believe that, but he didn't. So he describes everything.
- 4.76 At this point, it's worth noting the importance of the emergence of a discipline within history, or certainly within ancient history, that changes the discussion in various interesting ways, and that is the birth of archaeology in, let's say, the second half of the 19th century. As with the science itself, you've got gentleman amateurs who've got a lot of money and go off, and they've dreamed since they were schoolboys of discovering Troy or Knossos, and the labyrinth of the Minotaur, whatever it might be. And in the late 19th century, these figures start doing just that.
- 4.77 It takes a while for it to bed down into a proper science, but most of them were amateur archaeologists, self-made businessmen. You think of Sir Howard Carter, who discovers the tomb of Tutankhamun in 1922. Or you think of the great Heinrich Schliemann, who makes a fortune in the California Gold Rush in the mid-19th century. But he'd been brought up with the wonderful stories, the tales of Troy and of the Odyssey.
- 4.78 He reads the Iliad again and again and says, "This is— Homer's geography and topography works." He says there's a mountain. If it's here, he says, there's a mountain up there, which it is. There's a river over there, which there is. Things have changed a little bit. The seas come out a lot, for example, but you can just about reconstruct. He arrives in Hisarlik, Turkey, which is very near Istanbul, and then he just bulldozes through what he thinks is an ancient mound containing traces of Western civilization going all the way back to 1500 BC. He carves his way through the middle with his team.
- 4.79 Sure enough, after much destruction, he finds this layered—the hill is layered on the inside like a cake, and several layers. He starts exploring them. To cut a long story short, Layer VIb is now widely considered by archaeologists and ancient historians to be the

Troy that fell to fire at some kind of siege, some violent, sudden end, because we can see, because there's traces of carbon, you can see that it suffered some cataclysmic fire-related destruction. We can carbon date that to around about 1150 BC, 1175 BC, the first half of the 12th century BC. We can get that pretty precisely.

- 4.80 This is an extraordinary find. I mean, this is roughly where we would put the Trojan War. If the Iliad is being written or the oral tradition that the Iliad is, begins to be written down round about 550 BC, it's probably well underway by 750 BC. The timing works, because here you've got legends that are remembered and embellished and enhanced, but of particular world-changing events and battles and conflicts, which the Homeric tradition would have been remembering from 300 years before, 300, 400 years before. That feels about right.
- 4.81 So this was an extraordinary breakthrough by Schliemann, to use history, the tools of history—in this case, the material tools of history, archaeology— to support a thesis that nobody thought was credible before that, namely, that the Iliad is not a myth, but a legend, like King Arthur. We know there was a King Arthur, but how much more do we know, and so on and so forth, but that there was a historical kernel to the Homeric tradition.
- 4.82 This helps history to become a more scientific discipline, certainly ancient history, being able to date things precisely using scientific devices, as with carbon dating. It's not an exact science, but it gives us a very good structure, scientific structure, parameters within which to make historical judgments. This is an important development, particularly as we come to look at the way in which material things affect, both reflect a society and how they shape a society through the techniques of science and technology.
- 4.83 To draw this lecture to a close, as we prepare to move on to one of the great figures in the philosophy of history, we've looked at lots of different ways of thinking about history, of thinking about the past, doing the past. We've looked at the theologically inflected approach in the Hebrew scriptures and in Augustine, where providence is key, is the key agent of change, you might say, in a way that doesn't abolish human freedom.
- 4.84 You've got the more pagan approach of Thucydides, which is a realist approach, like Ranke in the 19th century. With Herodotus, there's more credulity. He's going to be less skeptical of the strange things he hears. He's just going to write everything down, try to organize it around a central question, namely, how did the Greeks hold off the Persians, even though Persia was so much mightier?
- 4.85 We've seen also histories that are histories about large civilizational chapters in the history of humanity, like with Gibbon and the decline and fall of Rome over a 1000-year, over a 1200-year period. It's quite a decline, that 1200 years. It's not—so things must have been looking up at some point in those 1200 years, and so on and so forth.

Then we've looked at more—we looked at some of the British tradition in Gibbon, of course, but also George Grote, where there's much more of a stress on evidence, on sources, on verification, and so on and so forth.

4.86 All the way through, we've got these differences of approach in how to think about the nature of history. Is it linear? If it is linear, what direction is it heading in? What can we say about the ultimate destination? If it's providence, is it some eschatology? Is it something that revelation has to show us? If it's secular, well, maybe we can just bring about progress here on Earth, and we can bring about utopia on Earth, no matter what the price, no matter what the cost might be, and so on and so forth.

4.87 There's ways of thinking about how history is shaped, a lot of which will depend on non-historical judgments that you take about whether or not God exists, whether it's just humanity and not religion, whether evidence and sources does, in fact, matter over and above everything else. In fact, maybe the interpretation of the facts is at least as important, and so on and so forth. We'll continue to look at these themes as we move on to the next lecture, and we explore the extraordinary development of historiography as a discipline, and in particular, the extraordinary explosion of different perspectives on what counts as the philosophy of history.

Lecture 5: Hegel & History

At a glance — Hegel and history.

- 5.1 Welcome to lecture five in Philosophy of History, an eight-part lecture series in which we are looking at the very meaning of history, what is history, how should we understand what we're doing when we're inquiring into the past? In this lecture, we're going to do something quite unusual. We're going to devote most of our attention to a single figure.
- 5.2 That figure is known to be one of the hardest philosophers ever to have put pen to paper. What makes it even worse is that he decided to put pen to paper and write in German. German, at the time, the beginning of the 19th century, is not a language, shall we say, that lends itself naturally to philosophical expression. It's still a very young language. It doesn't have the range and subtlety of Greek yet, or of Latin, or indeed French. He is a notoriously difficult thinker, notoriously difficult writer to understand. But his impact on the philosophy of history, on how we understand history, is enormous, greater than, I think, any other philosopher in history. I think that is a fair claim.
- 5.3 I'm talking about Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, H-E-G-E-L, Hegel. Born the same year as Wordsworth, William Wordsworth, the Romantic poet, in 1770, and he dies in 1831. Think of those dates. He lives through one of the most extraordinary chapters in the history of Europe. In the 1770s, what's happening in the 1770s, the French Revolution is beginning to brew, and with the extraordinary seismic effects and impact that the French Revolution is going to have, not just on France, but on all of Europe, in the 1790s. Then it gets so bad, they have to bring in not a king, but an actual emperor, in Napoleon. Then the Napoleonic Wars begin. We have Austerlitz in 1805 and Trafalgar in 1805, the Battle of the Nile in 1798, the march on Moscow in 1812, and Napoleon's final defeat on the battlefields of Waterloo in June 1815.
- 5.4 We see also in this period the emergence of crucial institutions of higher learning in Germany. In 1810, the University of Berlin is founded, a new kind of university that's structured in a different way from Oxford and Cambridge and all the medieval universities. We have all these different colleges dotted around, and it's the basket of colleges that is the university. In this new German model, you have a campus, you have faculties, and then you might have halls of residence off the side, but it's a unified university structure.
- 5.5 This is the German Protestant Berlin model, a model which is, broadly speaking, the model that we now use in Britain, is used in America. This supplanted the medieval structure. Hegel was a very important figure in the early history of the University of Berlin. A lot of his lectures on history, for example, are lectures, rather than books. They're just transcripts of lectures that he delivered at this new university.

- 5.6 Why are we spending a whole lecture on this difficult figure? Well, because every major question that we are asking about history these days is either framed in a Hegelian way or is very often given a Hegelian answer. I wanted to spend some time in this lecture getting to understand who Hegel was, what his ideas were, so that we can see where his fingerprints are today. You can understand it tracing back to this figure, and therefore, you can understand those ideas or points that have been made with Hegel's fingerprints on them much, much better.
- 5.7 Does history have meaning? Hegel's answer is, yes, it does. But history is neither random, but nor is it scripted by God. But history is still meaningful. Does history progress? Do things get better over time? Can we look forward to things in the future, just because they're in the future? Hegel says, yes, progress is possible. Progress towards freedom is possible, indeed inevitable. Can we know the laws of history? Are there any laws of history, principles that history unfolds by? Hegel also thinks that there are, that there are these dynamic principles, dialectical development of, a back-and-forth of ideas that gradually resolves itself and then provokes another tension and it resolves itself again. And that's the dynamism, that's the motor of history.
- 5.8 Has history ended? Hegel says, yes, it ended with the French Revolution. It ended in 1789 by this moment of freedom, that the French Revolution, this taste of freedom from kings, from priests, from aristocrats. This is a moment of— this is the end of history, as it were. He really did think that.
- 5.9 What's driving history? What is the role of individuals in history? All of these questions are ones that Hegel takes up and gives very particular answers to. What he thinks is driving history is just reason itself. Not God, not randomness, but reason itself, capital R. Individuals, like Napoleon or Cromwell, aren't great actors. They're not engine rooms of history. They're instruments of reason, instruments of the world spirit, "Weltgeist," world spirit.
- 5.10 This is Hegel's extraordinary claim, that reasoning about history is what historians think they're doing: they're studying the past, thinking about the past. In a theological context, reason is guiding history. God is guiding history. His hand is on the tiller, as it were. He's the helmsman of history. Hegel rejects both of those. We're not reasoning about history. This isn't reason guiding history. Reason is in history. We can see reason. We can see rational principles at work in the very unfolding of history itself. It's a very striking idea, this.
- 5.11 Trying to think of an analogy here, and the one I settled on was, imagine a jigsaw puzzle. We think of history as a completed jigsaw puzzle. Being at the end of history, you can see the completed jigsaw puzzle. The individual pieces of the puzzle will look odd, random, or if it's a good puzzle, they should look—they should be unique in their shape. The colors won't make sense. They won't be—it's very difficult to see how this piece fits in. But as you assemble the pieces, slowly a picture begins to emerge, and you can start to make sense of it.

- 5.12** The point here is that the pieces, though they look random—an individual historical event or a great battle or the assassination of somebody, these are historical events. It's hard to see how they make sense as history. But once they're slotted into the larger puzzle, they contribute to the rendering intelligible of the jigsaw.
- 5.13** And so, Hegel's idea is that, if you just take one event in isolation— the fall of Rome in 476, question mark, the invasion of Russia in Operation Barbarossa in June 1941—these are big events, but when you look at them in isolation, then it's like holding one puzzle piece. You can't see where it's all going to fit in. It can seem arbitrary, it could seem tragic, it could seem to have no meaning, to be completely senseless, but once it's slotted in, then you can start to see the intelligibility. You can start to see the relationship between all these different events.
- 5.14** This is roughly what Hegel means by his famous phrase that "the real is the rational, and the rational is the real." The real is the rational, and the rational is the real. The pieces of the jigsaw are pieces of real history, snapshots of real history. It doesn't look as if there's any rhyme or reason to it until you've slotted the piece into the jigsaw. Then you can see that what's real, a chunk of history, is also rationally embedded into this mosaic, this jigsaw puzzle, that forms a clear, comprehensive picture or narrative.
- 5.15** So history is not random. It has an internal coherence. It's not being guided from the outside by God, as it were; the reason is in the jigsaw pieces, wired into the jigsaw pieces. The real is the rational, and the rational is the real. These are coterminous. There isn't a God outside overseeing things, but nor is it a completely random, arbitrary sequence of events. You can make sense of history. The point is, the pattern exists in the pieces themselves, not in us imposing the pattern, but in the pieces themselves. Nor do we need to consult revelation for what God wants to be the case in history, because there's no God here at all. It's just the rational that is folded into the jigsaw pieces.
- 5.16** This is a very interesting development in the philosophy of history, because it seems to imply that history has a direction or an intention, really, of its own, that reason is somehow not something that is completely placeless, not something that is completely unanchored in something, that people are rational. Persons have reason. In personal processes, it's very hard to see how they can be rational.
- 5.17** If you see rocks suddenly arrange themselves into a special pattern saying, "Welcome to Sedona Valley," you're going to be suspicious that the rocks just happened to fall into that perfect configuration, such that they could convey a rational thought to you or a rational welcome. We immediately infer that some person has been involved in this communication of reason. It's a puzzling position, in lots of ways. But it's a very important one, not least because of the influence that Hegel had later on.
- 5.18** It turns out that a few people could understand him. The trouble is, they were all the worst people. I'm afraid I include Karl Marx in that, in that category of worst people,

worst interpreters of Hegel. Because part of Hegel's argument, or the part that Marx really latched onto, was the way in which, as the jigsaw puzzle becomes clearer, as the picture on the puzzle becomes clearer, what do we see? What is it that we see, for Hegel?

- 5.19** Well, what we see for Hegel is a society in which freedom is maximized, a society in which the human being, the individual, is liberated. In many ways, this is a very classic Enlightenment narrative of the self being able to throw off all the shackles that was holding human beings back from massacring tens of thousands in one day at the guillotine. Church and monarchy, and traditions, and customs, and aristocracies, and so on and so forth. This was cramping the style of the free human agent. Emancipation is the great Enlightenment ideal—emancipation even from the most basic relational connections that we might have to one another.
- 5.20** Hegel does make a lot of this. He has this famous parable, you might say, the master-slave dialogue, which is in the opening of his famous work, the *Phenomenology of Spirit*. I told you it wasn't easy. *Phenomenology*, *die Phänomenologie*. Let's try that again. *Die Phänomenologie des Geistes*. *Geistes*. The *Phenomenology of the Spirit*, or of *Spirit*. What on earth does that mean? *Phenomenology*, the word comes from the Greek meaning "to appear." So, it's really the appearance of the spirit, this principle of reason, in the processes of history.
- 5.21** In this famous parable, he talks about the master and the slave, the master and the serf. It's a very complex passage, but I'll do my best to explain it to you. These twopersons begin a relationship, a working relationship. Each recognizes the other. The slave recognizes the master as the master, and the master recognizes the slave as the slave. Part of what makes the master realize he's the master is the fact that he's got a slave. So knowing he's got a slave, it says something about him.
- 5.22** Immediately, a thought about the other bounces back into a thought about him. "If he's the slave, that means certain things are true about me." And the same in the other direction. The slave looks at the master and says, "I know my place. There are things I know about my place because of who he is." So there's a reciprocity here. And in fact, to be the master, the master needs a slave. What's he the master of, if he hasn't got any slaves? What's the slave, if the slave hasn't got a master? So they need each other.
- 5.23** This is Hegel's view. They need each other to be each other. Their identity is in this social relationship. Over time, the master becomes more and more dependent upon the slave, because the slave is doing more and more, is more and more diligent. As the slave gets more and more diligent, is entrusted with more and more responsibilities, he likes it. This is good for him. This invests his life with even more meaning. He's beginning to taste independence, or more independence than he had before. The master is beginning to taste dependence more and more. "I'm so free. I've got this slave who can do anything that I need."

- 5.24 He's been doing it for years. The slave has been doing it for years. And what would happen if the slave died tomorrow? What would happen to the master? So there's growing independence on one side, says Hegel, growing dependence on the other. And there is this life and death struggle. At least, life and death for the master, at least being a master, looks like the death of him being a master is around the corner, and the death of the slave being the slave is also around the corner because the things are changing.
- 5.25 Over time, says Hegel, there emerges a complete role reversal. The slave becomes truly free, and the master becomes trapped in dependence, and the tables are completely turned, and effectively, it's the slave calling the shots. The slave is, in effect, now the master, and the master is now the slave.
- 5.26 Hegel says, what's driving this breakdown, this reversal, in the relationship? Is it God, puppeteering it from the outside? Is it just random material processes, as Marx would say? No, says Hegel. This is just the ordinary inner logic and reason of how two human beings can interact with each other, or you could say, two representatives of two human institutions, the household and slavery, how they interact and how they change over time and become something different. Hegel thinks that this is something that you can extrapolate across history.
- 5.27 You might say the French Revolution, the execution of the bourgeoisie, the elimination of the aristocracy, sees that the master is thrown off, thrown away; the slave emerges forward with the revolutionaries, comes to the fore. But then that starts to break down, and by the end of the decade, they've got an emperor. The master's back. They couldn't cope with all that independence. This is a central idea in Hegel, not just that the rational is the real, that history works according to internally rational principles, but also that it's geared towards freedom or emancipation, independence as some final destination and outcome.
- 5.28 He famously writes a set of lectures on the philosophy of history, delivered in the 1820s when he's at the University of Berlin, but published in the late 1830s. It's quite difficult sometimes making sense of these lectures. They're based on lecture notes and student transcriptions and so on and so forth. But it really represents his mature thought, his final settled views towards the end of his life, just a few years before he dies in 1831, on what the meaning of history is.
- 5.29 His central claim is, "Die Weltgeschichte ist der Fortschritt im Bewußtsein der Freiheit." World history is the progress of the consciousness of freedom, "Bewußtsein der Freiheit." And this is the idea that there is a dynamic development to world history, and progress, what counts as progress, doing better over time, is the increase of history—or rather the increase in freedom, or rather the consciousness of being free, the awareness of being free.

- 5.30 He's got this idea of, there are three stages in human history. You start with the Oriental phase, which he thinks is a despotic phase, where everybody is slaves except one person, to the Greco-Roman structure of society in history, where many are free, but many are also slaves, to this third phase in history, which Hegel attributes to the Germanic, or at least the Christian world, where all in principle are free, that the birthright of every human being is freedom. He thinks that there's a world history that can be understood in those terms, from despotism to demi-despotism to freedom, to total freedom, at least freedom in principle.
- 5.31 This is an extremely influential idea, the idea that reason is working within history. Remember, Hegel isn't just saying that the thing about the puzzle is that it's solvable. He's saying the puzzle pieces themselves are reason assembling itself. Reason fits itself together in these different—history fits itself together in these different rational pieces. It's not us doing it, and it's not us who's designed the puzzle. And so, he talks about how it's possible for reason to peep through and to tweak human mistakes.
- 5.32 And he talks about "die List der Vernunft", the cunning of reason. He thinks reason has a certain cunning in the way it moves history forward. He thinks that reason can harness the passions, the desires, the ambitions of particular individuals, and as it were, press them into the direction that it needs them to go in. Reason can use the passions and feelings and desires as instruments in this cunning way.
- 5.33 And so, each piece, you might say, each piece of the jigsaw, might think it's this or that, it's blue or it's green, or it's a piece of a garden or a piece of a mountainscape, but the pieces contribute to the overall jigsaw in a way they don't themselves know about, they've got no consciousness of, you might say. He gives lots of examples of this—Caesar and Luther and Bonaparte, achieving lots of different things.
- 5.34 Hegel's point is that these are, there are these world historical individuals. So he agrees with Carlyle on that. You do get these heroic figures who seem to change an awful lot. But they do it unknowingly. They're not aware of themselves doing it. They are, as it were, at the mercy of the processes of reason assembling itself in history, using them in all kinds of cunning ways, including knowing that they'd like to think of themselves as key figures on the historical stage. But that's the wrong way to look at it. It's the wrong way to consider it, says Hegel.
- 5.35 One of the points he makes is that, once these individuals leave the stage, once they're used by history, they're simply discarded. That's it, it's over. Caesar's assassinated. Napoleon's exiled, twice. Luther's excommunicated. Once their objective is attained, says Hegel, they fall aside; "they fall away like empty husks," which suggests that their significance, their meaning, was only relevant insofar as it contributed to the processes of history. What happened? It's not them. It's the role that they played, the way in which they were folded into the jigsaw puzzle. That's the only point that matters, says Hegel.

- 5.36 He also writes in his book, a great work, *The Philosophy of Right*, 1821, he says famously that "the owl of Minerva spreads its wings only with the falling of dusk." The owl of Minerva spreads its wings only at the falling of dusk, only when dusk arrives. The owl of Minerva is a symbol of Minerva, the Roman name given to the goddess Athena. And what is the goddess Athena, the goddess of? Most notably, the goddess of wisdom, of "sophia." The owl of Minerva, that is to say, wisdom itself, philosophy, can spread its wings like the owl, only when the sun's going down.
- 5.37 What does this mean? I told you, it can be difficult to understand. Well, what he seems to have meant is that you can only start being wise about something, you can only start spreading your wings as the owl of wisdom, as the wise owl, or the philosopher can only start getting to work on some subject matter, when the dust has settled, when the sun has gone down on a topic. And what Hegel seems to have meant is that you can't really think about history until it's done, it's over. You can't really think about a period of history until it's done, it's over, and actually, probably, the dust has settled for a few decades. Then you can go back to it.
- 5.38 This is his view. He thinks that philosophy can comprehend what has happened, but it can't prescribe what ought to be the case in the future. It can only understand what is, what has happened. You can only understand the puzzle once it's complete. The philosophers can only start contemplating the jigsaw puzzle when every piece is in place. Wisdom is backwards-looking, not forwards-looking. It's retrospective. You can apply wisdom to the past. You can't apply wisdom to the future.
- 5.39 Why not? Because the future doesn't exist. You can't apply anything to what doesn't exist. It's a note of caution in what Hegel is urging there. We shouldn't have utopian dreams and blueprints of what the future could be like, because we don't have any understanding of it yet, and we're not part of the reasoning that operates within the jigsaw puzzle. And one needs to be cautious.
- 5.40 Hegel, in the 1820s, is quite a conservative thinker in lots of ways. What he's saying about institutions, the nation state, the family, caution in coming up with grand political schemes that will bring a lot of turmoil with them for a limited upside, or at least an upside we can't predict, we can't understand, because we can't predict the future and so on and so forth, which is very different.
- 5.41 It's kind of surprising that Hegel also had a huge influence on the so-called left Hegelians, Marx included. But there are right Hegelians as well. There are left-wing ways to interpret Hegel, and then there are right-wing ways to interpret Hegel, depending on which text you take from which points in his career. If you're taking the left-wing reading, you're dealing with, really, Hegel as a young man, still very immature in lots of ways. If you're taking the right, more conservative approach, you could say this is him in his settled maturity. There's no way he would have got on very well with Karl Marx. But that's a judgment that I can leave to you.

- 5.42 So he has this deep commitment to big history, meta-history, this idea of being able to see not just the history of the last few decades in his part of Europe, but world history. He's able to think about different civilizations, and why different civilizations came after each other, and why some lasted for a long time, others didn't last for a long time. Can you see a pattern emerging in the sequence of different civilizations that come along?
- 5.43 This starts a tradition, and there are other thinkers that we'll be looking at later, people like Oswald Spengler, Arnold Toynbee, figures who are writing these big world histories with great claims about the way in which history is developing. Again, Hegel recovers this idea of there being an Oriental phase where human beings are in their tutelage, or it's a kind of childhood, you might say, a childhood of humanity, no individual freedom, static, unchanging empires, despotism. Here, he's thinking of Persia, of Egypt, of China, of India, whether that's fair or not. That's how he thinks about it.
- 5.44 With the emergence of the Greek world, you can see that, he says, is humanity coming into its teenage years, into its youth. You've got this gradual dawning of democracy and the importance of individual freedom, of equality, of freedom of speech, of freedom of association, stress on beauty—beauty as being something that is public, not just the display of the power of one man, something that can enhance an entire common life. There's a basic harmony between the individual and the city-state, a relationship of harmony between the individual and the community. So he thinks this is humanity in its teenage years, in its youth.
- 5.45 Then, with the Roman world, humanity comes of age, has its 21st birthday party. That would probably be, I don't know, the murder of Caesar in 44 BC, the moment humanity comes of age, and Rome becomes an administrative imperial state. Humanity turns to the universal, to order, to might, to raw violence, control on violence. The law starts to have a crucial role, legal personality.
- 5.46 Then, says Hegel, that gives way to a certain unhappiness, bureaucracy, a mechanized state. It's vast, it's abstract, it's overwhelming. It's at this point, says Hegel, that Christianity emerges, which solves the problem that nobody had solved before, namely, how can you have universality, how can you have an embrace of the universal, without erasing the role of the individual and the importance of individual freedom? How do you balance this, the collective versus the individual?
- 5.47 Hegel says that Christianity has an obvious answer to this. It prizes and elevates the dignity of all human persons, and it ascribes individual freedom to them as a hallmark of what it is to be human. But precisely because this is how human beings are universally understood, not just Romans, not just Athenians, etc., this is the truth about human beings, this has universal implications for what it is to be human and how being human is to be valued and understood, and the centrality of freedom to what it is to be human, the centrality of reason to what it is to be human. And so, humanity is coming of age quickly here, coming into middle age, I guess, with Christianity.

- 5.48 Then finally, over the course of the 300, 400 years running up to Hegel writing his philosophy of right in the lectures on world history in 1820s, he thinks you have these shuddering moments. The Protestant Reformation is a moment of acceleration towards individual freedom, the freedom of every European to be able to read the Bible in their own language, for example; the freedom of every Christian believer to have access to the sacraments without that access being mediated by an institution. So he thinks the Protestant Reformation is a very important moment.
- 5.49 Then he thinks the French Revolution is a very important moment in this history of the emergence of individual freedom. Now, you might think, any history that has the Protestant Reformation, followed by the French Revolution, as somehow connected, you think, what on the Earth is going on there? One is a very, very religious, attempting to be an extremely authentic religious movement, going up against a religious institution that has lost its way, as in the case of the Reformation. The other just wants to wipe out all religious institutions, in the case of 1789, the French Revolutionaries.
- 5.50 How could those two have anything to do with each other? It'd be like picking up two jigsaw pieces and saying, "These can't be part of the same jigsaw because they showed such different scenes on them. They can't be part of the same jigsaw." And Hegel says, no, they really are. The Reformation is the quest for individual freedom, and partly successful, partly not successful. And the French Revolution, too, is an attempt by reason, working through the cunning of reason, working through the wills of a million people. It's also an attempt to seek rights, freedom, dignity for the individual, for all individuals, except the ones whose heads they're about to cut off, presumably. Freedom of sorts, I suppose.
- 5.51 But he sees this as just another chapter in the slow emergence, that slow quest for freedom, and so on and so forth. Then you can fill in the blanks. There'd be all sorts of moments of emancipation. Think of the 1807 Abolition of the Slave Trade Act, passed in Britain, followed up by the Slavery Abolition Act in 1833. Or you think of the Great Reform Acts, 1832 and 1867, expanding the franchise to people beyond the property-owning classes, to women, to the working classes, and so on and so forth. You think of the civil rights movements, for example, in America in the 1960s or in South Africa in the 1990s.
- 5.52 These, for Hegel, would all fit into the jigsaw puzzle, the history of the gradual emergence of individual freedom. And so, history is moving in a particular direction. It's rational. We can understand it. We can understand parts of it. Even if we can't see the whole jigsaw, we can see parts of the jigsaw. But this is a radically different way of thinking about how history happens, how it develops.
- 5.53 A lot of it is developing, in Hegel's view, through contradictions, through fruitful generative tensions between different ideas, between different states. For example—and he sees this everywhere, he sees this even in aesthetics, he sees it in art— so for example, in Greek thought, the idea of freedom goes along with or emerges from a

culture that's perfectly happy with slavery. How is it that a community like Athens gives birth to this extraordinary idea of radical democracy, freedom of speech, "isegoria," equality before the law, "isonomia," and a boldness in speech to contribute to democratic deliberations, "parrhesia"?

5.54 How is it that this very community depended upon slaves to free up their time for them to be free to exercise their rights as freeborn citizens in the democratic assembly? The dependency ratio is about two or three to one. So for every Athenian citizen, every Athenian male above the age of 23, born to Athenian parents, for every one of those, there'd be two or three slaves. It was an enormous industry. Hegel says that we've got a contradiction here. This is an obvious contradiction.

5.55 Or you might think of the fact that Thomas Jefferson owned slaves on the day that he wrote, helped to write, the Declaration of Independence, those extraordinary words. Hegel says: How does this work? This is a contradiction. Reason can't put up with this contradiction. Contradictions like this will therefore have to be resolved over time. They are resolved over time, says Hegel.

5.56 Slowly, as Greece gives way to Rome, then you have a more universal picture of what it is to be a human being, certainly after the conquest of Alexander the Great, where Alexander the Great conquers so much of the world so fast, that Greece goes from being the language of a little backwater in the eastern half of the Mediterranean, to being the language of the world, the language that everybody had to speak. If you weren't born speaking it, it would have to be your second language, or you were not going to get by in the post-Alexander world, because he'd conquered so much, and he hadn't, just the Mongols, flattened everything.

5.57 He'd founded cities: Alexandria—not a modest man. Not multiple Alexandrias all across the world, but in particular, the one in Egypt. These become centers of enormous cultural and civilizational significance, particularly Alexandria, which becomes 200, 300, 400 years after Alexander dies, the great teaching centers, one of the great university centers in the Mediterranean. Athens had become more of a backwater by this point.

5.58 But the library and the "Mouseion" in Alexandria, which was this huge library and, you might say, research center, spa, like a research spa, so scholars from all over the world could make their way to Alexandria and be in the Mouseion, literally the building that belongs to the Muses, the Muses' building. Whichever of the nine Muses you're most into, this has been an extraordinary place for brilliant minds to come together from all over the Mediterranean world.

5.59 For Hegel, these developments in history, Greece giving way to Rome, the stress that the Greeks had on what's particular, shifted to the Romans' picture of what was much more universal, post-Alexander also; it's not just about us being Athenians, it's about us being part of this much, much bigger thing. We're not just citizens of a city now, we're

citizens of an empire. Are there other empires? How do they relate to each other and so on and so forth?

- 5.60** And then in turn, the Roman phase gives way to a baptized view, a Christian view of how to hold the particular and the universal in balance. The particular individual bears the image of God and therefore is freighted with a special dignity. But that is something that applies to all in virtue of not just being a citizen of a particular state or a subject of a particular empire, but just by being part of the human family, part of a creature created by God. And so, your class distinctions or your ethnic or national distinctions or religious loyalties are, effectively, irrelevant at that level.
- 5.61** So this dialectic of history keeps on moving through Christianity, institutional Christianity, to reformation in the 16th century, to revolution in the 18th century, and so on. And so there's a pattern, says Hegel. There's a moment of unity, of coming together, and then there's a moment of division and warfare and conflict and revolution. Then there's a reunification again. This is how history moves forward. Like the puzzle, almost like the pieces get scattered, put them back together again, the picture becomes visible, and so on and so forth.
- 5.62** It's a brilliant achievement in lots of ways. Hegel's achievement; it's not secularizing history. It's still saying that there's meaning in history, there's reason in history. It's not just one damn thing after the other. It's not just random. History makes sense. We can read history books, and they make sense to us. How did that happen for no reason, immediately after this happened? So there's an internal reason to it, says Hegel.
- 5.63** But we don't need to be theological about it. We don't need to say that there's a divine puzzle-maker up in the sky who's crafted the puzzle and dropped the different pieces into our laps and told us to get on with it. No, the puzzle is the puzzle. It is what it is. It makes itself. It forms itself. It puts its own pieces together, as they are meant to be slotted together. Hegel's genius is that he doesn't just apply this to politics and to institutions. He applies it to art. He applies it to religion, and he applies it to thought itself, to philosophy.
- 5.64** The significance of this is that it's brought back a way of thinking about history as linear, as moving in a particular direction— the beginning, a middle, and an end—in a way that doesn't seem to rely on what are today contentious claims about this being God's providence unworking itself in history. God's narrative is unfolding here. The influence that Hegel has, this idea that history can come to an end, that it's just mopping up now after the French Revolution, freedom is fully out of the— freedom is free now. There's no way of putting it back in its straitjacket. That's the idea, the end of history has come, the final flowering of freedom has happened in 1789.
- 5.65** It's ironic that, 200 years later, after 1989—you have 1789, the French Revolution—in 1989, the collapse of the Soviet Union and the collapse of communism, which is a symbol for many in the West of tyranny, of opposition to freedom, of subordinating

individual freedom and the individual will to the collective, to abstract utopian economic schemes that don't ever seem to be able to actually work.

- 5.66** A very interesting book is written in 1991, 1992, by Francis Fukuyama, called simply *The End of History*. Fukuyama's point is that with 1989, the end of the Cold War, the long 20th century has finally come to an end. Liberal democracy has won, and that's it. That's the end of history. I mean, obviously, things are going to keep happening, we hope, for a long time, but there won't be any more history. Nothing interesting is going to happen because liberal democracy has won.
- 5.67** It's quite true of the 1990s. I was growing up as a teenager in the 1990s, and I do remember that feeling of, yeah, politics is over. It's really just a bit of—you need a little bit of expertise here and there on the economy, and need somebody probably at the bridge, tweaking the wheel occasionally. But really, history is over. The enemies of history, the enemies of reason, the enemies of freedom, have lost.
- 5.68** It's now self-evident that liberal democracy is the only way, really, to achieve maximum human flourishing. And so, we can say history is over. Hegel was just 200 years early. We can't blame him. We shouldn't blame him for everything. Not far off, but it's actually 1989, not 1789. Fascism is over. Communism is over. Our side won. Our side is obviously the right side. Our victory is total. Our victory is total.
- 5.69** Now, it turned out history wasn't actually all that over. Things kept happening, and the things that kept happening were very interesting and seemed to be nothing if not world historical in significance. Most of us who were around will remember where we were on the 11th of September, 2001. I remember exactly where I was, and I remember thinking, "This is a historical— this is big," is probably what was my thought. "This is big," by which I meant probably, "This is of—Hegel would really think that this is an event of world historical significance here." This isn't just two buildings. This isn't just any random collection of 3,000 victims. This is going to shape the century. We're barely a few months into the 21st century, and this will shape it. Histories of this century will have to begin with this date.
- 5.70** Global financial crisis in 2008: world historical significance, where the world has come in its globalized form to a financial meltdown. Lots of other moments in the last 25 years that you could point to, or maybe not lots, but certain significant moments in the last 25 years that you could point to as being somehow enormously, enormously significant, that history is not going to be the same after this has happened.
- 5.71** In many ways, Fukuyama has walked back that claim. I had the strange privilege of giving a paper at Berkeley and at Stanford, I think, about two years ago, which, part of which was very critical of Fukuyama. I then saw his face on the Zoom screen of all conference participants who were joining my seminar. I realized he was there, and he was going to listen to my paper and where I was going to be very critical of this end of history idea. Thankfully, he was extremely gracious and asked some very probing

questions, and we had a very good exchange, but I felt a little bit daunted at that moment. But not as daunted as I would have felt if I'd been him, being asked about his end-of-history thesis after 30 years of it, giving it a chance to be shown to be right, and it turned out that it was really just dead on arrival. He's had to rework things a little bit.

5.72 Actually, to be fair, if you read to the end of that famous book, *The End of History*, it's actually called *The End of History and the Last Man*. I often try to point this out. It's very easy to criticize Fukuyama for being naive about thinking that history came to an end in 1989. But actually, he says at the end of that book, "This is a problem. This is a problem. If history comes to an end, what's going to happen? We're going to get bored. We're going to get really bored.

5.73 This is the problem," says Fukuyama, quoting Nietzsche. "This is the problem of the last man. What does the last man do?" In a chapter in history in which there is no more history, no more history to participate in, no more history to bring about, to contribute to, to invest your life and your community or your nation's life with meaning from, there's a danger of the erosion of identity and a sense of worth and meaning.

5.74 He says this in 1992. It's quite prophetic, I think, because that is true of much of the young today, by all accounts, by all the studies that we can use to get a sense of how young people are feeling and thinking, which is, broadly speaking, despite—broadly speaking, conditions of material comfort for all of the concerns about cost of living and getting on the housing ladder in many parts of the West, it's very challenging, but the key diagnosis is the diagnosis of the founder of this university, Jordan Peterson, namely the meaning crisis. The meaning crisis. It seems we've got everything we pretty much want in material terms, or we could work hard to get it, but still, we're not happy. The more access we get to these goods, the less happy we become. This doesn't make sense.

5.75 Now, from Fukuyama's point of view, it does make sense. When history comes to an end, and there's no world historical stage that anyone can set foot on anymore, there's no project that will have that kind of impact that you can be part of because, really, it's just history is over, and we're just now tidying up.

5.76 It's a very interesting ongoing debate and one that goes all the way back to this great figure of Hegel. Much of the 20th-century writing about history is, in some ways, either a response to Hegel that still bears his fingerprints in many ways or an extension or refinement of Hegel himself. We'll explore some of those in the next lecture.

Lecture 6: Marx & History

At a glance — Marx and history.

- 6.1 Welcome to lecture six in this eight-part lecture series on the Philosophy of History. In the last lecture, we looked at probably the paradigm of philosophers of history in the figure of Hegel, 1770 to 1831. He's really, probably the most influential philosopher to have thought rigorously about history and how it unfolds.
- 6.2 The present lecture, this lecture, lecture six, is also going to focus on one man, not quite as much as we focused on Hegel in the previous lecture, but we're going to be looking at the most important and interesting and consequential response to Hegel in the figure of Karl Marx. But we'll also be looking at all of the various figures that Marx influenced or that reacted against Marx. We can start to see, within the history of history, from Hegel onwards, you can start to see particular phases in the history of history. There's Hegel's understanding of history that morphs into and is changed in dramatic ways by Marx's philosophy of history, and that in turn has enormous real-world impacts, as we shall see.
- 6.3 Marx's opening insight, you might say, is that Hegel is standing on his head. He's doing a headstand, and all we need to do is put him the right way up, and then we're done. What does he mean by this? Remember, for Hegel, all of history and historical change is about reason. It's about the mind. It's about ideas.
- 6.4 This maybe is why Marx unkindly says he's doing a headstand. All this ideas stuff and the thinking is on the ground, when his feet should be on the ground, because it's the feet and the hands that change history, not the mind, not reason, or not some weird reason that doesn't belong to anybody, wired into some jigsaw puzzle. It doesn't make any sense at all.
- 6.5 Stuff happens. It's stuff, material stuff, not ideas and books that nobody's ever really read, gathering dust in university libraries. It's stuff, people, economics, scarce resources, tsunamis, revolutions, elections, assassinations, stuff happening. That's surely the stuff of history. Hegel's just got all these ideas, these fancy thoughts. We've got to say that it's the material conditions of human society that drive change, not the eggheads.
- 6.6 He famously says at one point that the point of philosophers is to understand the world. But surely, the point of understanding the world is to do something, is to change the world. That's not what philosophers are doing. Philosophers are trying to understand the world, and they can only start understanding it, he says, the owl of Minerva can only start stretching its wings when it's all done. There's nothing to fix. It's all over. It's only when the dust has settled that the philosopher can pull his sleeves up, roll his sleeves up, and set to work.

- 6.7** He says famously, "It's not the consciousness of men that determines, that shapes their existence, but their social existence that determines their consciousness." We're not just random spirits moving through the material world, we are constructed and shaped by the material world, by the resources that we have access to, by the people that we are connected to, by the institutions that form us. These are material things— by our diets, and by the economic conditions that make certain diets possible and other diets not. These have a material impact on us.
- 6.8** As difficult and frustrating as Marx is to read, it's impossible to ignore him in any lecture series on the philosophy of history, because more than any other single philosopher, he had, you could say, an almost direct impact on a succession of dramatic political changes all across the world, over the course of the end of the 19th century and then into the 20th century.
- 6.9** In 1848, you have, as it were, a moment of nationalist uprisings, all across Europe. They're eventually put down quite quickly within a year or two. But in 1848, there is a sense that the age of the nation has arrived and that the age of the big old empires—the Russian Empire, the Austro-Hungarian Empire, the British Empire, the French Empire, all the European empires—all that was coming to an end. The new Europe was being born, a Europe of independent, sovereign nations-states. That critique of imperialism, the critique of the old guard, is beginning to carry, to exercise some influence.
- 6.10** It isn't until long after Marx's death, or quite a long time after Marx's death, that his ideas really start to have an impact—most famously, of course, with the second Russian Revolution of 1917, the second and most successful one, the October Revolution in Russia in 1917, that expressly attempted, in the figure of Lenin to put Marx's ideas into practice. But of course, we see Communist revolutions in Cuba in 1949—sorry, in 1959, in China in 1949, in Vietnam, of course, in 1975.
- 6.11** At its peak, Marx's ideas were formerly the political ideology of the political state of a third of the world's population. Marx's ideas came to shape the lives of a third of the world's population for most of the second half of the 20th century. For 40 or 50 years, we can say that Marx's ideas—and this is extraordinary. Can we think of any other philosopher in history who's had that kind of impact, that concrete impact, on the lives of so many millions of people? It's very hard to think of one.
- 6.12** Obviously, it's an ideology that led—whether because it was always going to lead or just because human nature being what it is—led to up to, it's estimated, 100 million deaths. This is an ideology that killed up to 100 million people, if you factor everything in. Again, one should be agnostic as to whether or not this is how Marx's ideas, if implemented, would always end up; these are the consequences that would always come—not the utopia that he promises us, the worker's paradise that's supposed to be at the end of the chain. That could be true. It could be the case that it's just not been

perfectly implemented, that Marx didn't intend these horrific outcomes. But this is still much debated, of course.

- 6.13 For the most part, I'd say that the track record of Marxist-inspired economies, planned economies, has not been great. The Soviets collapsed very quickly in the '70s and '80s through economic stagnation, through not being able to master productivity in anything like the orders of magnitude that countries in the West were able to achieve.
- 6.14 The famous "gulag archipelago" that was developed in the late 1920s and 1930s, these are a concentration camp system that was responsible for the deaths of at least 18 million Russians—sorry, 18 million imprisoned. We thought up to 1.6 million died. The numbers are still very hard to establish. Not much sign of a worker's paradise; plenty of signs of a totalitarian nightmare.
- 6.15 And so, the question is: Was Marx completely wrong? Maybe he was right about what drives history, or righter than others about what drives history: access to material resources. But maybe he was wrong about revolution. Maybe he was wrong about revolution being inevitable. Maybe he was wrong that the revolution would bring about the paradise that he thought it would bring about. Or maybe he was wrong about everything. It's perfectly possible.
- 6.16 I will say that there are many people on the left today who still read Marx, even aware of the consequences of his ideas, profitably. His diagnosis, for example, of capitalism, the diagnosis of the worker feeling a sense of investment and pride in the fruits of his labor, and that the Industrial Revolution and automatization and transition to a factory way of working life, away from working the Earth, brings with it a sense of dislocation, a sense that work is just something that you do. It's not organically connected to you. It doesn't have much more meaning to you than helping you pay the bills at the end of the month.
- 6.17 Now, that's a little bit speculative, you might say, but Marx is probably onto something here. There is a sense of there's dignity in work. There's a sense of satisfaction that one gets in being close to the fruits of one's work. He thinks that capitalism severs this link, destroys it. It alienates the worker from the fruits of his labor. There's an alienation; it's a disconnection that capitalism brings in there. This Marx's idea.
- 6.18 Now, I don't think that's—I don't really buy that myself, but there are ways you can understand it in the context of rampant consumerism in the modern world and the failure of consumer goods. The increase in the supply and breadth and diversity of consumer goods has not gone hand in hand with a slow, steady improvement of the world's mental health. You'd expect there to be some correlation, that the more we have, the more stuff we have, the happier we get.
- 6.19 But all the evidence is that, if anything, the relationship is the other way around. It's an inverse relationship. The more stuff we have access to, the more status anxiety we get, and eventually you catch affluenza— affluenza, the disease of affluence. You don't

know what to choose. It's a paralysis of choice. Everything you do choose doesn't give you the kick that you thought it would, or at least not for as long as you thought it would. Gradually, you come to understand that it's not all about stuff, and other explanations need to be folded in.

- 6.20** But the inversion of Hegel is fascinating. For Hegel, it's ideas at the base. Marx writes as if society has an architecture and different levels, different levels, structures and superstructures and so on. Effectively, you've got a base, you've got the structure and then the superstructure. For Hegel, the base is reason and it is ideas, the non-material reason, gradually unfolding itself in the jigsaw of the real in history. That's what drives material reality and institutions and culture and religion and so on and so forth.
- 6.21** Marx flips this round completely. He says ideas and consciousness and all of that stuff is right at the top. It's nothing to do with the foundations. At the base, it's stuff, material conditions, the mode of production, how you produce things, economics, how you regulate human desires, human needs for scarce material resources. That's what drives ideas and reason and consciousness. That's the superstructure. The base is a material one. The superstructure is just ideas.
- 6.22** So Hegel: ideas shape reality, material reality, Marx: no, it's material reality that shapes ideas. For Hegel, it's the dawning awareness of freedom in the slave, whose master has got more and more dependent on him. Slowly, he realizes, "Actually, I'm free, and I'm getting freer." That's what drives progress forward: a search for greater freedom, for Hegel. For Marx, it's not that. The struggle is not an internal struggle in the slave, but a class struggle, a struggle between the class of the slaves, the class that the slave belongs to, and the class that the master belongs to.
- 6.23** The whole of Hegel's idea of the master-slave relationship is politicized; it's turned into class. It says, this is what's driving history: conflict between classes, fighting over scarce resources—that's what's driving progress. That's what will eventually, this class struggle will eventually lead to a revolution, a political struggle, between the proletariat, the people, and the bourgeoisie, the property-owning classes. Those two classes will come into conflict, and the proletariat will win.
- 6.24** Then that will usher in a worker's paradise where everybody is equal, everybody has exactly what they need, "from each according to his ability, to each according to his need," et cetera. The whole of humanity will regulate itself like a happy family at the kitchen table, where it's true. At the family kitchen table, it is true that we can say that this little community operates on the principle, from each according to his ability, to each according to his needs. The mom and dad, from their ability to put bread on the table, are providing for the need of the children who can't bring bread to the table at this point. But that's probably one of the only settings in which that principle is going to work. If you try and expand that out into society as a whole, things get much, much more complicated.

- 6.25 This is the way to understand the differences between Hegel and Marx. Marx is inverting Hegel in lots of ways, but there would be—Marx would not have any of the ideas that he had were it not for the patterns in history and the way in which history moves, its dynamic quality, were it not the case that Hegel had first sown those ideas.
- 6.26 As I said, for Marx, it's class struggle that is the motor of history. We move, says Marx—he gives us this grand history from a kind of primitive communism, where there's no property, no classes, everybody's equal, but everybody's equally poor, into this ancient mode where slavery begins to emerge, and you've got this tension between masters and slaves. Then into medieval feudalism, where it's not quite masters and slaves, more like lords and serfs. So you can see the serfs are not quite slaves, and lords are not quite masters. They each have their own obligations and duties.
- 6.27 Then from feudalism, Marx says, we get to capitalism. It's not so much lord and serf, it's more owner and worker, the factory owner and the factory worker, you might say the bourgeoisie, the property-owning classes, people who own a house versus those who don't, but that asymmetry persists. Still the same dynamic that Hegel writes about in 1807, it's still there. Each stage, says Marx, is a bit more productive than the last. Each stage contains fewer tensions and internal contradictions. Lord and serf, there's less asymmetry there than master and slave, and similarly with property owner versus worker and so on and so forth. There's a gradual—there's a development here that Marx thinks is necessary.
- 6.28 Then he has complex theories as to why capitalism is now going to be a new phase ahead. Just as we've had, we've gone from feudalism to capitalism, now it's time to go from capitalism to communism. This is the next phase. To oversee this transition, it's going to be a very messy transition. And so it's very important that the proletariat side of the battle have total control over the course of the transition, of course.
- 6.29 The dictatorship of the proletariat, the dictatorship of the people, magically mediated through one man, or a very small committee of people dominated by one man, that one man is whoever was lucky enough to be general secretary of the central committee of the Soviet Communist Party. The dictatorship has to be brutal, direct, no questions asked. "This is the people speaking," etc. The worker's paradise isn't just going to produce itself. We're going to need some drastic measures here. You can't make an omelet without breaking a few eggs. This is the idea. If paradise is around the corner, I mean, how many eggs would you be willing to break? As many as it takes, surely.
- 6.30 The trouble with that, in the end, is not so much the number of eggs that were broken—100 million, according to some—but there isn't even an omelet. We had 100 million eggs broken for Marx's ideology, but there's no paradise. There's no omelet. This is not how Marx promised us it was going to go. The idea was, after the revolution, it wouldn't be that the state would be run perfectly; there wouldn't be the need for a state anymore. You wouldn't need a government in paradise. Who would put a

government in paradise? Would it be paradise if the state was still breathing down your neck and sending you tax bills? Of course not.

- 6.31** So Marx says it all falls away. You don't need it anymore, because we've reached this paradise of equality where everyone has exactly what they need, and if they don't, then we can just take it, take it from the person who's able to give the person what he needs. It makes perfect sense, surely. Just take it.
- 6.32** To his credit, if we go back and thinking about that first question that we were worrying about in lectures one and two, "Is history a science or is it a humanity?", Marx is saying, "Of course it's a science." All we're studying is stuff. We're not studying non-scientific; there's nothing non-scientific here. It's access to stuff. This is a kind of science. It's a description of material history when human beings are involved. It's just that. It's just processes, impersonal processes. It's not these great individuals coming through, shaping everything.
- 6.33** This is bound to happen, says Marx. If you ask, "Why has it not happened yet? Why that worker's paradise is still—despite those 100 million eggs, there's no omelet? What have you done with the eggs? Where is this omelet?" The answer is normally, "The eggs weren't cracked properly. It's the wrong kind of eggs. The eggs didn't do what they were told. We had to get rid of a lot of the eggs. We thought they were rotten, a lot of them. And also the eggs didn't want to be broken. They were complaining about being broken, being forced and subordinated into the service of this greater good, this extraordinary omelet that is, we promise, around the corner, just about to come out of the kitchen."
- 6.34** You'll say, "Why, so why did the eggs not want to be broken? Why?" "Because they had false consciousness." This is the reason the working classes have not thrown off the shackles of the property-owning classes, because the property-owning classes have got them in a daze. They've hypnotized them. And the workers are suffering from this false—they're under this hypnosis. They're being convinced that the wage packet that they get at the end of the week actually is enough to get on the housing ladder and buy themselves a few beers and keep their family happy, and actually, they believe that they're fine, and they don't want this revolution that we're urging on them, this paradise that we promise is around the corner.
- 6.35** They don't want to be broken into the omelet. Isn't it extraordinary how evil capitalism is? That it can hypnotize poor, innocent working-class people into believing this, into believing that they're happy or they've just about got what they need? This terrible belief in the free markets and individual opportunity and meritocracy and so on. Marx thinks of this state as a little bit like being drugged. The property-owning classes are drugging the working classes with these ideas and with consumer goods and life getting a little bit better every year. This is how they keep them hypnotized, keep the workers under their control.

- 6.36 Marx says this is what religion does, too. It's like a drug. It's like heroin. It's an opiate. Religion is the cry of a heartless creature, the sigh of the oppressed creature, the cry of a heartless world, the sigh of an oppressed creature. "Religion is the opium of the masses." Religion is this set of ideas, false ideas, which are fed to the working classes, are fed to the masses, and it drugs them, it anaesthetizes them.
- 6.37 It gives them a comfort that prevents them from seeing the need for the revolution and to bring an earthly paradise round and to usher in an earthly paradise. So religion's function is to stop the working classes getting into these revolutionary ideas. It dulls the pain and it prevents the pain of alienation, which the workers feel, says Marx, and prevents them from acting, prevents them from taking part in the great revolution to come. That's Marx.
- 6.38 We're about halfway through this lecture, and so I've given half the lecture over to Marx. But I think now I want to move into the 20th century and start to look at some of the responses to Marx and some of his influences. That will bring us, for the first time in this series, firmly into living memory, we might say.
- 6.39 The first figure is the great Viennese Jew who escaped from Vienna in, I think, the late 1920s, early 1930s, ended up in London, and developed a very distinguished university career in London, particularly at the London School of Economics, and became—though Austrian— became a major figure in British intellectual life, and particularly in philosophy. He wrote many important books, and the one that's relevant to our purposes is his 1957 book, *The Poverty of Historicism*. *The Poverty of Historicism*.
- 6.40 What is historicism? Not a word that we've come across yet, but we should be clear about it. Historicism is the idea that we've met many times so far in this series, that there are certain internal principles—laws, you might say— of governing how history happens or the limits of what can happen in history. You can spot these patterns, you can spot these laws, and then you can form a good sense of the architecture of the past.
- 6.41 The historicist believes that we can inquire into history in something like the way the scientist inquires into reality. We've seen this idea before, going right back to Ranke in lectures one and two. It's more than just studying history as if it were the object of scientific inquiry; it's also going beyond that, more from critical history into speculative history, because as we've already discovered with Hegel and with Marx, you've got these very, very grand conceptions of how all of world history fits together. For Popper, that is just going too far.
- 6.42 Here, his writings in the philosophy of science, in particular, *The Logic of Scientific Discovery*, which he published in the 1930s— you will know if you've listened to my philosophy of science lectures that one of the big features, one of the big problems in contemporary philosophy of science, is whether or not, from studying the way in which the world has behaved in the past, we can predict how it must behave in the future.

The sun came up, has come up, every day for the last 4.5 billion years on Earth, and therefore it must come up tomorrow.

- 6.43** It turns out, there are all sorts of problems, philosophical problems, in extrapolating from the past into the future, because we've never been able to prove that the future resembles the past. We've been able to prove that what was once the future resembles the past, but we can never capture the future and say the future now resembles the past, such that we know that this is going to happen.
- 6.44** All sorts of skeptics emerge, David Hume most famously, saying, no, that's not possible. Popper agrees with this. He says future history would depend on future knowledge, but you can't predict future knowledge. Why? Because you can't know anything about the future. Why? Because to know anything is to know something that exists, something that's true. But the future doesn't exist, and therefore there's nothing that can be known about it. There are no truths about the future that are true, because it hasn't happened. There are guesses, but it could never be knowledge, says Popper. It can never be knowledge.
- 6.45** You can't predict things. Everything that people talk about laws of history, these are actually just patterns that people have identified from past events, not patterns that people have identified across the whole of world history from beginning, middle, to the end—because no one has such a view except God, if God exists. But Popper didn't believe he did, so that's not a way out for him.
- 6.46** So, how does Popper bring these criticisms against Marx? Well, he says that Marx tells us that these things are going to happen in the future. There's going to be a worker's paradise at some point. There's going to be a massive clash between the classes. There's going to be a revolution. "I'm making this prediction." This is a science. If we turn around and we say these predictions didn't come true. I mean, the prediction that you would have to crack a lot of eggs came true, but there's no omelet, or most people don't like the omelet, or there's certainly not enough to go around. And so, we can say that the predictions were falsified, and that this theory, to the extent that it's a theory, you gave yourself the chance to be shown to be right and shown to be wrong, and you were shown to be wrong.
- 6.47** This is not science, says Popper, this is dogma. This is ideology dressed up as science, pretending to be science, cloaking itself in the language and terminology of science. Popper says this is very dangerous, very dangerous. If some ideology or some theory thinks it has such a clear understanding of the past that it can tell everybody what to do in the future is very dangerous. If you claim to know that you're on the right side of history, that history is on my side, this is how things must end, the arc of history is long, may zigzag a lot, but it bends towards justice or whatever it bends towards, X, that's very risky. If you claim confident knowledge in that, then anything that's getting in the way of history itself is, you've got to get rid of that immediately.

- 6.48** Just standing against the forces of history, trying to say, "Stop. Who do you think you are? Get rid of this person." What do you mean, there are ethical considerations for this particular part of society? No, this is historical necessity unfolding itself. Get out of the way or get run over. Popper says that it has a totalitarian logic. The person who thinks they've got some prize access to this special knowledge. This is very dangerous in the wrong hands. Any disagreement, any dissent, you're opposing history itself.
- 6.49** It's a very important year, 1945. It's the end of, the year that the Second World War ends. He claims that the emergence of totalitarianism and of fascism is partly due to certain crucial figures in the history of Western philosophy who impose too much of a constraining claustrophobic scaffolding and structure through their ideas to the world, whether it's Plato—and Plato is villain number one, with his complex theories of philosophy that lead, in Popper's view, to a very authoritarian, almost fascist kind of political utopia, as in *The Republic*, or *The Laws*, his much later dialogue. In fact, if you thought *The Republic* utopia was authoritarian, just wait till you get to *The Laws*. Marx himself is part of this gallery of villains, imposing these implausible ideological matrices on the whole of human history as the only way in which human history can be understood.
- 6.50** A figure who comes closely on the heels of Karl Popper, another émigré—so not British, but somebody whom Britain gave a home to at a critical at this point as war was spreading through continental Europe—I'm talking of Sir Isaiah Berlin, 1909 to November 1997, a Lithuanian, Russian-speaking Jew who gets out just in time after the Russian Revolution, makes it over to England and then to Oxford, where he spends the rest of his life as one of the great liberal philosophers of the 20th century, just as Popper had made it out to London, escaping from Vienna, both émigré Jews.
- 6.51** Berlin is a fascinating figure in many ways, writes one of the most important works on Marx in the 1950s. When he's at Oxford, it's one of the first pieces of work he does. Much of the rest of his life is a reaction against Marx, particularly against Marx's view that history is determined, that human agency, free human agency, doesn't actually have anything to do with how history moves forward. Then in particular, the nature of freedom, the importance of freedom.
- 6.52** Berlin sees, in a very subtle way, in a famous essay called *Two Concepts of Liberty*, 1958—is it '58? Yes, it's around about 1958. It's his inaugural lecture as the Chichele Professor of Political Philosophy at All Souls College, Oxford. He sees that there are two types, two kinds of freedom, one of which the Marxist can appeal to, and the other of which is the more true conception of freedom that Berlin wants to put forward.
- 6.53** The first thing to know about Berlin is that he thinks of himself as a philosopher of liberalism. That is to say, that way of understanding human beings and our place and relationship to society that emerges really in the 17th century under figures like John Locke and David Hume, Rousseau and Voltaire in France, in their different ways. Thomas Hobbes is a very important figure here, too.

- 6.54** The idea, roughly speaking, is that human beings emerge into the world as something like blank slates, self-legislating subjects, yes, that will be connected in all sorts of different ways to the world and to their society. But really, what matters is the subject, the self, the self's authority, by means of its reason, its reason and its capacity over the world, and to understand and to experience the world, that reason has a self-legislating power, or autonomy. Literally in Greek, autonomy means self-law, auto-law, autonomy. The importance for the liberal view is "libera," freedom, liberation from anything that you don't want yourself to be connected to.
- 6.55** This is a very new way of thinking about what it is to be human. With that view comes another view, namely that, if every individual is important, but there are big, deep disagreements between different individuals about some fundamental question—what the nature of God is, maybe, or what the nature of the good is, or what justice is, or how justice should be done—these are questions, because we have to respect the individual, and the individual has complete authority to determine what's right and what's wrong, what's valuable and what's not, who are we to say, who is society to say, who is any one individual to say to another individual, "You're wrong. You're wrong. You've got this wrong. You should have listened to me. You should have forgotten about your autonomy, and you should have sat at my feet and listened to me." This is not what the liberal person is supposed to do. It's, "No, if I don't want to listen to you, I don't have to listen to you. You're probably wrong, anyway. Don't you know who I am?" This is a little bit cartoonish, but that's, broadly speaking, the liberal picture.
- 6.56** On this view, the idea of pluralism begins to emerge. We've got these different people believing very different things about questions that we thought were settled and fundamental, and we haven't really got a mechanism to arbitrate between these different views of the good, different views of what a flourishing society looks like. So we let everybody get on with it. We're not going to judge. It's not our business. He thinks that. It's completely crazy, but he's free to think what he wants, to do what he wants with his freedom. That's it.
- 6.57** Berlin says we have to incorporate this idea of pluralism somehow. There's no way of arbitrating between different human goods and different human beings who want different things. Life is messy, life is tragic. These values, these competing conceptions of the good, are going to come into conflict. You might think that liberty, equality, and justice is perfect, is the paradise we should be aiming for. But the fact is, you can't have all of those together. They're going to conflict. They're incompatible in practice.
- 6.58** If you want total equality, you're going to have to take away virtually everybody's freedom. If you want to engineer complete mathematical and economic equality between citizens in a state at scale, you're going to need extraordinary levels of coercion and terror to make that happen. If you want total freedom, you are never going to get to total freedom if you just get rid of all the rules and say, "Oh, the state's got nothing to do with, the state's retiring. It's done. The police have served well, but

it's time to defund them, get rid of them. We can move beyond them in the quest for total freedom." This would be anarchy. It would be a captivity for everybody, if that were pressed ahead. These things don't go together. In a flourishing society, you want a measure of freedom, you want a measure of equality, but you've got to realize that you can't have each to the max in the same society. There's a trade-off.

- 6.59** Berlin is very good at seeing that, seeing, understanding the reality of that. It's a famous essay, one of the very first things I read by Isaiah Berlin. Actually, the first thing I read by Isaiah Berlin was *The Hedgehog and the Fox*, which is a wonderful essay he writes about Tolstoy, about how there are some people who know many, many different things about many, many different things. They're the foxes. And then, there are the hedgehogs who know a lot about one thing. He has this brilliant essay where he looks at different people, different historians, different philosophers, judging who are the hedgehogs and who are the foxes.
- 6.60** But the first thing, the essay that made a real impression on me when I first read it, was an essay called *Historical Inevitability*, which he wrote in 1954. Not many people read it these days, but I think it's a brilliant, one of the best critiques of Marx's view that we can tell from the past exactly what's going to happen in the future. It's going to be this revolution, it's going to be this worker's paradise, and it'll happen on this rough time scale.
- 6.61** Berlin's point is a philosophical one. He's saying, as soon as we start to think of human history as being determined, we're assuming that it's determined. That is to say, we're assuming that freedom has not got any role to play here. None. Everything is determined as if we're on a tram line. History is on a tram line, and it doesn't matter what all the historical actors on the tram are doing, or where they think they're driving to, or when they think they're putting the brakes aren't working. It's just history's moving forward. There are all these people in the tram cars who think they are, "Look how fast we've managed to get the tram going, and we've managed to get the tram heading in that direction now."
- 6.62** Berlin says it may be true, but how plausible does that feel? How plausible does that feel? If it were the case, on the tram car view of history, the tram line view of history, there's no freedom, and therefore, there's nothing to praise. There's no actions that could be praised. There's no actions that can be blamed. We can't do any evaluation when we're doing history. Why? Well, because Berlin takes the view, roughly, of Immanuel Kant, that ought implies can.
- 6.63** You can't say to somebody, "You ought to have put that fire out in the Bronx," when the person who ought to have put the fire out is in Notting Hill, in London. No, that person is not under any obligation because were he, then that would assume he had the capacity to discharge the obligation. But he didn't, and so the obligation doesn't arise. There needs to be a capacity. When you're blaming somebody for failing to do something or for doing something, you're assuming that they could have not done it.

They were free. They had the choice not to do it. Conversely, when we praise somebody, we praise somebody for having done something that they could have freely chosen not to do.

- 6.64** And so, Berlin says that it may be that Marx is right, that all of history and all of human actions is just determined. None of it was taken freely. But it would make a mockery of almost every human reflection on history. Every human reflection on the past involves some moral judgment. "He did well. Oh, he shouldn't have done that. What was he thinking? I would never have done that. Look at what happened when he did do that," et cetera. All of history is a moral exercise in moral evaluation like that.
- 6.65** Berlin says, but all of that makes no sense at all on the Marxist view. On the Marxist view, it was whatever was said was always going to be said. It doesn't mean anything. It's not describing behavior that could be praised or criticized. It's chaos determined by other things.
- 6.66** Berlin is very clear about how important freedom is, how irreducible it is. You can't get rid of it. You can't just get rid of it by saying that the freedom of the individual is just swallowed up in the determining engine room, the force of historical determinism, material determinism. Freedom still matters. Napoleon and Wellington, Nelson, Hitler, Stalin, they made decisions freely. They weren't determined to. They could be blamed and praised for making the decisions that they made. They're not just puppets of the grand process of history.
- 6.67** As we come towards the end of this lecture, we've seen this titanic clash between Hegel at the beginning of the 19th century, this new, first, really carefully worked-out philosophy of history, in terms of ideas and thought and world consciousness. On the other hand, Marx, who takes up so much of Hegel's framework, but either, depending on what you think about Hegel, turns Hegel on his head or turns him the right way up.
- 6.68** This great struggle between these two Germans would have a huge impact on how we understand politics and history in the 20th century, these worries that you can't predict history, it's too messy, you certainly can't assume that it's completely determined because that abolishes human freedom and our deep intuition that we can praise and blame different people in history for behaving in different ways.
- 6.69** This sets the scene for the last two lectures in this series, where we'll be looking at history today: what are the latest ideas, the latest debates about the meaning of history and the nature of history that have been affecting public discussions in the West over the last, say, 50 to 70 years? But for now, that concludes, you might say, the final historical chapter in this series—the Hegel and Marx chapter, or those two chapters—and we'll be moving into more contemporary conceptual considerations over lectures seven and eight.

Lecture 7: Decline & Renewal

At a glance — Decline and renewal.

- 7.1** Welcome to lecture seven in this eight-part lecture series on the Philosophy of History. In the previous lecture, we looked at a number of figures who had a particular theory about history and the direction that history was taking that was a fairly optimistic one. It looked towards the future as a place of betterment, of improvement, even a paradise, a utopia. In Marx's case, in Hegel's case, a paradise of freedom, where the individual is finally free and enabled to be free. With Marx, it's more when the worker gets to be free, and Marx applies this class analysis to it. But for both of them, history is moving. It's moving in a particular direction. It's linear. And it's moving in a positive direction. There's a utopia at the end. There's something to look forward to.
- 7.2** There were a lot of criticisms that we explored against that historicist idea, the idea that history unfolds according to certain rules and patterns and principles. In people like Karl Popper, we saw a new version of Hegel coming through with Francis Fukuyama's idea about the end of history happening, in 1989, November the 9th, round about tea time. And there's still a sort of Hegelian idea, an imprint, you might say, in Fukuyama's announcement of the end of history. Hegel thought it was 1789, Fukuyama thought it was 1989. What's a couple of hundred years between friends? And so, this is the broad picture of how history is conceived.
- 7.3** Other figures, too, of course. We've looked at Vico, this idea, which is a lot more "corsi e ricorsi," goings and comings, endless circles, which he thinks history unfolds in. But it's, broadly speaking, an optimistic picture, an optimistic horizon that one can look forward to.
- 7.4** And then, of course, a number of shattering events affect the world, world politics, world culture, in the early 20th century, which make these more optimistic views of where history is heading seem somehow false and inauthentic and implausible. It's very difficult to maintain your faith in human reason after you've been gassed in the trenches of the First World War, or you've suffered terrible shell shock, or you're a member of the family of some of the 20 million who died in the First World War, between 1914 and 1918.
- 7.5** And after a cataclysm like the Great War, or like the Russian Revolution, or like the Spanish Flu, which broke out the year that the First World War ended, tens of millions dying, after those events, it's very hard to maintain one's sunny optimism about the direction of history. And so, instead of having more utopian ideas about where history was heading, towards a paradise, you have these darker narratives emerging.
- 7.6** As opposed to utopian novels, you get dystopian novels. One of the earliest is one of my favorite, probably the least well-known is Robert Hugh Benson's *Lord of the World*,

1907, one of the first dystopian novels. Another is Yevgeny Zamyatin's *My, Russian for we*, which is a brilliant dystopian novel, comes out, I think, in the 1920s. And it's about the reduction of Russian citizens to numbers, and being placed in this highly sophisticated concentration camp where every inmate is completely depersonalized by this authoritarian, totalitarian machine.

- 7.7 And then, of course, there are the famous dystopian novels that emerge from the English-speaking world, particularly Britain, in fact. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World*, of course, George Orwell's *1984*, an incredible exercise in taking present scenarios, or rather imagining what those are like, and then projecting forward a few decades. I mean, it's striking when Orwell is beginning to write *1984* immediately after the Second World War, he publishes it in 1949, shortly before he dies, is that a lot of people at the time had no idea about the horrors of Stalin's regime. Very few people knew the sheer extent of Stalin's murderousness and brutality.
- 7.8 In 1945, '46, '47, he's Uncle Joe. He's the guy who helped us beat the Nazis. We couldn't have done it without Uncle Joe. All the horrific crimes that Stalin perpetrated in the 1930s, the show trials, the tens of thousands of officers and intelligentsia he put to death, executed, and not to mention the millions who starved as a result of the aggressive collectivization programs in Ukraine in the early 1930s— we don't really have a proper number, a handle on the number of those deaths. So, Orwell was very perceptive to see and to describe and to imagine what the court of Stalin was like, what a system, what a Soviet state would be like, and he does it brilliantly in that book.
- 7.9 So, dystopian novels emerge, and that is part of a more apocalyptic turn, you might say, in the way we think about history and the end times. And that's probably also affected by the fact that the year 2000 is coming up. The beginning of the 20th century, it's a millennial year—sorry, a millennial century, I should say, a millennial year that is fast approaching. And perhaps that's helped to think, encouraged us to think in a more epochal way about big chapters in history.
- 7.10 In any event, during the First World War, a brilliant young German philosopher and historian set his mind to a huge work, the work of a brilliant young German philosopher and historian in the German, *Der Untergang des Abendlandes*. In English, the downfall, the decline, *Der Untergang des Abendlandes*, of the sunset lands, literally. So the decline of the West, the decline of the West. It's a multi-volume work. First volume comes out in 1918, the year of the end of the First World War. It's an instant bestseller.
- 7.11 It's got a kind of pessimism that clearly rang true to the sort of broken people and broken state of Germany in the immediate aftermath of the First World War and the punitive, the very tough treaty that the Allies forced them to sign at Versailles. And Spengler's work can be read as a riposte, as a retort, to the more optimistic, positive myths of progress, or histories of progress, or accounts of history as heading in a particularly, in a progressive direction that we find in Hegel and Marx and other liberal thinkers as well.

- 7.12** And Spengler's central thesis is that history is not linear. We should think about history, really, in terms of culture and civilizations. And when you look at cultures and civilizations, he said, you can see that they're almost like organisms. There's a birth phase, there's a growing-up phase, there's a coming-of-age phase, and then there's a decline. And he says that all civilizations go through these cycles.
- 7.13** This is no less true of Western civilization. There's a spring, a birth, a spring season, growth in the summer, maturity in the autumn, and then decline and death in the winter. So he's got this metaphor of the seasons, which he attaches to a civilization. A civilization has these four seasons.
- 7.14** So he takes Western cultures and says, the springtime for the West was really Late Antiquity, say 800-900 AD, through to, say, 1200. We got the emergence of cathedrals, the emergence of guilds, of crusades, intense period of faith, restraint, and asceticism. The growth of monastic traditions, in particular. Feudalism. And Spengler says this is an early stage, the birth stage of the West.
- 7.15** And then 1200 to 1500, move through the High Middle Ages and into the Renaissance. This is a kind of growth spurt. This is the teenage years for the West: the growth of the universities, for example, in the 13th century and the 14th century, all around Europe. The emergence of international finance networks, thanks to the bankers in Florence, in particular. The emergence of a network of scholars, scholarly networks between all the different monastic traditions, and so on.
- 7.16** And the Renaissance, of course, an explosion in new architectural styles, new texts. There's a rediscovery, not just of Aristotle, which had been found and had happened already in the 12th and 13th century, but Plato now as well. So Plato is being rediscovered in the second half of the 1400s. That has an electric impact on European ideas, just as Aristotle had done 200 to 300 years before. So, this is the growth phase.
- 7.17** And then the Enlightenment, so 1800, that period up to 1800—1500 to 1800. This is a period of the Reformation, of course, in the 16th century. The emergence of something like the modern Western state after the Treaty of Westphalia in 1648. Then you've got this run of extraordinary philosophers, thinkers, scientists on both sides of the Channel, in both Britain and continental Europe, who push forward entirely new ways of thinking. Of course, enormous breakthroughs in science.
- 7.18** So in England, obviously, you've got Locke, John Locke. You've got Hume. You've got Bishop Berkeley. You've got Isaac Newton, Thomas Hobbes. These are crucial players in the Enlightenment. On the continent, Leibniz and Descartes and Spinoza, all figures who are pushing forward their own distinctive ideas, but that are subversive of what's come before. And so, this is the—you might say, this is the point where Western civilization, for Spengler, achieves its maturity. It's in its mature phase.
- 7.19** And the great cultural achievements start to come through at this point, of course, with people like Bach in the music world, 1685 to 1750, or Mozart, of course, in the 18th

century, 1756 to 1791. Beethoven, a little bit later, 1770 up to 1826, I think it is, 1827. These are extraordinary leaps forward in the possibilities of music. With the emergence of the piano, particularly the pianoforte, in the very early 1800s, that develops as an instrument very quickly from the harpsichord. Concertos begin to emerge. Opera is reaching its peak in the middle of the 19th century.

7.20 And so, it's at that point that Spengler says the West starts its decline, after the high noon of high culture, broad political stability. Remember that, after the Congress of Vienna in 1815, it's an incredible treaty, an incredible peace after the end of the Napoleonic Wars, this is roundabout Waterloo. So in the summer of 1815, the Congress of Vienna results in a period of extraordinary peace for Europe, which is not really shattered until 1914. It's almost 100 years of unprecedented levels of peace across continental Europe.

7.21 Yes, there was the year of the revolutions in 1848, nationalist uprisings that died down after a year or two. But that still signaled that there were countries that needed to be nations. Italy in 1860 became a nation. Germany in 1870, 10 years later, thanks to Otto von Bismarck, becomes a nation state. And both Italy and Germany thinking about, how do we forge ourselves into—how do we think of ourselves as a "we," as a nation, as a collective? We need stories, we need a hinterland, we need history. We need a history. Now, often there's plenty of places to look for, to put together histories of Italy and Germany, but as a completely new political entity, there was still something a little strange about it. But anyway, a broad period of peace.

7.22 There's the Franco-Prussian War in 1870. There are some misunderstandings between the Brits and the Afghans. Well, three major sets of misunderstandings, but nobody really cared too much about that. We had various scuffles around the world, but broadly speaking, this is an era in which there's extraordinary peace around the world, partly, thanks, I should say, to the Royal Navy, which had total control of all the waterways, all the major waterways of planet Earth, in the 19th century, and was able to massively reduce the slave trade, almost to extinction by the end of the 19th century, and was able to provide security against piracy, and control of all the main trade routes. That played a factor; that had a role to play in it all.

7.23 And so, this is the time of peace, but, says Spengler, this is, as it were, the calm before the storm, the calm before the decline. And the decline, for Spengler, runs from roughly 1900 to 2200. So he thinks we're coming up to the middle of it. So, what's his claim? Why does he think that we're entering now into a period of decline? Well, he thinks we've moved from culture, which he thinks is a good thing, to civilization. Culture is what you get in the spring, the summer, and the autumn. Civilization is what you get in the winter. And it's really—and this is not something that anybody can escape. This is fixed. It's inevitable. At some point, this will happen.

7.24 The transition from the organic, the creative, the spiritual, which he thinks characterizes the first three seasons of a chapter in human history, as it were, of a

single culture. And then it's in that fourth stage that culture returns into a civilization. It becomes mechanized. It's focusing on the mechanical, the artificial, the mass-produced, the engineered. It's culturally and artistically sterile. It's not producing any more Mozarts. It's not producing any more Michelangelos. It's mass-producing lots of technologically impressive things and impressive conveniences. But we've lost—there isn't any more of that artistic genius or flair that characterized previous chapters of European civilization.

- 7.25** Now remember, Spengler's writing in 1918. This is still probably the year, round about those few years that modernism in art and poetry begins to emerge. But he's got an interestingly prophetic quality. Instead of Gothic cathedrals, he says, we've now got skyscrapers. Is a skyscraper more impressive than a Gothic cathedral? In some ways, perhaps it is. But these are two very different phases in a civilization's history, the one elevates the Gothic cathedral as the center of spiritual gravity, as it were, the center of something that expresses a beauty and expresses the civilization's character on the world, and then, on the other hand, the skyscraper. How does culture think of itself when it's producing each of those kinds of, when it's undertaking each of those achievements?
- 7.26** So, this is Spengler's claim, that culture always inevitably ends up as civilization, just as certainly as winter follows autumn. This is what we must simply face up to; we can't escape it. And if you look, there are various markers that Spengler says that will be true of a civilization in decline, or certainly our civilization in decline. World cities—he doesn't like big cities, a megalopolis. We don't want any megalopolises, but there will be lots, and they'll start to dominate and suck everything up, and rootless masses will start to replace rooted people.
- 7.27** As you saw in the Industrial Revolution, halfway through the 19th century, London explodes in size, overwhelmingly the biggest city in the world. Birmingham explodes, Manchester and Liverpool explode, Bristol explodes in terms of population. This has happened; it is very common. But the advantages that that brings to a national economy and to national prosperity and flourishing come at the cost of this demographic churn around, say, certainly an island as small as Britain is, where you're having enormous, vast populations effectively being uprooted and moving away from their local village that tied them to their family, perhaps for hundreds and hundreds of years. Everything was still quite stable, to suddenly renting a room above a barber's in Manchester. This is your new life, and your family's new life. You've moved in from the country, you've become an urban, you've become a "city-zen".
- 7.28** Money starts to dominate, Spengler says, finance capitalism, plutocracy, the haves and the have-nots, and so on and so forth. Democracy gets more and more exhausted and becomes more and more of a pantomime. And these Caesar figures start to seem attractive, charismatic individuals, politicians who come in and are able to, through force of will and personality, steer a country in a particular direction.

- 7.29** Spengler also says technology will overwhelm us. Technology is going to overwhelm us. It's not going to liberate us; it's actually going to imprison us, in possibly something like the same way that the slave and the master, the master-slave parable with Hegel. The master thinks at the beginning that having a slave frees him up, gives him freedom over his life, over his world, but over time, he's so dependent upon the slave for everything, he can't even wash his own dishes, that the slave suddenly starts to get a lot of bargaining power. And it turns out the master is not as free as he thought.
- 7.30** So, Spengler's theory about the seasonal approach, as it were, to understanding a civilization and the history of the civilization, is, in his view, one that can be applied generally to all sorts of different cultures. He works his way through eight—Babylonians, the Egyptians, the Hellenic, the Greek, and so on and so forth. And he claims to see all of these patterns emerging.
- 7.31** But about the West, he specifically says that what distinguishes the West is its Faustian character. It's like Faust. It's like the character in Christopher Marlowe's famous play, *Dr. Faustus*, Thomas Mann's great novel, of course, but also Goethe's *Faust*, possibly the greatest German play ever written, one of the greatest works of literature in German ever written, Goethe's *Faust*. And Spengler takes this medieval character of Faust and says that character is what the West is, is what's so distinctive, captures what's distinctive about the West, compared to the other seven civilizations that I've been looking at.
- 7.32** So, why does he say this? Well, Goethe's *Faust*, what's the story? He's a scientist, slightly unhinged, temperamental, emotional, but he's striving for complete total knowledge. He wants to know everything there is to know. He's never satisfied; he's always striving for the infinite. And of course, he does a deal with Mephistopheles, the figure of the devil, who promises everything, all the knowledge he could possibly want to know. It's his great—it's another Garden of Eden moment: desperate for the fruit of knowledge. And the devil gives it to him, and that spells doom, of course, for Faust.
- 7.33** But Spengler says, now the West is like this. We're striving for the infinite. Think of those cathedrals. Think of how high they soar, how unnecessarily high the Gothic cathedrals soar. They weren't very tall in those days. They certainly weren't as tall as we were. So why? And why these extraordinary structures? Well, Spengler says, it's because we've got this yearning for the transcendent and a sense that it can be attained. He says it's true of Western civilization. There's also a will to power, you could see, in a structure like a Gothic cathedral. It's where it's putting its stamp on the surroundings; it's dominating nature.
- 7.34** There's a sense of limitless expansion also in the West, as we see in the various waves of Iberian and European and British colonization starting really in the 15th century with the Portuguese—15th, 16th century—and going all the way up to the 19th. So, it's never static; there's a restlessness to the West. But eventually, it exhausts itself. Faust famously refuses to sell—refuses, as it were, to go back on the pact. Or, I mean, he

does wish he had, but he doesn't go back on it. He's sold his soul for knowledge and for power, and that's what spells the end of him. He exhausts, as it were, he dies a complete wreck.

- 7.35** And Spengler says the West also is, after it's made this pact, is going to eventually exhaust itself in its striving. Despite all the achievements that the West has brought, decline is inevitable, as it is for every other civilization. And this may seem very grand; it may seem a very speculative way of doing history, but it's worth noting that Spengler made some pretty accurate predictions. He said, for example, that Europe would be marked by a series of cataclysmic conflicts between the great powers. He's writing this in 1918. Now, you might say, yes, he was aware of the First World War, but he could see that, in 1918, this wasn't the end. There was more to come.
- 7.36** He predicted the rise of Caesar figures, dictator figures, charismatic strongmen. Again, he was absolutely right about that in the figure of Stalin in Russia, figure of Hitler, and a whole number of authoritarian tyrants popping up in Europe at this time. There's Franco in Spain, after the Spanish civil war; there's Mussolini, of course, in Italy. So there is a sense something is coming. Democracy maybe really looking shaky, and democracy looking like it's coming to an end, that parliamentary systems aren't working anymore; they can be easily overridden by these charismatic leader figures, and so on and so forth.
- 7.37** He was probably also right about technology and what technology would do to the modern world. Maybe he understated the progress that modern technology would spread, but also he does note the way in which technology can undermine individual freedom and how it can undermine and change the way we look at the world. We'll talk more about that when we come and look at the figure of Martin Heidegger later on. So, quite a pessimistic view of how history unfolds from Spengler.
- 7.38** In many ways, his more cheery counterpart is an Englishman called Arnold Toynbee. And Toynbee, like Spengler, undertakes this huge project, even bigger than Spengler's, in world history. His *A Study of History*, 1934 to 1961, is in 12 volumes, each well over 1,000 pages. You can get a cleverly abridged edition that runs just to two volumes, but it's an enormous work, took him nearly 30 years. Toynbee is a little bit more optimistic than Spengler.
- 7.39** He says that civilizations can avoid decline. There are things that they can do. There are moments in history we can point to that show civilizations suddenly pulling themselves out of the doom loop. Now, certain conditions have to be in place, but he says, you know, if you look at the way civilizations evolve, it's normally in response to some challenge. It's not too hard, not too easy. It's manageable. And then a "creative minority"—this is Toynbee's phrase—a creative minority emerges and rises to the challenge and succeeds. And then that leads to a period of growth for that society. And then eventually the creative minority becomes a dominant minority, rules by force

rather than appeal and attraction. And then you get a kind of rupture and then a disintegration. And then another sequence, in Toynbee's view, begins.

- 7.40 So this is the basic idea. There's a birth in response to a challenge, there's growth, and then there's a breakdown, disintegration, and stagnation. He draws on dozens and dozens of examples to try to support this point. A good one would be the history of Greece, say, between 1200 BC and, shall we say, 322 BC, where you have, from 1200 to 900 BC, or 1200 to 1000 BC, you have the so-called Late Mycenaean period.
- 7.41 Now, we're not entirely sure what happens, but there's evidence of many sieges, fires, sudden depopulation of many corners of the Mycenaean world, this very sophisticated, stunning civilization and culture almost overnight vanishes from the records. We see this also happen down in Crete with the civilization that Sir Arthur Evans discovered, with the great palace of Knossos, the Minoan civilization. Vanishes.
- 7.42 The civilization on the island of Thera, which suffered a terrible earthquake in 1500 BC, the modern-day island of Santorini, almost overnight, probably because of the earthquake, the entire civilization just vanished. Thankfully, over the last few decades, some amazing remains have been found of this civilization in Santorini, which you can see partly at the National Archaeological Museum in Athens, but mainly now in some, in a fantastic site and museum based in Santorini.
- 7.43 So these civilizations vanish, and everything's lost. Literacy is lost. Trade is—trading partners vanish; trading networks disappear; palaces are lost; literature disappears, if there was any literature. And there's no more central command and control. The civilization is just fragmented into small villages and small groups. This is the period, you know, this carries on through the Dark Ages from, say, 1000 BC till about 800 BC, 750 BC.
- 7.44 This is the period when the oral tradition that is going to give us the Iliad and the Odyssey is beginning to emerge, but it's not scholars trying out their verses in elegant libraries in Athens. It's much more like a shepherd saying some lines to himself and thinking of the stories that his father told him all day, every day on the mountains, and then coming back, and around a primitive fire in a village, speaking poetry for eight hours, six hours. The Iliad takes about 24 hours to deliver orally, 16,000 lines.
- 7.45 And we think that bards, wandering bards, would do exactly this over three nights, four nights, five nights, to—I mean, there was no Netflix in those days. You had to make do with what you could. And if this mysterious man who had all these brilliant stories, endless stories crafted into beautiful poetry, with a musical instrument, we think that a lyre would accompany the Homeric hexameters of dum-dee-dee, dum-dee-dee, dum-dee-dee, and so this is a dark age, but also an age in which challenges are responded to. Homer is a very good example of that.
- 7.46 And city-states—small creative minorities that Toynbee describes start to set up various city-states around about 800 BC, 700 BC, 600 BC. Halfway through the 8th

century BC, some of the Greek city-states are already big enough to send out colonies. So, for example, Naples, that is originally a Greek colony from the 8th century BC, we call it Naples because it used—the Greek is Neapolis, *nea*, "new," *polis*, "city." So the "new city" is Naples. And they would literally just get a group of 50, 60, of your citizens, give them some money, wish them luck, promise them military support for a few years, but then, you know, it's up to you, time to grow up.

- 7.47** And so, we're having waves of this colonization happening already in the 700s BC. This would, for Toynbee, be the period of growth, a response to a challenge, and a time of accelerated civilizational growth. And what a growth. By the 5th century BC, so by the 400s BC, these little city-states are capable of holding off the mightiest empire ever known in the defeat of Darius at the Battle of Marathon in 490, and then at the defeat of his son Xerxes at the battles of Salamis in 480, and the Battle of Plataea the following year in 479.
- 7.48** And so, that's how fast they've grown. This is how successful they've been, partly through circumstance, through risk, through existential threat. The Greek city-states have finally got together and done something extraordinary that no other civilization was able to do—namely, to resist the might of the Persian Empire. Babylon, remember, Cyrus captures Babylon in 539, 538 BC. If they can defeat the whole of the Babylonian Empire, surely they can defeat this rabble of Europeans easily, and yet, they don't.
- 7.49** And so, this gives way to one of the most extraordinary golden ages in the history of humanity. As we move through the 5th century BC, specifically in Athens, elsewhere as well, but specifically in Athens. Here, in this short period, this short, short gasp, really, in the scope of human history, let's say— what year could we use? Let's say 470.
- 7.50** In 470, Aeschylus is beginning to perform his greatest plays. Socrates is born. Then Pericles comes along, undertakes one of the most impressive building projects ever witnessed in Europe, emerges with the Parthenon, the Propylaea, the Asclepeion, the Temple of Athena Nike, the Erechtheion. These are extraordinary buildings which are still there, a testament to Pericles' genius and his civic-mindedness. You've got the emergence of democracy for the first time in practice, and seeing that work itself out. The invention of theater, as I said, with Aeschylus and tragedy, the emergence for the first time ever in human history of satire and of comedy.
- 7.51** The birth of philosophy with Socrates and Plato. You've also got the first reflections on psychology, on rhetoric, on botany, and so on and so forth. You have the first historians. We've already talked at length about Herodotus and Thucydides. Herodotus is writing in the 440s, 430s BC. Thucydides is writing probably during the war that he himself is a general in, from the 420s onwards, probably up to 404 BC, and so on and so on. All of this is happening. All of this is happening over a 30- to 40-year span.
- 7.52** So these aren't just impressive contributions to theater; it's the invention of theater. Nobody had done theater before. This is not amazing contributions to satire and

political comedy; no, this is where comedy begins. Komoidia literally means, in Greek, the "village song." So the satires would start in the villages, in the country. The "goat song," the tragos-ode, the tragedy, so-called because the play was put on after a goat is sacrificed at the altar of Dionysus, because the performance of the play is itself part of a religious ritual, the Feast of the Dionysia, where for one week of the year, the Athenians go completely crazy and drink far too much, and their slaves are allowed to as well. They get it out of their system. This is the idea. And the tragedies, the goat songs, were part of that religious ritual, where people would put on masks and start playing different characters from the mythical past.

7.53 So this is an extraordinary period of growth, not really comparable, I think, to any other period in human history, possibly Renaissance Florence in the late 15th century, you might say, over that period; you could say Vienna, possibly, at the end of the 19th century, had a similar burst of intense cultural and philosophical, creative, and political creativity. So, this is an example, for Toynbee, of how a creative minority can have an extraordinary impact on a civilization.

7.54 And then, of course, as all of that's happening in Athens, you've got this incredibly destructive, exhausting war, the Peloponnesian War, which runs from 431—it's really three different wars—but runs from 431 BC to 404 BC. So, as they're doing all of this, producing these extraordinary plays, and buildings, and this extraordinary artwork, they are massacring each other, sometimes massacring masses of innocent people, putting, razing entire cities to the ground.

7.55 And then they go and sit and watch one of the most moving pieces of drama ever written—the extraordinary insight into the pain, particularly that the losers of wars feel. So Euripides writes a play called *The Trojan Women*, which is a tragedy of what happens to the women of Troy after Troy is sacked. Or *The Phoenician Women*, there's all of these. Or there's the *Hecuba*, which is the story of Priam's wife, the Queen of Troy, if you like, what it's like for her after the fall of Troy. And this is often—these plays are by Euripides. And Euripides was particularly sensitive to the cost of war.

7.56 But it's extraordinary to think that the very people who would be rowing the triremes and hitting the battlefields and doing the massacring would also take time out to go and watch the summer blockbuster. Troy captured; the women of Troy in a terrible state, look how awfully they've been treated. "Oh, yeah, brilliant. That doesn't remind me of anything." And so, it is extraordinary that great civilizational glory and blossoming can go hand in hand with this extraordinary disruption and dislocation and internal turmoil.

7.57 I can't remember, I think it was the literary critic George Steiner who remarked that there was a grove sacred to Goethe, very close to Buchenwald concentration camp. Goethe, for Germany, really, he is their Shakespeare and their Milton just rolled into one. He's an incredibly potent figure in German thought. It was partly because Goethe was from Weimar that Weimar was chosen— Weimar Germany, that was the idea for

the restoration of Germany after the First World War in the 1920s. It didn't obviously work out so well. But it's a stunning observation that this grove that was sacred to the greatest cultural genius that Germany ever produced, was also just a few feet from industrialized incarceration and mechanized slaughter.

- 7.58** So, Greece, Athens, collapses by 322 BC. It has been smashed by Alexander the Great. And it's been turned into a backwater, at best, a university town that posh Romans would sometimes want to send their children to, to pick up a little bit of Greek and a little bit of sophistication. But that's really all it was. It was just a university town until, really, the 19th century, after the Greek War of Independence is decided, is chosen as the capital.
- 7.59** One of the reasons Athens is so hideously ugly, compared to, say, Rome, is because most of it has been added from the 1880s onwards. It's grown very, very fast, but there isn't any core to it. It hasn't been a big city continuously for centuries in the way that, say, Rome or Paris or London has. And actually, ironically, the only old, structured part of Athens is the Ottoman part. It's the Turks built these very orderly, regular squares called Pláka. And so, actually, the nicest part of Athens now is—you shouldn't point this out to the local Greeks, but the nicest part of Athens is actually the Ottoman part. And so, you have this period of extraordinary decline from a civilizational peak. And says Toynbee, that's the pattern. That's the decline. The creative minority becomes the dominant minority, and then the civilization unravels.
- 7.60** So, these are two examples of what you might call mega-history or meta-history. These are attempts to almost do a rough science of civilizations, using explicitly scientific metaphors like organism, the growth of an organism, and the seasons. This is this idea that we are stitched in, we are stitched in somehow into the natural world.
- 7.61** It is quite naturalistic. Notice that, with neither Spengler nor Toynbee, at any point do we have references to Providence. Do we even have references to what Hegel thinks about, as, you know, freedom is our natural horizon? Nor do we really have Marxist predictions of the utopia to come. It's much more cyclical, but it's naturalistic. It's almost an attempt to come up with a very modern history that's completely consistent with the natural sciences and the dominance of the natural sciences. Yeah, civilizations are like an organism, a bit more complicated, but the same sequence, the same pattern and trajectory.
- 7.62** I want to turn now to, as we draw to a close, two figures who, I think, are two German figures who wrote very interesting and penetrating passages about the meaning of history. And the first of these is the German philosopher Martin Heidegger, who, 1889 to 1976, has a very long life. He's most famous for his work, *Being and Time*, *Sein und Zeit*, 1927. We don't need to go into a lot of depth on Heidegger, but I just wanted, in passing, to note that he has a very interesting way of thinking about human beings in relation to history.

- 7.63** One of his central ideas is the idea of *Geworfenheit*, or literally, "thrownness," a state of being thrown. Heidegger says we're all in this kind of condition. We didn't choose our starting point, didn't choose our families, didn't choose our cultures, didn't choose which team we're on, or what the score is, or anything like that. We are just thrown into the world, and this is the hand that we've been dealt, and this is the game we're going to have to play; this is the strategy we're going to have to adopt.
- 7.64** This is thrownness. You're starting from somewhere, you didn't choose it, but where you've been thrown, says Heidegger, is going to fundamentally affect how you're going to play the game, how you're going to interact with the world around you. These are going to shape what you can think. They go on the limits to what you can think that will be imposed by the world that you've been thrown into. You can't just jump outside this world, or it's very difficult to jump outside this world, because you're already in it. It's like, the person to ask what the water's like is not the goldfish. The goldfish is not going to know what the water's like.
- 7.65** And similarly, says Heidegger, you're not going to be able to just jump outside of the particular culture you're thrown in and say, "I don't believe in individual rights or human rights. It doesn't mean anything. What are you talking about? Why do you think all human beings have dignity? Why does reason matter? Why do you Enlightenment people keep talking about reason? Why does reason matter? I don't understand why it matters. Why is a revolution needed? I don't understand that either."
- 7.66** Heidegger says, yes, we do understand all of these things. Of course we do. We're thrown into them. We couldn't really operate without those things being true, or at least without those things being a feature of the world in which we find ourselves. And it's very hard to judge these things objectively because we're caught up in them, and it's very hard for us to imagine a counterfactual scenario or a parallel scenario.
- 7.67** But ancient Greek thought couldn't come up with the idea of a universal human right. It just couldn't. There were all these blocks in place. I mean, the ancient Greeks found it hard enough to think of themselves as ancient Greeks, saying, "I'm not Greek, I'm a Spartan. I'm not Greek, I'm a Macedonian first and foremost." Polis before nation, before country, let alone to have this idea that there were these rights or this dignity that extended beyond Greek speakers to barbarians, people who couldn't even speak Greek. "We're supposed to think of them as having some kind of dignity or worth? They can't even do their second declension nouns, weird accents. They didn't make any effort. They wear trousers. They drink wine the wrong way," and so on and so forth. These are all criticisms that Greeks made of barbarians. So, it wasn't part of what they could think about.
- 7.68** And Heidegger says we're all, as it were, locked into our *Gestalt*, to our "framing." We frame the world with our language and our thought in particular ways, ways that make certain principles available to consider and to think about, and others it just rules out completely.

- 7.69 Heidegger has some very famous essays, one famous essay in particular, *The Question Concerning Technology*, where he talks about the way in which technology is a way of enframing—is a way that we moderns enframe the world, structure the world, structure our view of the world. And he thinks that technology leads us to think of most of nature as a resource, what he calls a "standing reserve" that we can draw on when we need it. Because technology is so successful, technology is what we do, and then we need to feed, we need to feed the beast. We've got to feed whatever technology needs. And we need to think about the world through *techne*, through "technology," through what can be done to it through technology.
- 7.70 So, instead of thinking about woods, we think of timber. It's good timber. That would keep this factory going for 37 days. We don't look at a beautiful mountain stream. We think excellent hydroelectric potential. We could get a little mini hydroelectric power station going here. Think how much electricity we could get from this bit of water in the mountains, and so on. And so, Heidegger says we—the world becomes disenchanted and we start to impose and to start to structure reality. It's still a stream; it's just, we don't think of it as a beautiful stream. We think of it as electricity, or a source of electricity, source of money. It's very utilitarian and very practical.
- 7.71 This affects all sorts of features of our age as a historical period. There's no more mystery, there's no more reverence, there's no more sense of the sacred, says Heidegger, even though he is a complicated atheist. He's certainly not a card-carrying Christian from the 1920s onwards. But it is a lament that you might hear a theologian make, of a post-God landscape. But Heidegger is saying this himself.
- 7.72 He is a significant figure, of course. His own role, his own complicity in the Nazi period, was a source of extraordinary—was shameful, and not something he ever publicly repented of. He was appointed rector of Freiburg University in 1934, 1933-34, just as the Nazis are coming to power, and delivers a sinister speech. I think it's actually sometimes called the—is it the Führer speech? But anyway, it's an inaugural speech that he delivers as president of Freiburg University, in which he, broadly speaking, supports Nazi philosophy, or at least he pushes a particular view of the earth, of the soil, of the German people, which is convergent with, you might say, the principles of National Socialism. And clearly, he wouldn't have been allowed to be rector of Freiburg, if the Nazis had not expressly permitted it.
- 7.73 Shamefully, he bans his former teacher and PhD supervisor, Edmund Husserl, from the premises of the university. He was succeeding Husserl to— was an important successor to Husserl. He refuses him even to use the library. So, a very sinister stepping into national politics, we see with Heidegger, which is quite rare for a philosopher. And yet, he is still read today. In fact, there are entire cottage industry of scholarship on Heidegger, such is the depth of his thought and the honesty of his thought and transparency of his thought, despite this terrible black mark in his career.

- 7.74** So we've looked at three significant figures in the course of this lecture—Oswald Spengler, Arnold Toynbee, and finally, Martin Heidegger. We've seen this mood and notes of pessimism begin to creep into the story in the wake of cataclysmic events like the First World War.
- 7.75** What we're going to look at in the final lecture, a number of things we're going to look at, but in particular, we're going to look at ways in which some of the theological narratives that we thought we'd put behind us begin to re-emerge in critiques that a lot of these secular theories of history are, in fact, copycats of theological ways of understanding history in terms of providence. So we'll be looking at that in the first half of the next lecture, before we come into land and wrap up together some of the themes that we've been exploring in the entire series.

Lecture 8: Meaning Through History

At a glance — Meaning through history, the finale.

- 8.1 Welcome to the eighth and final lecture in the series, Philosophy of History. We're going to focus in this lecture on wrapping up some of those great historians of decline. We're going to be thinking about the way in which that narrative has been criticized and reshaped.
- 8.2 Then we're going to try and pull together the various strings and the various questions of this series with some contemporary case studies of how much history matters, how we narrate the past and how we narrate it, the means that we do use to narrate it, whether it's through history, texts, whether it's through rituals, through ceremonies, through certain habits, and so on and so forth, and trying to understand how to think about history in the contemporary context, how to navigate those difficult debates in the public square.
- 8.3 The first figure I want to look at in this lecture is not terribly well known, certainly not a household name, but a fascinating historiographer, a fascinating historian of history, a fascinating student of how history unfolds and how we project different labels onto the past. He's a German. He's called Karl Löwith, L-O, with a couple of dots on it, W-I-T-H, Löwith. He writes this wonderful book immediately after the Second World War, not a coincidence, in 1949. The book is called Meaning in History.
- 8.4 He looks at all the different secular myths, progressive myths of progress, and the way that history is told, particularly in figures like Hegel and Marx and Kant. He says that these modern progress narratives are really just a secularized version of the Christian doctrine of providence. This is a point that a number of scholars have made over the years. Carl Becker's famous book on The Heavenly City of Eighteenth-Century Philosophers, Carl Becker, for that book from the 1930s, very famous.
- 8.5 Löwith is saying, this is really just Christianity, except with God taken out of it, heaven taken away, the eschatology taken away, the end times theorizing taken away, but it's basically the same structure. History is moving in a particular direction. It's linear, it's heading to a good place, it's progressing. But of course, the content is completely different. So the framework has been borrowed by these secular histories of progress and myths of progress, but without the foundations, without the foundations in the actual narratives of these distinct religious traditions, in this case, the Christian tradition, about God's interaction with history and, in particular, how history will resolve itself, how it will end.
- 8.6 We've already seen in earlier lectures that this introduction of a creationist way of thinking about time and history, that is to say, creationist because it believes in a creator of some kind, opens up a very different way of thinking about time from what we might find elsewhere—we find in the Greeks, we find in the Romans, we find in the

Chinese, we find in the Indians, namely a more cyclical way of thinking about time. No, time has a beginning and it has a middle and an end, like a story, like any good story, beginning, middle, and an end.

- 8.7** That's the fundamental structure, fundamental way that Christianity structures time or structures its understanding of history, very similar to the Jewish and the Islamic way. But very different from what you find in China and India, where the much more common view is that time is either an illusion or it just operates in endless cycles, a kind of eternal return.
- 8.8** But what's so different about the Abrahamic model, of course, is, it's that direction. Everything has a purpose. Everything has a meaning, everything has a significance, and things are really only happening once. They might be foreshadowed in different ways, but the key events just happen once. We should have faith in the processes of history and providence, even when things look bad. This is something distinctive and new: that history is a meaningful story with a beginning, a middle, and an end.
- 8.9** And so, Löwith looks at this transition from Christian ways of thinking about history in terms of providence, to secular Enlightenment ways of thinking about history as progress, material progress, or emancipation of certain people-groups or whatever it might be. This is the new kind of redemption, the new kind of salvation. And Löwith says this starts very early. It starts, he thinks, with this famous heretic, Joachim of Fiore, who is condemned, I think, at the Fourth Lateran Council in 1215 AD. I think they're called the Joachimites.
- 8.10** So Joachim of Fiore had this philosophy, or this theology of history, where you had the Age of the Father, the Age of the Son, and now the Age of the Holy Spirit. Now you might think, what's wrong with that? It's very religious, very trinitarian, it's very theological. What's wrong with that? He said that the age of the Father is the age of the Old Testament. The age of the Son is the age of the New Testament. The age of the Spirit is the age of— who wants to write a testament? Each age is higher than the previous one. It's progress is, as it were, written into history, into now, not the life beyond, that you actually have the Trinity unfolding itself in actual history, in concrete history.
- 8.11** You can see why he got into trouble. The age of the Spirit is an age of spiritual perfection, where we can overcome all of our sins. It's higher than the age of the Son. It's higher than Jesus. It's higher than the New Testament. You do get a lot of these groups who see themselves as so committed to the life and freedom of the spirit. They've been liberated even from the need to consult scripture or bishops or priests or anything. There's a kind of anarchic spirit to the Holy Spirit, or at least to movements that proclaim themselves to be devoted to the Holy Spirit, because the Spirit blows where it wills, and there's no obvious way of contradicting it or anticipating it and so on and so forth.

- 8.12** But the point is, this is happening within history. That was what was problematic about Joachim of Fiore's view. He was folding theology into the processes of history. Perfection is happening in history, not beyond it, which is the standard Christian view.
- 8.13** Löwith goes on and says that we see it already in the Middle Ages, but we see it, of course, in the Enlightenment. We see it with people like Kant. We see it, particularly, with Hegel. Hegel, instead of God, has this Geist, "Absolute Spirit," revealing itself. Do you remember, through the jigsaw pieces, and through the legibility, the intelligibility of the jigsaw as the last piece is slotted in? Instead of providence, we have a necessity, a dialectical necessity, which is the driving force, the engine room of history. Instead of the Kingdom of God, you've got this rational state where everybody is free and free to exercise their reason, and operating within a world of rational institutions and a rational state, rational society.
- 8.14** But Löwith says, you've got the same pattern here. Just as with Christianity, you've got creation, fall, redemption, and finally, judgment and the end times, in Hegel, you're in a state of captivity, like the slave. You begin to win partial freedom as the master becomes more dependent on you. You attain universal freedom, as Hegel thought, in 1789; the French were kicking it off. Then you have this state of the Absolute Spirit working through history, coming to be conscious of itself in Hegel's very grand terms. But you've still got that similar sequence. It's just a secular script; it's a secular version of it.
- 8.15** And similarly with Marx as Löwith, you can see, instead of sin, he thinks of the alienation of the worker from the fruit of his labor—that's the terrible thing, that's the terrible injustice. Instead of redemption, Marx is thinking about revolution, a violent revolution if necessary, preferably, in Lenin's case. Instead of the kingdom of God, you've got this communist paradise that's awaiting you. But there's this idea, it's still heaven at the end; it's just a different kind of heaven, and you don't have to wait till you die, even better. You can have whatever you want.
- 8.16** But it's still, Löwith says, it's still similar, very similar. Instead of the faithful, the body of Christ, you might say, you've got the proletariat, the working classes. These are the classes that are held up as uniquely dignified and uniquely special. You see this time and time again, says Löwith. But the trouble is, he insists, you can't just take the framework without the foundations. You can't just take the theological narrative, keep the structure and remove God, or remove God as an explanatory ingredient in that account.
- 8.17** Either Christian eschatology, the Christian theories about the end times, is true or it's not. It's either true or it's not. If it's true, then God exists, and there is something like providence, and that's the way things are. If God is not involved at all in the processes of history, then why on earth assume that history is going to take the course of the mistaken, the false theological account? There's no God. It was all fake all along. So, why take bits of it and say, there was a redemption-style moment, an Exodus-style

moment? He'd say that if you don't believe any of this stuff, then stop bringing it into your theories of how human beings, how human history works.

- 8.18** Löwith, he's writing in 1949, so he sees how implausible it is that these narratives have taken on what is, fundamentally, an optimistic theology of history. It all works out in the end. Julian of Norwich, as she famously says, "All shall be well, all manner of things shall be well." There's a strong note of hope and optimism in Christian eschatology.
- 8.19** All of that gets blown away, really, literally, by both the First World War and the Second World War, by the gulags, by the Holodomor, by all of the horrors perpetrated on human beings in the first half of the 20th century, which left no doubt that this optimistic, this idea that it was some secular paradise or secular hope lying at the end of history made that a laughable thing to hope for or to be aiming at. And so, history is, in a way, in a state of turmoil here, but the progressive narrative somehow seemed completely implausible. It's, really, only the apocalyptic dystopian ones that seem to ring true.
- 8.20** Indeed, we see in the wake of the Second World War, in the '40s, '50s, and '60s, an extraordinary profusion of dystopian novels, dystopian plays, dystopian films, much more than we get of the notes of optimism in a previous phase of popular culture. So these are the ideas that Löwith puts forward, and that leaves us with the thought of, well, what are the options?
- 8.21** As we come to the end of this series, what are the options? As progress seems to be less certain, less predictable, we can rightly ask: What is there to hope for in history? How can we structure history? One response is to—and it's implicit in what Löwith says—is to recover, unapologetically, an idea that history is somehow rooted in the transcendent purposes of an all-powerful, all-knowing, all-loving being, and to recover certain theological ways of thinking about history or thinking about human nature in particular, and the way that human nature can intersect with how we understand history to operate.
- 8.22** I mean, one of the reasons that Thucydides says that his history is a "ktema es to aiei," "a possession for all time," one of the reasons he explicitly gives is because human nature doesn't change very much. Human nature is what it is, really, from period to period. We are a species capable of producing a Mother Teresa, and we're a species capable of producing a Jeffrey Dahmer, a serial killer. That is just part of what it is to be a human being. We get better in some respects, perhaps; we get worse in other respects. There is no ramp that is leading human beings towards a state of complete moral perfection.
- 8.23** That in itself, Thucydides has that insight, but it's obviously a central commitment in Christian doctrine, certainly for the Western Latin half of Christianity, perhaps not so much for the Orthodox, but this idea of original sin, that you're never going to be able to—the problem with human beings is not just external forces or scarcity. There's

something that, as Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn says in a very famous passage—he survived the Gulag Archipelago, but comes with a warning to the West—he says that it's too easy to think that the line between good and evil runs across boundaries between, say, NATO and the Warsaw Pact.

- 8.24** No, he says, the line between good and evil runs right through every single human heart. You in the West are just as vulnerable to a civilizational collapse as the Soviet Union is. You've got different problems and different weaknesses, but you have to return to God. You have to return to some kind of investing history and human beings with some transcendent meaning. Solzhenitsyn expressly says this. You've had a few others that press this line: John Paul II, certainly, Benedict XVI.
- 8.25** Pope Benedict XVI was a fierce critic of the dictatorship of relativism, so the idea that you could offer any kind of claim and assert that it's true, just in virtue of the fact that you've made it. Certainly, some philosophies of history are like this. "That's your history. This is our history." This is the history of the same place, the same nation, but we're claiming ours is right and yours is wrong. Benedict calls this the "dictatorship of relativism." This is a dictatorship, and we have to—when transcendence is abandoned, then all bets are off.
- 8.26** For Benedict, obviously, God is capital-T truth. God is what unifies all truths as true. And Benedict says, once you've got rid of that, then it's just power. Whoever can assert most convincingly or most forcefully some truth and protect it just as his own, that's inevitable, says Benedict. Similar criticisms from figures like G. K. Chesterton, C. S. Lewis, T. S. Eliot, and so on and so forth. All of them effectively say that you need God not necessarily to be able to predict the future or to understand exactly how human history works, but because morality is something we can't escape. Meaning is something we're always going to need. There's always going to be a need to ground our intuitions about human dignity.
- 8.27** For that, it's very hard to turn to the political religions of the 20th century, which can't make any sense of those ideas of human dignity and meaning and morality, or at least perverts them terribly. And so, the habit of secular political religions taking the framework of Christianity without the foundations is disastrous. And Löwith argues, the only way to come back and recover this is to return to transcendence. So that's one option, one strategy.
- 8.28** Another is simply to accept, cheerfully accept, that history is meaningless. There's no purpose to it. There's no rhyme or reason beyond what we project onto it, and no cosmic meaning. We create our own values, our own stories, and we're open about it. We're honest about the groundlessness. God is dead. We have killed him. Morality is not looking too well either. And so, it's up to us to craft our own values. This is the existentialist line of people like Camus and Sartre. We can embrace the absurd, even if—we can embrace the meaninglessness. We can still do fun plays and do crazy art and write crazy novels, absurdist novels that delight in the absurd.

- 8.29** So these are two very different—I mean, these are opposing responses, you might say. In the middle might be a more modest, liberal way of thinking about things, where we don't know if God exists or not. We haven't got any transcendent guarantee, particularly, but maybe we could pretend he exists, and work for justice, and try and to conduct ourselves that we can give a good account of ourselves at the end of our lives.
- 8.30** This is The New York Times columnist, David Brooks, talks about the difference between obituary virtues and resume virtues. Your obituary is going to sound—how different will your obituary sound from your resume, from your CV? We can work for our obituary virtues without expecting any kind of cosmic thank you at the end or a special seat in the heavenly realm. There may be no grand laws of history. We can be agnostic about that. We're liberals, after all. We can—no grand laws of history, no historicism, but maybe we can work to make things a little bit better here and there.
- 8.31** And there's maybe not an ultimate meaning. We've got no real idea why we're here, why one thing happens after another, what the patterns are, how we predict things. But we've got enough. We've got enough meaning. Life's okay in liberal democracies, and so it's pretty much OK elsewhere as well. We can keep on going, keep on strolling through history without a care in the world, because we've got enough meaning, even if we haven't got ultimate meaning. And so, figures here might be Karl Popper, Isaiah Berlin, who we looked at in previous lectures, and that's certainly a plausible third option—the more transcendent religious response, the more nihilistic, absurdist one, and then a middle-of-the-road liberal modesty.
- 8.32** But tying all of these thinkers together is a sense that human beings, human civilization, has reached an end stage, you might say. Whether it's the beginning of a decline, whether it's what's happening immediately before a dramatic transition, there is a sense that the 20th century marked an end and a new beginning to human civilization. There's a sense even now that the 21st century is going to look very different from the 20th. Apart from anything else, Europe will have run out of natural resources and will be so poor that it won't be worth fighting a world war in Europe. It's just a complete waste of time.
- 8.33** And so, we're starting to think in these very grand, larger meta-historical terms, not just in terms of the history of our particular countries, but the history of the West, we might even say. It's a very contentious concept, the West. It's only been around about 100 years. Most of the people who've lived through the West do not think of themselves as being in the West. But we are starting to talk and think about that now, not least when that was begun, I think, or at least catalyzed, by Oswald Spengler in his great *Decline of the West*, from 1918 to 1922.
- 8.34** There are some other decline theorists, some extremely obscure ones, which I wanted to bring to your attention, partly because of the novelty, the originality. You won't have heard of these figures before, but they both represent very interesting meta-historians and, basically, quite pessimistic ones, but rigorous and interesting in their own way.

The first is very obscure, not really a historian in many ways. He was an officer, a brilliant British general, Sir John Glubb. He wrote a tiny little book, 1978, *The Fate of Empires and the Search for Survival*.

- 8.35** He is a man who witnesses Britain's imperial decline. He witnesses the rise of Arab nationalism in the Middle East, particularly in the interwar period. But he's in charge of —he commands the Arab Legion in Jordan from 1939 to 1956. This is a fascinating, very short book, but he thinks he can see certain patterns in the decline and fall of certain civilizations, or of many civilizations. He says empires have a consistent life span of about 10 generations, about 250 years, he says, and they pass through certain distinct stages. He thinks there are basically six. And these patterns repeat across all different civilizations.
- 8.36** So, first of all, he says, you've got the age of the pioneers, the age of the pioneers, conquest, expansion, hardship. Remember Toynbee? Remember Toynbee's account of the influence of creative minorities responding to chaos, the chaos of the Dark Ages, the emergence of the Greek city-states? These leaders in this phase are bold, they take risks, they're visionary. And the explorers, the pioneers, give way to the age of conquests. Military dominance is asserted.
- 8.37** And think here of the transition from the Roman Republic to the Roman Empire. The Roman Republic, from 264 to, let's say, 31 BC, is a place in constant exploration, constant domination, gradually building up its power base around the Mediterranean, expanding fast. Then, really, with Augustus, when Augustus comes along in 31 BC, you have the beginnings of the Principate, the beginning of the Roman imperial dynasty. There it starts to enter into the imperial stage, the age of conquests.
- 8.38** Then, Glubb says, then you've got the age of commerce. As the empire settles down and its different subject-people start to learn to do business with each other, you have a burst of the age of commerce. That leads to extraordinary affluence. Living standards are very high. Comfort then comes in and replaces ambition. And Glubb says, this is where the rot begins. This is where the rot begins. Excessive wealth— empires, civilizations become defensive rather than expansive, trying to hold on to the plenty they've got, because they just don't really need anymore.
- 8.39** And finally, in the final two stages, after this, you've got the age of intellect. This is when the eggheads come along, all the university types come along, and public intellectuals; that's when things are getting really bad. That's when you know you're in trouble as a civilization. You're in the penultimate stage. You're in the departure lounge when eggheads like me come along. Beware of geeks bearing gifts.
- 8.40** What you have now is a stage of self-criticism, because you start letting the philosophers and the intellectuals write their awkward plays and their late-night comedy shows and witty novels and satirical films. And civilization is no longer at ease with itself. We did all these great things, yes, but what about all the bad things? What

about them? Think of what we did and our forefathers did, how do we atone for it? This is the effect of the geek's gifts.

- 8.41** What does it all matter, anyway? This is a lot of the philosophers of the 20th century, like Sartre himself saying, "What does it all matter, anyway? Just live your own life, make sure it's authentic, and who cares if it's also immoral?" Because what's morality, anyway, except a construct of the property-owning classes to force you to behave in particular ways? You get these arguments, this approach, this skepticism towards civilizational achievement.
- 8.42** This is Glubb's six-part theory. He's not a professional historian. One's got to treat his work with some caution. Mind you, I suppose Spengler and Toynbee weren't really, either, in their own way. But it's not a self-confident, self-consciously academic work. But this is a very interesting perceptive mind who'd been on the ground, who'd witnessed a very important phase in the twilight of the British Empire and the rise of Arab Nationalism, as I said. He's not too far off with his 250-year estimate of the average shelf life of a civilization and a great empire.
- 8.43** You think of Assyria, which is very old, I mean, very old, mid-9th century BC to 612. It gets finally defeated in 612 AD. That's 247 years. The Persian Empire from 538, that's when Cyrus defeats N, defeats, captures Babylon, that's 538, up to when Alexander the Great smashes it, 330 BC, 208 years. Greece, or at least Macedonian Greece, Alexander's Greece, 331 to 100 is 231 years. The Roman Republic, if you measure that, 260 to 27 BC, that's 207 years. Arab Empire, 246 years. The Mamluks in Egypt, 267 years. Ottoman Empire, exactly 250 years. Spain, exactly 250 years, rounding out the beginnings and the end dates a little bit there. Romanov Russia, 1682 to 1916, 234 years. And Britain, if you measure the British Empire, quite plausibly from 1700 to 1950, 250 years.
- 8.44** You might ask: When does the Pax Americana come to an end? What's 250 years in the case of America? What's 1776 plus 250? Well, it turns out, at the time of recording, about six months away. So, gather your rosebuds while you may, and sit tight and hope that the Glubb's law, 250-year law for great civilizations and empires, doesn't apply to the United States of America.
- 8.45** So it's an interesting, obviously very speculative theory, but it's a way of doing history about history, meta-history, trying to think in much, much broader terms about human development. You can say it is the West in decline, according to Glubb's indicators. You could see Glubb, in 1978, thought that both Britain and America did exhibit all of the signs of that phase five and phase six of acute self-criticism and a decadence, a pessimism, a defensiveness, a stress on material wealth as the only kind of real value, the weakening of religion, and so on and so forth, disconnected elites, and elites that prefer decadence to duty.

- 8.46 There are some insights here which can help us. Anchored in this idea that human nature stays the same pretty much no matter what, perhaps it's more plausible to think that history is more likely to move in cycles than to move in a straight arc towards justice. Because people aren't becoming more just. We might be becoming more educated.
- 8.47 We're not obviously becoming a more moral civilization, or at least certainly, if you take the last 200-250 years, you can say it's a mixed record, mixed record, very mixed, the report card. Lots of Ds and Es and unmarkable, and a few A-pluses and Bs here and there, but it's not obvious that we're just straight-A humans now, just because some time has passed and we've invented a few amazing things and written some amazing plays and so on and so forth.
- 8.48 My second obscure figure I wanted to draw your attention to is a guy called J. D. Unwin. He's a secular, I suppose he's an anthropologist. Anthropology wasn't really a discipline back then. It was only, really, very much a nascent discipline. But he did this huge comparative study of different societies, primitive societies, known civilizations. He dies very young, dies at the age of 41. His work has been almost completely forgotten.
- 8.49 In fact, I couldn't even find a copy of his work when I started getting interested in him 15, 20 years ago. I found one, old PDF online. I don't think it's been republished, but more people are reading it now. The work is called *Sex and Culture*, 1934, *Sex and Culture*. He has got this fascinating theory, again, that is tied to, as it were, this idea that human nature doesn't change, and how a particular facet of human nature, namely sex and sexuality, has a connection to the civilizational success and flourishing of the people that he's considering.
- 8.50 There is a relationship between this ordinary human disposition, instead of human desires that are basically constant, and civilizational strength and resilience and flourishing. What he argues is that there's this direct relationship between restraint, between asceticism, between very solid guardrails around, as it were, sites of human sexuality in culture and social mores, on the one hand, and on the other hand, the cultural energy of a civilization.
- 8.51 It's very strange, maybe an unusual link to draw, but he says that this is—very strict rules around sexuality and marriage and so on and so forth lead to high levels of cultural energy, high social energy, and cultural achievement. Whereas on the other hand, a license, an intense focus on sexual freedom, sexual liberation, he says, goes hand in hand with a civilizational exhaustion and collapse.
- 8.52 How on earth do you go about measuring this? He does it very carefully. He looks at all those societies with very strict sexual codes. Prenuptial chastity is enforced. Absolute monogamy is enforced. No divorce. Adultery is stigmatized. He says that these are the societies that are most expansive, that are most high-energy, there's most cultural

creativity. And then he thinks then, this is when relaxation sets in, the sexual freedom begins.

- 8.53** First of all, you witness a very positive, artistic, cultural flowering of the arts and philosophy and literature and so on, because society is still riding high on the successes of its previous, more hardened, ascetic, more self-consciously moral civilizational phase. And so, there's a relatively long period that Unwin thinks is where we're running on the gas that the previous driver had put in, but we've got no way of actually putting in gas of our own. And so, for a time, it all seems fantastic.
- 8.54** So, think here, for example, of the Bloomsbury group in London at the turn of the 19th, 20th century. The Bloomsbury group, who have you got? You've got Virginia and Leonard Woolf. You've got figures like Bertrand Russell, T. S. Eliot is at the edges of it, as well. John Maynard Keynes is part of it. You see philosophers, economists, literary types. Lytton Strachey, very famous, very famously. The Bloomsbury group is a group of aesthetes, pretty snobbish, but self-consciously modern, self-consciously secular, self-consciously bohemian. It's a phase in the emergence of modernism in art and in poetry.
- 8.55** It's self-consciously critical, critical of empire, critical of nationalism and so on and so forth. It is both—it seems like a positive. It is a flowering of culture and ideas in many ways, but it's also advocating, in the case of the Bloomsbury group—a lot of them slept with each other. They were very promiscuous in terms of sexual mores, were very relaxed, and they could just about get away with it, because these were luxury beliefs that, as with luxury goods, they may be expensive because living them out is basically—if you want to live them out and deal with a bill at the end, then you've got to be in a particular level of society.
- 8.56** They were able to cope with it to some extent. This is Unwin's theory. He thinks that you've got this idea of sexual restraint and moralizing channels energy into social and cultural pursuits. Marriage is an extremely powerful institution. It's got a very high investment. It allows men and women to, as it were, fulfill their vocations to working, to creating, to building in different ways. Whereas the sexual revolution approach, the sexual freedom approach, dissolves all of that, undermines those nation-building institutions that is the family, according to Unwin.
- 8.57** And sexual freedom also, in undermining families and dissolving it or seeing that as just one option among many, this leads to a gradual weakening of social cohesion. And Unwin, when you read him, you can listen to these ideas and think, "Gosh, he must have been some Calvinist preacher or some extreme Catholic or something." No, not at all. He's completely secular. He's just observing and saying, "All these different 80 primitive societies and six civilizations that I've studied at great length, this does seem to be what—you can track how these different codes, the hold that these different codes have on their respective societies, and you can measure quite accurately how they do, what happens, whether they flourish or whether they don't."

- 8.58** Unwin thinks that this is just true of the six civilizations that he looks at. He says, you look at the Sumerians, they're very strict to begin with; later it relaxes, and then they collapse. Same with the Babylonians. He thinks the same happens with the Greeks: very classical strictness to start with, then Hellenistic freedom, and then they're conquered by Rome. They don't have to worry about anything else after that.
- 8.59** Rome, republican virtue, people like Cato and Marius and fine upstanding republican figures, to a phase of imperial decadence, the horrors of the court of Caligula or Tiberius or Nero or Domitian, and then eventual fall. Anglo-Saxons, you might say America, there's Puritan restraint with the Mayflower and the early settler generations, and then you might say even Victorian restraint, certainly the case in Britain. Then that gives way to a relaxation of these different codes in the modern period.
- 8.60** This is what he claims. Any human society is free to choose either to display great energy or to enjoy sexual freedom. The evidence is that it cannot do both for more than one generation. It cannot do both for more than one generation. So he's not moralizing there. He's just saying, "Based on my observations, this is the trade-off." Take it either way. He himself was personally agnostic about which choice was better. That's the choice. You could only fool yourself that you don't have to make the choice for one generation.
- 8.61** Certainly a provocative thesis, but it does, I think, resonate. This was written in 1934—so 70, 80, 90 years on, family breakdown, atomization, loneliness, declining fertility rates all around the world, the rise of fatherlessness, broken homes, and so on and so forth. He predicted these things. He did say that this is how civilization begins to dissolve itself, not from external shocks, but from internal dynamics and the loss of a certain internal spirit of confidence that all civilizations on the up have shown.
- 8.62** What displays your confidence more, after all, than making lots of future citizens, ensuring to conquer the world for you? There's always been high fertility rates when civilizations are on the up like that. Declining fertility rates suggest less confidence about the future, perhaps more inward-looking, perhaps thinking more simply about not in generational terms, but not building for the future, but simply operating within the cycle of one's own life, or perhaps one's very immediate dependence. This is Unwin's extraordinary claim. You can have sex or you can have Shakespeare. You can't have both. This is the idea.
- 8.63** As we come into land in this lecture and with the series more generally, I wanted to reflect for a moment on not just what stories we can tell about history and the theories we can attach to how history is structured, but more practically, how it is that societies go about remembering, building their history, and how also they go about forgetting, erasing their history. Whether you're creating your history or erasing your history—if you're erasing your history, you're saying something about your history. You don't like it, you don't want it, you want to pretend that it never happened, and that happens a lot.

- 8.64** But this shows us how important history is to the present day, how a society understands itself. Here, a great writer who died in 2019, sadly, but he's a contemporary historian and theorist called Paul Connerton, C-O-N-N-E-R-T-O-N, wonderful book, 1989, *How Societies Remember*. How Societies Remember. Connerton's point is that societies don't just remember by reading lots of history books when they're kids and just learning the dates of the kings and queens. No, memory is not just cognitive, but it's embodied and it's ritualized; it's social.
- 8.65** This is how we remember: through ceremonies, through marking the calendar in particular ways, through wearing little gadgets. In Britain, round about Remembrance Sunday, or round about the 11th of November, everybody wears, or most people will wear, a poppy for a week, 10 days, a couple of weeks; it's fairly simple. You wouldn't be —pretty much everybody does it. You wouldn't remark on it if somebody was wearing a poppy at that time of year. It's just a small little gesture, a token, a symbol, where we reflect on one particular conflict, the First World War, and the extraordinary sacrifice that Britain made in that war, but about war more generally, and veterans, and so on.
- 8.66** That's a way in which a society at scale, a highly complex society that is vast—I mean, not as vast as America—but as 65 million people come together, or a good chunk of them will come together, for two minutes of silence at 11 o'clock on the 11th day of the 11th month. That's a very important ritual, a ritual that everybody can take part in, no matter what their religious commitments might be or whether or not they arrived five minutes ago, as is the case with increasingly many people in Britain.
- 8.67** In principle, you can take up the history of your adoptive country; at least, there have to be mechanisms for that, but it's the history of your country that needs to be taught or given a priority of some sort. And what it is to then take part in that as a newcomer is your willingness to take part in it. There's nothing that prevents you from taking part in it, nothing in your religion that prevents you, nothing in your ethnicity, nothing in your cultural background. But that would be—but it's important that everybody can participate in it.
- 8.68** Connerton says these are very important, these ceremonies and these rituals, whether it's July the Fourth in America, whether it's Bastille Day, 14th of July, "quatorze juillet," in France, whether it's St. George's Day, or Patron Saint's Day, as it is in the case in England, and so on and so forth. Or Trafalgar Day was celebrated often over the course of the 19th century, Nelson's great victory over Napoleon, and really, the end of Napoleon's ambitions against Britain.
- 8.69** This isn't just remembering the past, but it's almost trying to reenact the past. It's almost trying to relive it or to make the past present. It creates a kind of continuity and an identity and a solidarity. And that's why history is important. If we look at some of the history wars that have been dominating the public square for the last five years or so, it's fascinating to see how different narratives are developed, both in America and in Britain.

- 8.70** There are claims in America, particularly coming from The New York Times, people writing for the New York Times, that the true founding of America was not 1776, but in fact, 1619, when it's alleged that the first enslaved Africans arrived in Virginia, that this is the true founding. So obviously, that's got a very clear moralistic point to it, because the argument is that slavery is somehow fundamental to American identity, somehow distinctive to American identity, when, in 1619, almost no civilization, almost no nation that was capable of generating and sustaining a slave industry didn't. Most civilizations we know of engaged at an industrial scale in slavery.
- 8.71** Then the claim is that the American Revolution, as Brits like to call it, or the War of Independence, as Americans like to call it, the whole point of the revolution was to preserve slavery. Of course, the whole point of the Civil War on one side is to preserve slavery. So a big political battle breaks out, Republican senators weighing in, saying we should defund schools that take this stuff seriously. President Trump, from the first administration, announced the 1776 Commission, directed by the brilliant Larry Arnn, another lecturer at Peterson Academy, of course, and president of Hillsdale College in Michigan.
- 8.72** The task of this group of historians, the 1776 project, was to try to respond to some of these charges made by the 1619 Project, to develop a counter-narrative that celebrated the founding, but not uncritically; that was open to things that have gone wrong, or things that have been done wrong, or things that have been mythologized. But broadly speaking, this is a celebration of our history because it's ours. All the good bits and the bad bits, it's ours. It's what makes us "we." It's what makes it possible to use the first person plural.
- 8.73** I don't think President Trump said that in so many words, but I think this was the spirit behind the executive order founding the 1776 Commission, which, sadly, because it was right at the end of his administration, really never saw the light of day, although I think Dr. Arne did produce a book out of it, which was an important book, important treatment. So it shows that these history wars went right up to the Oval Office, I mean, right up to a presidential executive order.
- 8.74** These are the fights that are happening today, in schools today, on both sides of the Atlantic. How is this going to be taught? We can't teach the history, we can't teach the history of the nation, if we've decided already whether we think it's a good thing or a bad thing. In any case, history should always be trying to educate us into the sufferings of the victims. And so, the history of America just is the history of America's victims. The history of Britain just is the history of the many and various people Britain has been nasty to in the last 1,200 years.
- 8.75** And that's it. That's all there is to be said, that history is a kind of exercise in self-flagellation. How terrible are we? In order for this much more revolutionary "they," as it were, to sweep through. It's very reductive, just as jingoistic, overly patriotic films or books or portrayals of a country can ring hollow, very difficult to watch, propaganda;

similarly, reverse propaganda is just as tedious because it's not art. It's just this one political message that is being pushed, that all America is—the only way to understand America is through the history of persecution of ethnic minorities or of slavery, and to ignore all the progress, including abolition, that is also a part of the national history.

- 8.76** So, great contestations over this fundamental question with which we began the series — can history have a meaning? Can it have a meaning in the wake of the collapse of all these grand narratives, these big-picture accounts of whether it's providence, whether it's progress, whether it's Hegel's reason, whether it's Marx's class struggle? We still need, as human beings, anchoring, a mooring, an identity, an orientation, a belonging.
- 8.77** We're still asking the question: Who are we? Where are we from? Where are we going? What does it all matter? Is this person a part of my history? Is that person not part of my history? Does it matter? Could he join my history if he wanted to? And so on and so forth. This is not a question that a historian, as a historian, can answer. Maybe Heidegger is right, that we're simply thrown into history and we can no more jump outside of it and make an assessment, an objective assessment of it than we can simply jump out of our skin and take a look at what we look like from a third-party point of view.
- 8.78** So history matters if, for no other reason, that we are historical beings. What it is to be a human being is to be in history, not just as an observer, but as caught up in the whole historical process. And in the end, it will simply be a matter of philosophy, perhaps of taste, of intuition, how we invest history with meaning, indeed, whether we invest it with meaning at all. But I hope that, in the course of these lectures, you've got a better sense than before of all the different options available to you; and why how we understand history, how we understand our past, is so fundamental to how we can shape our present and what we can hope for in the future. Thank you for listening.
- 8.79** I'm curious if there is anyone that is considering a third potential besides the linear or the cyclical. I'm imagining an inclined plane moving upward through cycles. Because I do believe that we are better than we were back in the beginning when we were more beastly to each other, it seems. Is that something that anyone has talked about? Are you aware of any?
- 8.80** Yes, that's a good way of thinking about it. I think there are certainly improvements, the technological improvements, and there are moral improvements as well. There's no doubt about that. A lot of those moral improvements are a lot easier to enforce in this day and age than was the case back in the 13th or 14th century. So we can get away with less now, is also true.
- 8.81** I think your idea is probably something quite close to Joachim of Fiore. Hopefully not too close because he's condemned as a heretic, but you remember the Age of the Father, the Age of the Son, and then the Age of the Spirit, Old Testament, New Testament, my Testament? That is this idea that history is going in a particular

direction, but it's like a step. There was the Old Testament, now we've got the much nicer, more cuddly New Testament, and then the Age of the Spirit, where it's just freedom. You do get ideas like that.

8.82 Now, somebody like Tolkien would say, "Oh, no. For me, just the philosophy of history is, I'm a Catholic, and the philosophy of history is just one long series of defeats with a final crashing ultimate victory at the end." There's no going up and up. It's just pretty terrible all the way to the end, but the end is fantastic.